

Hamlet

William Shakespeare · 1603

Standard Ebooks edition (modern text drawing on the 1604–05 Second Quarto and the 1623 First Folio)

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

21 scene lessons plus 2 seminar day(s), a test day and an essay day: 25 class days of 90 minutes, 5 a week (block schedule), 5 weeks
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–21), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Hamlet survives in three early texts: the First Quarto (1603), the Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623). The reading text is the Standard Ebooks edition, a conflated modern text divided into the conventional 20 scenes plus the cast list. The year shown is the first printing; the play was probably written about 1599–1601. Cite act, scene and line from this edition.

Content note for teachers: Murder, a ghost, feigned and real madness, suicidal thoughts ('To be, or not to be'), Ophelia's possible suicide, sexual wordplay, and multiple on-stage deaths; Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia and Gertrude deserves critical discussion. See the scene notes and the safe-messaging script.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Scaffolded-support track (grade-9 floor): students work from teacher-selected passages with scaffolds, sentence starters and partial-credit probes. **Weeks:** 5. **Class days:** 25 × 90 minutes (21 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Hamlet suggest about revenge and justice?
- What does Hamlet suggest about action and delay?
- What does Hamlet suggest about appearance and reality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about death and mortality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about corruption and the state?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the play in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.

- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the scene quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily scene quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-book test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Scene lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Dramatis Personae (20-minute preview) and Act I, Scene I Act I, Scene II Act I, Scene III Act I, Scene IV	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*revenge and justice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
2	Act I, Scene V *Socratic seminar on revenge and justice* Act II, Scene I Act II, Scene II Act III, Scene I	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*action and delay* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on revenge and justice • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
3	Act III, Scene II Act III, Scene III Act III, Scene IV Act IV, Scene I Act IV, Scene II (20-minute preview) and Act IV, Scene III	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*appearance and reality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
4	Act IV, Scene IV Act IV, Scene V *Socratic seminar on action and delay* Act IV, Scene VI Act IV, Scene VII	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*death and mortality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on action and delay • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
5	Act V, Scene I Act V, Scene II *Whole-book test (90 minutes)*	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*corruption and the state* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do,	Whole-book test and final essay

	Final paper writing workshop (drafting in class; finish the draft as homework) *Final paper: peer review, revision and submission*		discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Whole-book test (90 minutes) • Final paper writing workshop (drafting in class; finish the draft as homework) • Final paper: peer review, revision and submission • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Hamlet

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about William Shakespeare's life or times connects to revenge and justice in “Hamlet”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (revenge and justice, action and delay, appearance and reality).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623).

Historical and cultural context

Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir.

Publication and reception, then and now

Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play.

Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation.

Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's

(1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play.

Main themes

- revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both?
- action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance?
- appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays.
- death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us.
- corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Why it matters

Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

Spoilers · teacher only

The Ghost says Claudius murdered him and demands revenge. Hamlet feigns madness, rejects Ophelia, and stages a play (The Mousetrap) that confirms Claudius's guilt. He spares Claudius at prayer, then kills Polonius, hidden behind a curtain, by mistake. Claudius sends Hamlet to England to be executed; Hamlet escapes, sending Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths. Ophelia goes mad and drowns. Laertes returns for revenge, and Claudius plots a rigged fencing match with a poisoned blade and poisoned wine. Gertrude drinks the poison; Laertes and Hamlet are both wounded with the poisoned blade; Hamlet kills Claudius and dies in Horatio's arms. Fortinbras of Norway takes the throne.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.*
> **Prompt:** Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

Key literary terms for the unit.

revenge tragedy (a play driven by a quest for vengeance, ending in many deaths); soliloquy (a speech alone revealing thoughts); aside; foil (a character who highlights another by contrast: Laertes and Fortinbras for Hamlet); feigned madness (pretended insanity, an "antic disposition"); play within a play; regicide (killing a king).

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).

About the author. William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623). The world of the book. Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir. Publication and reception. Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play. Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation. Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's (1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" slowly and put it in my own words: After the Ghost appears and beckons Hamlet away, the guard Marcellus says that something is rotten in the state of Denmark. Next, craft. I notice the image of decay applied to a whole country, as if the kingdom were a body going bad. The strongest word is "rotten": it suggests corruption spreading from inside, which fits a murder hidden at the top of the state. Then, effect. What does Marcellus's line suggest about Denmark at the start of the play? My answer: Marcellus senses that the Ghost means a moral sickness in Denmark's rulers; the image of rot runs through the play, as Claudius's secret crime poisons the court, the family and Hamlet's mind.

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" slowly and put it in my own words: After the Ghost appears and beckons Hamlet away, the guard Marcellus says that something is rotten in the state of Denmark. Next, craft. I notice the image of decay applied to a whole country, as if the kingdom were a body going bad. The strongest word is "rotten": it suggests corruption spreading from inside, which fits a murder hidden at the top of the state. Then, effect. What does Marcellus's line suggest about Denmark at the start of the play? My answer: Marcellus senses that the Ghost means a moral sickness in Denmark's rulers; the image of rot runs through the play, as Claudius's secret crime poisons the court, the family and Hamlet's mind.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play. Themes to track: revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both? action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance? appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays. death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us. corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Hamlet: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Hamlet still matter? Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.
Anchor question: Why might Hamlet still be taught today?
Facilitation: Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Shakespeare wrote Hamlet around 1600, near the end of Queen Elizabeth I's reign, when no one knew who would succeed her, and revenge tragedies were popular on the London stage. How might that context shape a play about a disputed throne and revenge? Answer: Accept answers such as: worry about succession made a stolen crown feel urgent; audiences knew the revenge-play formula and Shakespeare questions it; the play reflects anxiety about legitimate rule.
Exit ticket: Shakespeare wrote Hamlet around 1600, near the end of Queen Elizabeth I's reign, when no one knew who would succeed her, and revenge tragedies were popular on the London stage. How might that context shape a play about a disputed throne and revenge?
Answer: Accept answers such as: worry about succession made a stolen crown feel urgent; audiences knew the revenge-play formula and Shakespeare questions it; the play reflects anxiety about legitimate rule.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Dramatis Personae.

Teacher notes · sources: Folger Shakespeare Library, "Shakespeare's life" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-life/); Shakespeare Birthplace Trust, "William Shakespeare" (https://www.shakespeare.org.uk/explore-shakespeare/shakespedia/william-shakespeare/); Folger Shakespeare Library, "Hamlet" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-works/hamlet/); Royal Shakespeare Company, "Hamlet: about the play" (https://www.rsc.org.uk/hamlet/about-the-play); British Library, "Hamlet: the First Quarto (1603)" (https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/hamlet-first-quarto-1603); Saxo Grammaticus, Gesta Danorum, Book III (Amleth) (https://www.gutenberg.org/); Britannica, "Hamlet" (https://www.britannica.com/topic/Hamlet-by-Shakespeare)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The date (about 1599–1601) is a scholarly inference; Q1 (1603) gives a terminus.
- Gabriel Harvey's note cannot be dated exactly; scholars date it between 1598 and 1601.
- Any link between Hamlet and Shakespeare's son Hamnet (died 1596) is speculation; present it as such if raised.

Critical voice: "If the dramas of Shakespeare were to be characterised, each by the particular excellence which distinguishes it from the rest, we must allow to the tragedy of HAMLET the praise of variety." (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note*

on Hamlet; public domain). Bell-ringer: list the tones you expect from a revenge tragedy; return to the list after Act V. *Objective:* Introduce the play's structure and its mix of tones. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.5

Critical voice: “Hamlet is a name: his speeches and sayings but the idle coinage of the poet's brain. What then, are they not real? They are as real as our own thoughts. Their reality is in the reader's mind. It is WE who are Hamlet. This play has a prophetic truth, which is above that of history.” (William Hazlitt, essayist and critic, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays (1817), "Hamlet", "Hamlet"*; public domain). Discussion: is identifying with Hamlet a help or a trap for analysis? *Objective:* Consider why readers identify with Hamlet. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, SL.11-12.1

Critical voice: “And probably more people have thought _Hamlet_ a work of art because they found it interesting, than have found it interesting because it is a work of art. It is the “Mona Lisa” of literature.” (T. S. Eliot, poet and critic, *"Hamlet and His Problems," The Sacred Wood (1920), "Hamlet and His Problems"*; public domain). Provocation: Eliot thinks Hamlet is an "artistic failure." Keep a running log through the unit: evidence for/against. *Objective:* Evaluate competing judgments of the play's artistic success. *Standards:* Common Core W.11-12.1

Lesson 2: Dramatis Personae

Focus: the court of Denmark

Objective: Students will identify at least 5 characters from the cast list and explain, in one sentence each, how each is related to the play's central family or court.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3

Teacher only · spoilers

The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of Hamlet's father.

Background: Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest.

Significance: The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....*
> **Prompt:** If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
> **Sentence starters:** I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
> **Strong response:** A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

> **8–16 min · Background and context · I do (8 min)**
> Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
> *Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest. The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs. Characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Watch for the Ghost: listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.*

> **16–20 min · Closure · I do (4 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the court of Denmark. Key takeaway: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.*

Total: 20 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.
- **Setting:** "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle.
- **Structure:** Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

Symbols and motifs

- **the Ghost:** listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) Hamlet's divided position.
- “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) Gertrude's two roles.
- “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae) Another prince who has lost a father.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings.
Evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae)
Reasoning: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
messengers (noun)	people who carry messages	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	

attendants (noun)	servants who wait on a person of rank	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	"attendants": Origin of "attendant": Old French attendant. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/attendant#Etymology)
sailors (noun)	seamen	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	"sailors": Origin of "sailor": an English formation from sail + -or. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/sailor#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Which characters are listed as courtiers? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.
2. Who is king of Denmark at the start? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
3. What is Hamlet's relation to the king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Nephew
4. Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius's
5. Who is Fortinbras? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Prince of Norway
6. Where is the play set? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Denmark
7. Retell the three most important events of "Dramatis Personae" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of…
8. Who is on stage in "Dramatis Personae", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.

9. Where and when does “Dramatis Personae” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants” What does “messengers” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: messengers: people who carry messages.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge.
2. What does “Dramatis Personae” suggest about the court of Denmark? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the setting in this scene shape what we understand about the court of Denmark? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Claudius, king of Denmark”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Dramatis Personae”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric;…
7. As the opening scene, what does “Dramatis Personae” set up that the rest of Hamlet will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Dramatis Personae”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the court of Denmark. [DOK 4 ·

thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Dramatis Personae”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Dramatis Personae” treats the court of Denmark with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position

that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the court of Denmark? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia?
    A. Claudius's
    B. Polonius's
    C. Horatio's
    D. Gertrude's

    Key: B (Polonius's)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other _____” Word bank: sailors, messengers, attendants
    Key: attendants
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is king of Denmark at the start?
    A. Fortinbras
    B. Old Hamlet
    C. Claudius
    D. Polonius

    Key: C (Claudius)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Fortinbras?
    A. An actor
    B. A gravedigger
    C. Prince of Norway
    D. A Danish courtier

    Key: C (Prince of Norway)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Hamlet's relation to the king?
    A. Nephew

B. Cousin

C. Son

D. Brother

Key: A (Nephew)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “attendants” most nearly mean?

   A. servants who wait on a person of rank

   B. pressed with requests; courted

   C. repay

   D. prevented beforehand

   Key: A (servants who wait on a person of rank)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “_____, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet”

   Key: Gertrude

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, _____, and other attendants” Word bank: attendants, messengers, sailors

   Key: messengers

9. [short · recall · DOK 1] Which characters are listed as courtiers?

   Sample answer: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers?

    Sample answer: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

    A. The court of Denmark

    B. The graveyard

    C. The Mousetrap

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: A (The court of Denmark)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae)

    A. Ophelia's fear.

    B. Hamlet's divided position.

    C. Atmosphere.

    D. Gertrude's description.

    Key: B (Hamlet's divided position.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

    A. Revenge and justice

B. Corruption and the state

C. Action and delay

D. Appearance and reality

Key: B (Corruption and the state)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.

A. Metaphor

B. Structure

C. Characterization

D. Allusion

Key: C (Characterization)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Dramatis Personae”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is the play set?

A. Denmark

B. England

C. Poland

D. Norway

Key: A (Denmark)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “sailors” most nearly mean?

A. substitute

B. boisterous; reeling

C. seamen

D. not yet having feathers; immature

Key: C (seamen)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the _____ king”

Key: present

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae)

A. Claudius flees.

B. Gertrude's two roles.

C. Thinking prevents action.

D. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

Key: B (Gertrude's two roles.)

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae)

A. Resolve.

B. The pirate attack.

C. Another prince who has lost a father.

D. Atmosphere.

Key: C (Another prince who has lost a father.)

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle.

A. Diction / vocabulary

B. Tone / mood

C. Alliteration

D. Setting

Key: D (Setting)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Another prince who has lost a father.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest?

Sample answer: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position.

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “messengers” most nearly mean?

A. accompaniment; proper ceremony

B. power; capacity

C. people who carry messages

D. outdo; defy

Key: C (people who carry messages)

27. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae).

Sample answer: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing

reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 6, 17, 5, 3, 18, 19, 8, 20, 21, 13, 12, 22, 23, 15, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 5, 3, 2, 1, 9, 21, 13, 11, 20, 10, 15, 14, 23, 24, 25	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 1, 26, 2, 19, 11, 20, 27, 21, 13, 15, 28, 14, 23, 29, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 17, 19, 2, 10, 13, 20, 12, 11, 23, 22, 14, 15, 29, 24, 25	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 2, 18, 12, 20, 21, 13, 28, 15, 14, 23, 22, 29, 30, 24, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	19, 8, 6, 21, 20, 13, 11, 15, 23, 14, 28, 22, 16, 24, 25, 30	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	2, 8, 10, 12, 11, 21, 23, 28, 14, 22, 15, 24, 29, 16, 30, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	8, 2, 10, 27, 12, 20, 15, 14, 28, 22, 23, 29, 30, 16, 24, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	8, 2, 21, 20, 27, 12, 22, 23, 15, 14, 28, 25, 24, 29, 16, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	8, 2, 20, 21, 10, 13, 22, 14, 23, 15, 28, 29, 30, 25, 16, 24	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Dramatis Personae,” how does Shakespeare show the court of Denmark? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Dramatis Personae, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the court of Denmark? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Dramatis Personae develops the idea of the court of Denmark. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Dramatis Personae (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Dramatis Personae suggests about the court of Denmark. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Dramatis Personae to complicate the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Dramatis Personae within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the court of Denmark responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Dramatis Personae alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the court of Denmark follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Dramatis Personae and its treatment of the court of Denmark. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Dramatis Personae as evidence for a larger claim about the court of Denmark in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Dramatis Personae as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the court of Denmark. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Claudius, king of Denmark*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

   A. Claudius at prayer

   B. The plot against Hamlet

   C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

   D. The court of Denmark

SAT key: 1. D (The court of Denmark)

Lesson 3: Act I, Scene I

Focus: the Ghost on the battlements

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in "Act I, Scene I" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.

Background: Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic.

Significance: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: foreknowing — knowing in advance; harrows — distresses deeply; tears at; eruption — an outbreak of trouble; partisan — a long-handled spear with a broad blade; martial — military; warlike. "eruption": Origin: Middle French éruption; earlier Latin eruptio. "martial": Origin: Middle French martial; earlier Latin mārtiālis.
Words: foreknowing: knowing in advance · harrows: distresses deeply; tears at · eruption: an outbreak of trouble · partisan: a long-handled spear with a broad blade · martial: military; warlike

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic. The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state. Setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "this relief much thanks: 'tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Who's there" slowly and put it in my own words: On a cold, dark night, the sentry Bernardo comes to relieve Francisco and calls out "Who's there?" Next, craft. I notice it is the incoming guard who challenges, the wrong way round, which shows how nervous he is. The strongest word is "there": the word points into darkness at something unseen, the way the whole play searches for hidden truth. Then, effect. Why does the play open with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard? My answer: The play opens with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard because Denmark is uneasy and no one knows who anyone is; the reversed question sets the mood of fear and the central problem of hidden truth.

> *Who's there (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Who's there" slowly and put it in my own words: On a cold, dark night, the sentry Bernardo comes to relieve Francisco and calls out "Who's there?" Next, craft. I notice it is the incoming guard who challenges, the wrong way round, which shows how nervous he is. The strongest word is "there": the word points into darkness at something unseen, the way the whole play searches for hidden truth. Then, effect. Why does the play open with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard? My answer: The play opens with a nervous challenge from the wrong guard because Denmark is uneasy and no one knows who anyone is; the reversed question sets the mood of fear and the central problem of hidden truth.

40–50 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (10 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

> *This bodes some strange eruption to our state (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

50–55 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (5 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

55–60 min · Discussion · We do (5 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
Facilitation: Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?

60–67 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

67–70 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes the Ghost on the battlements. Key takeaway: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

Total: 70 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."
- **Foreshadowing:** The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state."
- **Structure:** The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask).

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "this relief much thanks: 'tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "Sit down awhile; / And let us once again assail your ears, / That are so fortified against our story / What we have two" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) The first line: a play of questions.
- "tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) Mood: cold and unease.

- “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio) Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state.
Evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)
Reasoning: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
foreknowing (noun)	knowing in advance	*If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!*	
harrows (verb)	distresses deeply; tears at	*Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.*	
eruption (noun)	an outbreak of trouble	*In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*	“eruption”: Origin: Middle French éruption; earlier Latin eruptio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/eruption#Etymology)
partisan (noun)	a long-handled spear with a broad blade	*Shall I strike at it with my partisan?*	
martial (adjective)	military; warlike	*Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With martial stalk hath he gone by our watch.*	“martial”: Origin: Middle French martial; earlier Latin mārtiālis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/martial#Etymology)
needful (adjective)	necessary	*Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it, As needful in our loves, fitting our duty?*	
majestical (adjective)	majestic; royal in bearing	*We do it wrong, being so majestical, To offer it the show of violence; For it is, as the air, invulnerable, And our vain blows malicious mockery.*	
portentous (adjective)	full of ominous meaning	*I think it be no other but e'en so: Well may it sort that this portentous figure Comes armed through our watch; so like the king That was and is the question of these wars.*	

fantasy (noun)	imagination; a figment	*How now, Horatio! you tremble and look pale: Is not this something more than fantasy?*	

Discussion questions

1. What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the first line of the play? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: 'Who's there?'
2. Where does the scene take place? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The battlements at Elsinore
3. Whom does the Ghost resemble? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The dead King Hamlet
4. Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
5. What does Fortinbras want? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To recover lands his father lost
6. When does the Ghost vanish? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At cockcrow
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.

10. Reread: “If thou art privy to thy country’s fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!” What does “foreknowing” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: foreknowing: knowing in advance.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Horatio think the Ghost appears? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It bodes some strange eruption to the state.
2. What does “Act I, Scene I” suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Horatio says ’tis but our fantasy, And will not let belief take hold of him Touching this dreaded sight, twice seen of us: Therefore I have entreated him along With us to watch…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The…
7. How does “Act I, Scene I” build on “Dramatis Personae”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and

uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes a story's opening scene frightening?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Why open with guards rather than royalty? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment about atmosphere and perspective.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost on the battlements. [DOK 4 ·

thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. On setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene I” treats the Ghost on the battlements with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo): The

first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it, As _____ in our loves, fitting our duty?” Word bank: needful, harrows, eruption, foreknowing
    Key: needful
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] When does the Ghost vanish?
    A. At noon
    B. When Hamlet arrives
    C. At cockcrow
    D. At midnight
    Key: C (At cockcrow)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Fortinbras want?
    A. To marry Ophelia
    B. To become king of England
    C. To join Hamlet
    D. To recover lands his father lost
    Key: D (To recover lands his father lost)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “We do it wrong, being so _____, To offer it the show of violence; For it is, as the air, invulnerable, And our vain blows malicious mockery.”
    Word bank: harrows, eruption, majestical, foreknowing
    Key: majestical
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With _____ stalk hath he gone by our watch.” Word bank: foreknowing, harrows, eruption, martial
    Key: martial

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.”, what does “harrows” most nearly mean?

   A. favor and approval

   B. distresses deeply; tears at

   C. in a state of gross sin, unprepared

   D. cleansing; also medical purging

   Key: B (distresses deeply; tears at)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does the scene take place?

   A. A graveyard

   B. A ship

   C. The throne room

   D. The battlements at Elsinore

   Key: D (The battlements at Elsinore)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost?

   A. Osric

   B. Horatio

   C. Hamlet

   D. Laertes

   Key: B (Horatio)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene I, Francisco: “tis _____ cold, / And I am sick at heart”

   Key: bitter

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Horatio think the Ghost appears?

    Sample answer: It bodes some strange eruption to the state.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo)

    A. The first line: a play of questions.

    B. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

    C. Claudius flees.

    D. Rosencrantz as sponge.

    Key: A (The first line: a play of questions.)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The first line: a play of questions.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene I”?

    A. Polonius spies on Laertes

    B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    C. The court of Denmark

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: D (The Ghost on the battlements)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene I”? Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."

    A. Theme

    B. Setting

    C. Metaphor

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: B (Setting)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act I, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

17. [short · recall · DOK 1] What is the first line of the play?

    Sample answer: 'Who's there?'

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Shall I strike at it with my partisan?”, what does “partisan” most nearly mean?

    A. habitual drinkers

    B. a long-handled spear with a broad blade

    C. causing great pain

    D. substitute

    Key: B (a long-handled spear with a broad blade)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene I, Horatio: “This bodes some strange _____ to our state”

    Key: eruption

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio)

    A. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

    B. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    C. Life versus death.

    D. Corruption.

    Key: A (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene I”? The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state."

    A. Metaphor

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Imagery

    D. Conflict

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a

passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

23. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I think it be no other but e’en so: Well may it sort that this _____ figure Comes armed through our watch; so like the king That was and is the question of these wars.” Word bank: foreknowing, portentous, harrows, eruption

    Key: portentous

24. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco)

    A. Mood: cold and unease.

    B. Claudius.

    C. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    D. Polonius's advice.

    Key: A (Mood: cold and unease.)

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio).

    Sample answer: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The first line: a play of questions.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Why open with guards rather than royalty?

    Sample answer: A judgment about atmosphere and perspective.

28. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

    A. Corruption and the state

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Action and delay

    Key: A (Corruption and the state)

29. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Mood: cold and unease.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Mood: cold and unease.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 18, 5, 2, 6, 1, 7, 19, 13, 12, 20, 10, 21, 14, 15, 22	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1

HS Sophomore	23, 17, 18, 4, 19, 3, 24, 11, 20, 10, 13, 21, 25, 14, 26, 27	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	19, 18, 7, 6, 9, 24, 13, 11, 20, 10, 14, 21, 25, 28, 26, 22	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 3, 9, 1, 13, 11, 29, 12, 20, 14, 25, 28, 21, 22, 30, 27	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	1, 5, 3, 24, 29, 13, 11, 28, 15, 21, 25, 14, 22, 27, 30, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 5, 2, 20, 13, 12, 29, 21, 25, 14, 15, 28, 27, 30, 26, 22	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 1, 20, 11, 13, 29, 21, 14, 28, 15, 25, 30, 27, 22, 16, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	4, 1, 29, 10, 24, 12, 21, 28, 14, 25, 15, 22, 26, 16, 30, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	5, 1, 29, 10, 24, 20, 28, 25, 21, 15, 14, 16, 26, 27, 22, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	9, 5, 13, 11, 20, 10, 21, 25, 14, 28, 15, 27, 22, 30, 26, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show the Ghost on the battlements? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost on the battlements? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene I suggests about the Ghost on the battlements. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost on the battlements responds to that

context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost on the battlements follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene I and its treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost on the battlements in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “eruption” most nearly mean?

   A. an outbreak of trouble

   B. full of ominous meaning

   C. majestic; royal in bearing

   D. imagination; a figment

2. *Horatio says ’tis but our fantasy, And will not let belief take hold of him Touching this dreaded sight, twice seen of us: Therefore I have entreated him along With us to watch the minutes of this night; That if again this apparition come, He may approve our eyes and speak to it.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene I”?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   B. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   C. The Ghost on the battlements

   D. The Mousetrap

SAT key: 1. A (an outbreak of trouble); 2. C (The Ghost on the battlements)

Lesson 4: Act I, Scene II

Focus: Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “It was the moral shock of the sudden ghastly disclosure of his mother's true nature, falling on him when his heart was aching with love, and his body doubtless was weakened by sorrow.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III*; public domain). Close reading of "O, that this too too solid flesh": is the father's death or the mother's remarriage the deeper wound? *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's first soliloquy and the source of his grief. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (suicidal thoughts, incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Hamlet wishes his flesh would melt and regrets that God forbids 'self-slaughter.' Use the safe-messaging script; focus on grief and what Hamlet is reacting to. Hamlet calls the marriage 'incestuous sheets' (the period view of marrying a dead husband's brother). This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…at is your affair in Elsinore? We'll teach you to drink deep ere you depart. My lord, I came to…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What has made Hamlet feel this way?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.

Background: Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university.

Significance: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How long should grief last? Who decides? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenable — kept close; held secret; retrograde — contrary; opposed; yesternight — last night; methinks — it seems to me; countenance — favor and approval. "tenable": Origin: French tenable. "retrograde": Origin: Middle French retrograde; earlier Old French retrograde.
Words: tenable: kept close; held secret · retrograde: contrary; opposed · yesternight: last night · methinks: it seems to me · countenance: favor and approval

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university. The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief. Characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "fie! 'tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "A little more than kin, and less than kind" slowly and put it in my own words: When Claudius calls him "my cousin Hamlet, and my son," Hamlet mutters that they are a little more than kin and less than kind. Next, craft. I notice the wordplay on kin and kind, two words that sound alike but mean family and natural feeling. The strongest word is "kind": it carries two meanings, "loving" and "natural," and Hamlet denies Claudius both. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's first line reveal about how he feels toward Claudius? My answer: Hamlet's first words are a bitter aside; he resents the hasty marriage that made his uncle his stepfather, and his punning shows the sharp wit he will use as a weapon.

> *A little more than kin, and less than kind* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "A little more than kin, and less than kind" slowly and put it in my own words: When Claudius calls him "my cousin Hamlet, and my son," Hamlet mutters that they are a little more than kin and less than kind. Next, craft. I notice the wordplay on kin and kind, two words that sound alike but mean family and natural feeling. The strongest word is "kind": it carries two meanings, "loving" and "natural," and Hamlet denies Claudius both. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's first line reveal about how he feels toward Claudius? My answer: Hamlet's first words are a bitter aside; he resents the hasty marriage that made his uncle his stepfather, and his punning shows the sharp wit he will use as a weapon.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

> *Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not "seems* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides? Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Key takeaway: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
- **Structure:** First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt."

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “fie! ’tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “hear your enemy say so, / Nor shall you do mine ear that violence, / To make it truster of your own report / Against” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.
- “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Appearance versus reality.
- “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) First soliloquy.
- “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet on Gertrude.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs.
Evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history

tenable (adjective)	kept close; held secret	*I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.*	"tenable": Origin: French tenable. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/tenable#Etymology)
retrograde (adjective)	contrary; opposed	*For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.*	"retrograde": Origin: Middle French retrograde; earlier Old French retrograde. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/retrograde#Etymology)
yesternight (noun)	last night	*My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*	
methinks (verb)	it seems to me	*My father!—methinks I see my father.*	
countenance (noun)	favor and approval	*A countenance more in sorrow than in anger.*	
nighted (adjective)	dark as night; here, mourning-black	*Good Hamlet, cast thy nighted colour off, And let thine eye look like a friend on Denmark.*	
instrumental (adjective)	serviceable; useful	*The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more instrumental to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father.*	"instrumental": Origin: Medieval Latin īnstrūmentālis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/instrumental#Etymology)
courtier (noun)	a person who attends a royal court	*For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.*	"courtier": Origin: Anglo-Norman corteour. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/courtier#Etymology)
requite (verb)	repay	*I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.*	
dexterity (noun)	quickness; speed	*O, most wicked speed, to post With such dexterity to incestuous sheets!*	

Discussion questions

1. How long should grief last? Who decides?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the funeral baked meats? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They coldly furnished forth the marriage tables.
2. Whom has Claudius married? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. Where does Hamlet want to go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Wittenberg
4. Where is Laertes allowed to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: France
5. How long after the funeral was the marriage? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Less than two months
6. What does Hamlet wear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Black mourning clothes
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves." What does "tenable" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: tenable: kept close; held secret.

Inferential / analytical

1. How does Claudius try to win Hamlet over? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He calls him his son and heir and urges him to stop mourning.
2. What does “Act I, Scene II” suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. On diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “We doubt it nothing: heartily farewell.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the…
7. How does “Act I, Scene II” build on “Act I, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “How long should grief last? Who decides?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's anger at Gertrude justified? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position

that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene II” treats Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on Gertrude. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene III” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2,

SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Good Hamlet, cast thy _____ colour off, And let thine eye look like a friend on Denmark.” Word bank: retrograde, yesternight, tenable, nighted
   Key: nighted
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.”, what does “retrograde” most nearly mean?

   A. a person without moral restraint

   B. majestic; royal in bearing

   C. sugared; flattering

   D. contrary; opposed

   Key: D (contrary; opposed)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet wear?

   A. A crown

   B. Black mourning clothes

   C. Armour

   D. Rags

   Key: B (Black mourning clothes)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene II, Hamlet: “A _____ more than kin, and less than kind”
   Key: little
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more _____ to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father.” Word bank: yesternight, tenable, instrumental, retrograde
   Key: instrumental
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A _____ more in sorrow than in anger.” Word bank: retrograde, countenance, tenable, yesternight
   Key: countenance

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.”, what does “yesternight” most nearly mean?

   A. last night

   B. trickery

   C. a bird easily caught; a fool

   D. an outbreak of trouble

   Key: A (last night)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Laertes allowed to go?

   A. France

   B. Wittenberg

   C. Poland

   D. England

   Key: A (France)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “My father!—methinks I see my father.”, what does “methinks” most nearly mean?

   A. forced their way onto (a ship)

   B. it seems to me

   C. completion; ending

   D. chains for the feet

   Key: B (it seems to me)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Appearance versus reality.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Acceptance before the duel.

    B. Polonius's aside.

    C. Hamlet's last words.

    D. First soliloquy.

    Key: D (First soliloquy.)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] How does Claudius try to win Hamlet over?

    Sample answer: He calls him his son and heir and urges him to stop mourning.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene II”? Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."

    A. Conflict

    B. Allusion

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Setting

    Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's anger at Gertrude justified? Argue.

    Sample answer: A reasoned view.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How long after the funeral was the marriage?

    A. A year

    B. Less than two months

    C. A week

    D. Five years

    Key: B (Less than two months)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Hamlet want to go?

    A. France

    B. Norway

    C. Wittenberg

    D. England

    Key: C (Wittenberg)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom has Claudius married?

    A. A Norwegian princess

    B. Gertrude

    C. Hamlet's sister

    D. Ophelia

    Key: B (Gertrude)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene II”?

    A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    B. Hamlet hides the body

    C. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: A (Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief)

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    B. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

    C. Corruption.

    D. Hamlet's rejection.

Key: B (Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.)

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene II”? Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.

    A. Plot

    B. Conflict

    C. Structure

    D. Characterization

    Key: D (Characterization)

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

    A. Death and mortality

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Action and delay

    Key: B (Appearance and reality)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Appearance versus reality.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest _____, cousin, and our son.” Word bank: tenable, courtier, yesternight, retrograde

    Key: courtier

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    B. Claudius's anxiety.

    C. Hamlet on Gertrude.

    D. Death levels all.

    Key: C (Hamlet on Gertrude.)

27. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    B. Hamlet's self-reproach.

    C. The pirate attack.

    D. Appearance versus reality.

    Key: D (Appearance versus reality.)

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

29. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say about the funeral baked meats?
    Sample answer: They coldly furnished forth the marriage tables.
30. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal’d this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.”, what does “tenable” most nearly mean?
    A. cannons
    B. offers (of love)
    C. substitute
    D. kept close; held secret
    Key: D (kept close; held secret)
31. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: First soliloquy.
32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"
33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from an earlier scene to “Act I, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 17, 18, 19, 3, 5, 6, 4, 10, 20, 21, 12, 22, 23, 14, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	4, 1, 17, 25, 6, 9, 21, 11, 20, 26, 27, 23, 22, 15, 28, 24	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 25, 4, 29, 30, 13, 27, 20, 10, 12, 15, 14, 31, 23, 16, 28	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	25, 6, 29, 7, 26, 11, 12, 10, 20, 14, 23, 22, 31, 32, 33, 24	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 1, 30, 20, 21, 13, 12, 23, 22, 14, 15, 31, 33, 28, 24, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 6, 8, 12, 13, 20, 10, 23, 31, 15, 14, 22, 32, 33, 16, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 1, 26, 27, 12, 11, 15, 22, 14, 23, 31, 28, 24, 16, 33, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	1, 6, 11, 26, 13, 21, 22, 14, 15, 31, 23, 33, 24, 16, 32, 28	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	6, 1, 20, 13, 26, 10, 22, 15, 14, 23, 31, 16, 28, 24, 33, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 6, 21, 20, 11, 10, 23, 31, 22, 15, 14, 28, 24, 32, 33, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius's court and Hamlet's

grief? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene II suggests about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene II and its treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “yesternight” most nearly mean?

   A. repay

   B. a person who attends a royal court

   C. last night

   D. quickness; speed

2. *We doubt it nothing: heartily farewell. Exeunt Voltimand and Cornelius. And now, Laertes, what’s the news with you? You told us of some suit; what is’t, Laertes? You cannot speak of reason to the Dane, And lose your voice: what wouldst thou beg, Laertes, That shall not be my offer, not thy asking? The head is not more native to the heart, The hand more instrumental to the mouth, Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father. What wouldst thou have, Laertes?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene II”?

   A. Claudius at prayer

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. The duel and the deaths

   D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

SAT key: 1. C (last night); 2. B (Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief)

Lesson 5: Act I, Scene III

Focus: Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene III” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Polonius is a man bred in courts, exercised in business, stored with observation, confident of his knowledge, proud of his eloquence, and declining into dotage.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, note on Act II, Scene ii*; public domain). Annotate Polonius's advice to Laertes for "proud of his eloquence" and "declining into dotage." Is the advice good even if the man is foolish? *Objective:* Analyze Polonius as father and counselor. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Teacher only · spoilers

Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.

Background: Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state.

Significance: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Should parents choose whom their children date? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because....
Prompt: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenders — offers (of love); primrose — flowery and pleasant (the easy path); dalliance — idle, flirtatious play; unfledged — not yet having feathers; immature; borrower — one who borrows. “dalliance”: Origin: Old French dalier. “borrower”: Origin: an English formation from borrow + -er.
Words: tenders: offers (of love) · primrose: flowery and pleasant (the easy path) · dalliance: idle, flirtatious play · unfledged: not yet having feathers; immature · borrower: one who borrows

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state. The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency. Characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" slowly and put it in my own words: Sending Laertes off to France, Polonius gives a list of maxims, including not to borrow or lend money. Next, craft. I notice the balanced, proverb-like phrase "neither... nor," typical of his tidy, quotable advice. The strongest word is "borrower": it frames life in terms of money and reputation, his main concerns. Then, effect. What does Polonius's advice show about his values? My answer: Polonius cares most about appearances and prudence; his advice sounds wise but is calculating, and his later spying shows the same concern with managing how things look.

> *Neither a borrower nor a lender be* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" slowly and put it in my own words: Sending Laertes off to France, Polonius gives a list of maxims, including not to borrow or lend money. Next, craft. I notice the balanced, proverb-like phrase "neither... nor," typical of his tidy, quotable advice. The strongest word is "borrower": it frames life in terms of money and reputation, his main concerns. Then, effect. What does Polonius's advice show about his values? My answer: Polonius cares most about appearances and prudence; his advice sounds wise but is calculating, and his later spying shows the same concern with managing how things look.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

> *This above all: to thine ownself be true* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date? How much choice does Ophelia have?
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Facilitation: How much choice does Ophelia have?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Key takeaway: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.
- **Conflict:** Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
- **Irony:** Polonius advises honesty while he will spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “what loss your honour may sustain, / If with too credent ear you list his songs, / Or lose your heart, or your chaste” (Act I, Scene III, Laertes).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Polonius's advice.
- “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").
- “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia) Ophelia's obedience.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family.
Evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)
Reasoning: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
tenders (noun)	offers (of love)	*He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.*	
primrose (adjective)		*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the*	

	flowery and pleasant (the easy path)	*steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	
dalliance (noun)	idle, flirtatious play	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"dalliance": Origin: Old French dalier. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/dalliance#Etymology)
unfledged (adjective)	not yet having feathers; immature	*Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.*	
borrower (noun)	one who borrows	*Neither a borrower nor a lender be; For loan oft loses both itself and friend, And borrowing dulls the edge of husbandry.*	"borrower": Origin: an English formation from borrow + -er. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/borrower#Etymology)
importuned (verb)	pressed with requests; courted	*My lord, he hath importuned me with love In honourable fashion.*	"importuned": Origin of "importune": Middle French importuner; earlier Medieval Latin importūnor ("to make oneself troublesome"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/importune#Etymology)
libertine (noun)	a person without moral restraint	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"libertine": Origin: Latin libertinus ("a freedman"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/libertine#Etymology)
ungracious (adjective)	lacking God's grace; wicked	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	"ungracious": Origin: an English formation from un- + gracious. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ungracious#Etymology)
pastors (noun)	ministers; preachers	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven;*	

		Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.	

Discussion questions

1. Should parents choose whom their children date?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Polonius say about friends? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Grapple tried friends to your soul with hoops of steel.
2. Where is Laertes going? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: France
3. What does Laertes warn Ophelia about? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's love
4. What does Polonius advise about money? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Neither borrow nor lend
5. What does Polonius order Ophelia to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Stop seeing Hamlet
6. How does Ophelia answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: I shall obey
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me." What does "tenders" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: tenders: offers (of love).

Inferential / analytical

1. What is ironic about Polonius's advice to be true to oneself? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He is a manipulator and spy.
2. What does “Act I, Scene III” suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the conflict in this scene shape what we understand about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.
7. How does “Act I, Scene III” build on “Act I, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Should parents choose whom their children date?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what

characters expect or say and what is true.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene III” treats Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Neither a _____ nor a lender be; For loan oft loses both itself and friend, And borrowing dulls the edge of husbandry." Word bank: dalliance, primrose, borrower, tenders
   Key: borrower
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, Polonius: "This above all: to thine _____ be true"
   Key: ownself
3. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Polonius say about friends?
   Sample answer: Grapple tried friends to your soul with hoops of steel.
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "My lord, he hath _____ me with love In honourable fashion." Word bank: tenders, importuned, primrose, dalliance
   Key: importuned
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.", what does "unfledged" most nearly mean?
   A. not yet having feathers; immature
   B. placed in a coffin
   C. sugared; flattering
   D. accompaniment; proper ceremony
   Key: A (not yet having feathers; immature)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own…", what does "primrose" most nearly mean?
   A. image; likeness
   B. wooden flutes
   C. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)
   D. an outbreak of trouble
   Key: C (flowery and pleasant (the easy path))
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Laertes going?
   A. England
   B. France
   C. Wittenberg
   D. Norway
   Key: B (France)
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own…", what does "dalliance" most nearly mean?
   A. a reply or answer
   B. seamen

C. idle, flirtatious play

D. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

Key: C (idle, flirtatious play)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff’d and reckless _____, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.” Word bank: primrose, tenders, libertine, dalliance

   Key: libertine

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What is ironic about Polonius's advice to be true to oneself?

    Sample answer: He is a manipulator and spy.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)

    A. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

    B. Claudius flees.

    C. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    D. Gertrude's shame.

    Key: C (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene III”?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. The closet scene

    C. Claudius at prayer

    D. The Mousetrap

    Key: A (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.

    A. Characterization

    B. Simile

    C. Imagery

    D. Point of view

    Key: A (Characterization)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Ophelia's obedience.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Laertes warn Ophelia about?

    A. Hamlet's love

    B. Claudius

    C. Polonius's anger

    D. The Ghost

    Key: A (Hamlet's love)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But, good my brother, Do not, as some _____ pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff’d and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.” Word bank: primrose, ungracious, dalliance, tenders

    Key: ungracious

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene III, Polonius: “Neither a _____ nor a lender be”

    Key: borrower

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.”, what does “tenders” most nearly mean?

    A. following

    B. a punishment; whip

    C. offers (of love)

    D. flirting; trifling

    Key: C (offers (of love))

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia)

    A. Ophelia's obedience.

    B. Laertes.

    C. The pirate attack.

    D. The plan.

    Key: A (Ophelia's obedience.)

22. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Polonius's advice.

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius).

    Sample answer: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene III”? Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.

    A. Symbolism

    B. Simile

    C. Setting

    D. Conflict

Key: D (Conflict)

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate.
    Sample answer: A reasoned judgment.
26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Ophelia answer?
    A. She laughs
    B. She refuses
    C. She runs away
    D. I shall obey

    Key: D (I shall obey)
27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Polonius order Ophelia to do?
    A. Go to France
    B. Spy on Claudius
    C. Marry Hamlet
    D. Stop seeing Hamlet

    Key: D (Stop seeing Hamlet)
28. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius)
    A. Polonius's advice.
    B. Riddle.
    C. Life versus death.
    D. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    Key: A (Polonius's advice.)
29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.
    A. Death and mortality
    B. Action and delay
    C. Appearance and reality
    D. Revenge and justice

    Key: C (Appearance and reality)
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Polonius's advice.
31. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Polonius advise about money?
    A. Neither borrow nor lend
    B. Gamble wisely
    C. Save everything
    D. Spend freely

    Key: A (Neither borrow nor lend)

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from an earlier scene to “Act I, Scene III”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.
33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	9, 1, 17, 8, 7, 18, 19, 20, 21, 11, 13, 22, 15, 23, 24, 25	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	19, 7, 26, 27, 1, 8, 13, 21, 22, 28, 10, 14, 24, 29, 16, 30	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 6, 2, 31, 18, 12, 21, 13, 10, 22, 24, 29, 15, 14, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	20, 1, 4, 27, 10, 13, 11, 12, 22, 23, 14, 29, 24, 16, 30, 25	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 1, 19, 28, 11, 12, 13, 15, 14, 24, 23, 29, 30, 32, 25, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	19, 1, 8, 12, 28, 11, 10, 14, 24, 15, 29, 23, 16, 25, 33, 30	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	18, 4, 10, 28, 22, 21, 15, 24, 29, 14, 23, 16, 32, 25, 33, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	1, 4, 21, 12, 13, 10, 29, 23, 14, 24, 15, 16, 30, 33, 32, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	1, 4, 12, 13, 22, 28, 14, 15, 24, 29, 23, 16, 32, 33, 30, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 4, 21, 10, 13, 22, 29, 24, 15, 14, 23, 30, 25, 32, 33, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of

textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene III suggests about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene III and its treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "dalliance" most nearly mean?

   A. ministers; preachers

   B. idle, flirtatious play

   C. a person without moral restraint

   D. lacking God's grace; wicked

2. *I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart. But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene III"?

   A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   B. The court of Denmark

   C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. B (idle, flirtatious play); 2. D (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

Lesson 6: Act I, Scene IV

Focus: Hamlet sees the Ghost

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in “Act I, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (alcohol): Claudius's drinking ('takes his rouse', 'keeps wassail', 'drains his draughts of Rhenish') is a custom Hamlet calls 'more honour'd in the breach than the observance'. Name the drinking plainly; discuss how Hamlet ties it to Denmark's reputation.
Student preview: This scene describes the king's heavy drinking.
Suggested language: “Why does Hamlet disapprove of the custom?”

Teacher only · spoilers

On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.

Background: Danish drinking was proverbial in England.

Significance: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What would make you follow a ghost? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... Content note before we start: This scene describes the king's heavy drinking.
Prompt: What would make you follow a ghost?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: hearsed — placed in a coffin; beckons — signals someone to come; cerements — burial cloths; wassail — drinking and revelry; ordnance — cannons. “cerements”: Origin of “cerement”: French cirement (“waxing”).
Words: hearsed: placed in a coffin · beckons: signals someone to come · cerements: burial cloths · wassail: drinking and revelry · ordnance: cannons

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Danish drinking was proverbial in England. The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption. Setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” slowly and put it in my own words: Waiting on the battlements, Hamlet says the air bites shrewdly and is very cold. Next, craft. I notice the personified air that "bites," which gives the night a hostile edge. The strongest word is “bites”: it makes the cold feel like an attack, adding to the tension. Then, effect. Why does Hamlet comment on the cold air before the Ghost appears? My answer: Hamlet comments on the cold air before the Ghost appears to fill the nervous wait; the biting air prepares the audience for something supernatural and threatening to appear.

> *The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold* *(Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” slowly and put it in my own words: Waiting on the battlements, Hamlet says the air bites shrewdly and is very cold. Next, craft. I notice the personified air that "bites," which gives the night a hostile edge. The strongest word is “bites”: it makes the cold feel like an attack, adding to the tension. Then, effect. Why does Hamlet comment on the cold air before the Ghost appears? My answer: Hamlet comments on the cold air before the Ghost appears to fill the nervous wait; the biting air prepares the audience for something supernatural and threatening to appear.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* *(Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost? Is the Ghost good or evil?
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost?
Facilitation: Is the Ghost good or evil?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes Hamlet sees the Ghost. Key takeaway: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.
- **Foreshadowing:** Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “in ignorance; but tell / Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, / Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, / Wherein we saw thee” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) Corruption.
- “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Atmosphere.
- “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet sees the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state.
Evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)
Reasoning: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
hearsed (adjective)	placed in a coffin	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	

beckons (verb)	signals someone to come	*It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.*	
cerements (noun)	burial cloths	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	"cerements": Origin of "cerement": French cirement ("waxing"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cerement#Etymology)
wassail (noun)	drinking and revelry	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	
ordnance (noun)	cannons	*A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within.*	
swaggering (adjective)	boisterous; reeling	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	
drunkards (noun)	habitual drinkers	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	
traduced (adjective)	slandered; spoken ill of	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	
swinish (adjective)	like a pig; gross	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	
nipping (adjective)	sharply cold	*It is a nipping and an eager air.*	

Discussion questions

1. What would make you follow a ghost?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about his life? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He does not set it at a pin's fee.
2. What is Claudius doing below? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Drinking and revelling
3. What does the Ghost do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Beckons Hamlet
4. What do Hamlet's friends fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Ghost may lead him to madness or death
5. Who says something is rotten in Denmark? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Marcellus
6. How cold is it? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Very cold
7. Retell the three most important events of “Act I, Scene IV” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
8. Who is on stage in “Act I, Scene IV”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act I, Scene IV” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…” What does “hearsed” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: hearsed: placed in a coffin.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet criticize the drinking? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It damages Denmark's reputation.
2. What does “Act I, Scene IV” suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Indeed?”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
7. How does “Act I, Scene IV” build on “Act I, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What would make you follow a ghost?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or

unusual word choices and their connotations.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet brave or reckless? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet sees the Ghost. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A

judgment of thematic development across the work.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. On setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene IV” treats Hamlet sees the Ghost with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene V” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…”, what does “cerements” most nearly mean?

   A. trickery

   B. burial cloths

   C. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   D. when witches are abroad

   Key: B (burial cloths)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.”, what does “beckons” most nearly mean?

   A. capable of being pierced

   B. signals someone to come

   C. trickery

   D. roundabout methods

   Key: B (signals someone to come)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet: “The air bites _____; it is very cold”

   Key: shrewdly

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A flourish of trumpets, and _____ shot off, within.” Word bank: beckons, cerements, hearsed, ordnance

   Key: ordnance

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How cold is it?

   A. Mild

   B. Very cold

   C. Warm

   D. Hot

   Key: B (Very cold)

6. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say about his life?

   Sample answer: He does not set it at a pin's fee.

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus: “_____ is rotten in the state of Denmark”

   Key: Something

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us _____ and tax’d of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform’d at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.” Word bank: traduced, cerements, hearsed, beckons

   Key: traduced

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do Hamlet's friends fear?

   A. Nothing

B. It is a trick

C. Claudius will see

D. The Ghost may lead him to madness or death

Key: D (The Ghost may lead him to madness or death)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet criticize the drinking?
    Sample answer: It damages Denmark's reputation.
11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Atmosphere.
12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Corruption.
13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene IV”?

    A. The Ghost's revelation

    B. The closet scene

    C. The duel and the deaths

    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    Key: D (Hamlet sees the Ghost)
14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus).
    Sample answer: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.

    A. Simile

    B. Hyperbole

    C. Theme

    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: D (Foreshadowing)
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet: “Angels and _____ of grace defend us”
    Key: ministers
18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.”, what does “wassail” most nearly mean?

    A. drinking and revelry

    B. a sport; diversion

C. a person who attends a royal court

D. treacherous

Key: A (drinking and revelry)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…”, what does “hearsed” most nearly mean?

A. completion; ending

B. open to more than one meaning

C. denial

D. placed in a coffin

Key: D (placed in a coffin)

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax’d of other nations: They clepe us _____, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform’d at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.” Word bank: hearsed, cerements, beckons, drunkards

Key: drunkards

21. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the _____ up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.” Word bank: cerements, hearsed, beckons, swaggering

Key: swaggering

22. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus)

A. The Ghost's farewell.

B. Corruption.

C. Greatness.

D. Polonius's method.

Key: B (Corruption.)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet sees the Ghost.

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

A. Corruption and the state

B. Appearance and reality

C. Action and delay

D. Revenge and justice

Key: A (Corruption and the state)

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Corruption.

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Claudius doing below?

    A. Praying

    B. Holding council

    C. Drinking and revelling

    D. Sleeping

    Key: C (Drinking and revelling)

27. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Polonius's advice.

    C. Hamlet's chance.

    D. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    Key: A (Hamlet sees the Ghost.)

28. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    B. Hamlet's chance.

    C. Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

    D. Atmosphere.

    Key: D (Atmosphere.)

29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene IV”? The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.

    A. Allusion

    B. Setting

    C. Conflict

    D. Plot

    Key: B (Setting)

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet brave or reckless? Argue.

    Sample answer: A reasoned view.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act I, Scene IV”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Atmosphere.

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who says something is rotten in Denmark?

    A. Marcellus

    B. Hamlet

    C. Bernardo

    D. Horatio

Key: A (Marcellus)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 18, 19, 8, 20, 21, 7, 9, 22, 12, 13, 11, 23, 15, 24, 25	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 26, 9, 3, 19, 18, 27, 28, 11, 13, 10, 24, 14, 29, 30, 31	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	19, 6, 17, 8, 2, 13, 12, 10, 22, 28, 29, 15, 14, 24, 16, 32	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	33, 9, 20, 3, 28, 22, 12, 11, 27, 15, 29, 23, 14, 30, 25, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 19, 3, 10, 11, 12, 22, 29, 15, 24, 14, 23, 25, 16, 30, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 3, 9, 22, 28, 11, 13, 15, 24, 29, 14, 23, 31, 16, 25, 30	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 4, 12, 11, 13, 28, 24, 15, 14, 23, 29, 25, 31, 16, 32, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	4, 21, 27, 11, 12, 22, 14, 24, 23, 29, 15, 30, 32, 25, 31, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	4, 21, 13, 27, 11, 10, 23, 14, 24, 29, 15, 25, 30, 31, 16, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	4, 21, 10, 13, 22, 12, 23, 15, 29, 24, 14, 16, 31, 32, 30, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet sees the Ghost? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene IV suggests about Hamlet sees the Ghost. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet sees the Ghost follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene IV and its treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet sees the Ghost in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "cerements" most nearly mean?

   A. sharply cold

   B. burial cloths

   C. like a pig; gross

   D. slandered; spoken ill of

2. *Indeed? I heard it not: then it draws near the season Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk. A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within. What does this mean, my lord?*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene IV"?

A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

C. Worms and kings

D. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

SAT key: 1. B (burial cloths); 2. A (Hamlet sees the Ghost)

Lesson 7: Act I, Scene V

Focus: the Ghost's revelation

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act I, Scene V” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “To me it is clear that Shakspeare meant, in the present case, to represent the effects of a great action laid upon a soul unfit for the performance of it. In this view the whole play seems to me to be composed. There is an oak-tree planted in a costly jar, which should have borne only pleasant flowers in its bosom: the roots expand, the jar is shivered.” (Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, poet and playist (spoken by his character Wilhelm), *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship (1795-96), trans. Thomas Carlyle (1824), Book IV, Chapter XIII, Book IV, Ch. XIII*; public domain). Metaphor analysis: what are the oak, the jar, the shivering? Note that the speaker is Goethe's character Wilhelm, not Goethe in his own voice. *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's response to the Ghost's command ("The time is out of joint"). *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (murder (poison), incest and adultery (described)): The Ghost describes his murder by poison poured in his ear and calls Claudius 'that incestuous, that adulterate beast', with images of lust that will 'prey on garbage'. Gloss 'incestuous' as the period view of marriage to a dead husband's brother; keep discussion on betrayal and revenge.
Student preview: A ghost describes being murdered and uses harsh language about his widow's remarriage.
Suggested language: “What does the Ghost ask of Hamlet, and what does he forbid?”

Teacher only · spoilers

The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.

Background: Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared.

Significance: The command of revenge launches the plot.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: A ghost describes being murdered and uses harsh language about his widow's remarriage.
Prompt: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet swears to remember.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: traitorous — treacherous; howsoever — in whatever way; ambiguous — open to more than one meaning; adulterate — adulterous; sulphurous — of sulphur; hellish. "traitorous": Origin: Anglo-Norman traiterous. "howsoever": Origin: an English formation from how + so + ever.
Words: traitorous: treacherous · howsoever: in whatever way · ambiguous: open to more than one meaning · adulterate: adulterous · sulphurous: of sulphur; hellish

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared. The command of revenge launches the plot. Characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" slowly and put it in my own words: The Ghost tells Hamlet to avenge his foul and most unnatural murder. Next, craft. I notice the superlatives "foul" and "most unnatural," which stress how monstrous the crime was. The strongest word is "unnatural": killing a brother breaks the most basic bonds of nature and family. Then, effect. What does the Ghost demand of Hamlet? My answer: The Ghost gives Hamlet his mission: revenge on Claudius; the word "unnatural" frames the crime as a violation of the natural order, which Hamlet must set right.

> *Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder* (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" slowly and put it in my own words: The Ghost tells Hamlet to avenge his foul and most unnatural murder. Next, craft. I notice the superlatives "foul" and "most unnatural," which stress how monstrous the crime was. The strongest word is "unnatural": killing a brother breaks the most basic bonds of nature and family. Then, effect. What does the Ghost demand of Hamlet? My answer: The Ghost gives Hamlet his mission: revenge on Claudius; the word "unnatural" frames the crime as a violation of the natural order, which Hamlet must set right.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

> *Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me* (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Why does Hamlet feign madness?
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet feign madness?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes the Ghost's revelation. Key takeaway: Hamlet swears to remember.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Remember me."
- **Plot:** Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on."

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet swears to remember.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “for luxury and damned incest. / But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, / Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive / Against thy” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) The Ghost's command.
- “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) The Ghost's farewell.
- “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet) Hamlet's reluctance.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it.
Evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)
Reasoning: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
traitorous (adjective)	treacherous	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous*	“traitorous”: Origin: Anglo-Norman traiterous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/traitorous#Etymology)

		queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!	
howsoever (adverb)	in whatever way	*But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.*	"howsoever": Origin: an English formation from how + so + ever. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/howsoever#Etymology)
ambiguous (adjective)	open to more than one meaning	*Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*	
adulterate (adjective)	adulterous	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!*	
sulphurous (adjective)	of sulphur; hellish	*My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and tormenting flames Must render up myself.*	
witchcraft (noun)	magic; here, seductive power	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!*	
tormenting (adjective)	causing great pain	*My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and tormenting flames Must render up myself.*	
whirling (adjective)	wild and confused	*These are but wild and whirling words, my lord.*	
distracted (adjective)	confused; irrational	*Ay, thou poor ghost, while memory holds a seat In this distracted globe.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does the Ghost say Claudius told people? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: That a serpent stung him in his orchard.
2. How was Old Hamlet killed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poison in the ear
3. Who killed him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
4. What must Hamlet not do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Harm his mother
5. What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Remember him and take revenge
6. What does Hamlet say he may put on? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An antic disposition
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous…" What does "traitorous" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: traitorous: treacherous.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet make his friends swear? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: To keep secret what they saw and his plan.
2. What does "Act I, Scene V" suggest about the Ghost's revelation? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The command of revenge launches the plot.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “And therefore as a stranger give it welcome.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene V”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear…
7. How does “Act I, Scene V” build on “Act I, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Should Hamlet trust the Ghost? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned position.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The command of revenge launches the plot.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene V”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost's revelation. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene V”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene V” treats the Ghost's revelation with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act II, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, Ghost: “Revenge his foul and most _____ murder”
   Key: unnatural
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.”, what does “ambiguous” most nearly mean?
   A. people who carry messages

B. open to more than one meaning

C. picture; portrait

D. chains for the feet

Key: B (open to more than one meaning)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act I, Scene V, Hamlet: “The time is out of joint: O _____ spite, / That ever I was born to set it right”

   Key: cursed

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who killed him?

   A. Fortinbras

   B. Gertrude

   C. Polonius

   D. Claudius

   Key: D (Claudius)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous…”, what does “traitorous” most nearly mean?

   A. a solemn declaration

   B. crafty; shrewd

   C. treacherous

   D. favor and approval

   Key: C (treacherous)

6. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does the Ghost say Claudius told people?

   Sample answer: That a serpent stung him in his orchard.

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How was Old Hamlet killed?

   A. Poison in the ear

   B. Stabbed

   C. Drowned

   D. In battle

   Key: A (Poison in the ear)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say he may put on?

   A. A disguise as a priest

   B. A crown

   C. Armour

   D. An antic disposition

   Key: D (An antic disposition)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous…”, what does “adulterate” most nearly mean?

   A. a person who attends a royal court

   B. graft onto

C. adulterous

D. curse (a mild oath)

Key: C (adulterous)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet)

    A. Acting advice.

    B. Hamlet's reluctance.

    C. The first line: a play of questions.

    D. The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.

    Key: B (Hamlet's reluctance.)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

    A. Claudius's plan.

    B. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    C. Mood: cold and unease.

    D. The Ghost's farewell.

    Key: D (The Ghost's farewell.)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The Ghost's command.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost)

    A. The Ghost's command.

    B. Acceptance before the duel.

    C. Hamlet on humanity.

    D. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    Key: A (The Ghost's command.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene V”? The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.

    A. Hyperbole

    B. Characterization

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Setting

    Key: B (Characterization)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's reluctance.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from an earlier scene to “Act I, Scene V”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Hamlet swears to remember.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “These are but wild and _____ words, my lord.” Word bank: howsoever, whirling, traitorous, ambiguous
    Key: whirling
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My hour is almost come, When I to sulphurous and _____ flames Must render up myself.” Word bank: ambiguous, howsoever, traitorous, tormenting
    Key: tormenting
19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What must Hamlet not do?
    A. Leave Denmark
    B. Pray
    C. Harm his mother
    D. Tell Horatio

    Key: C (Harm his mother)
20. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet make his friends swear?
    Sample answer: To keep secret what they saw and his plan.
21. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The Ghost's farewell.
22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet swears to remember.
    A. Revenge and justice
    B. Action and delay
    C. Death and mortality
    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: A (Revenge and justice)
23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost).
    Sample answer: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"
24. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With _____ of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!” Word bank: ambiguous, witchcraft, howsoever, traitorous
    Key: witchcraft
25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “My hour is almost come, When I to _____ and tormenting flames Must render up myself.” Word bank: sulphurous, ambiguous, howsoever, traitorous
    Key: sulphurous
26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Should Hamlet trust the Ghost? Argue.
    Sample answer: A reasoned position.
27. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene V”?
    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia
    B. The Ghost's revelation

C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

D. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

Key: B (The Ghost's revelation)

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: The Ghost's farewell.

30. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act I, Scene V”? "Remember me."

A. Structure

B. Diction / vocabulary

C. Irony

D. Conflict

Key: B (Diction / vocabulary)

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: The Ghost's command.

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do?

A. Leave Denmark

B. Remember him and take revenge

C. Pray for him

D. Marry Ophelia

Key: B (Remember him and take revenge)

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.”, what does “howsoever” most nearly mean?

A. in whatever way

B. adulterous

C. treacherous

D. open to more than one meaning

Key: A (in whatever way)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 17, 18, 19, 5, 3, 4, 6, 20, 21, 13, 12, 15, 22, 23, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	24, 8, 2, 17, 5, 25, 13, 20, 12, 21, 11, 22, 14, 15, 16, 26	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2

HS Junior	17, 18, 4, 6, 8, 13, 12, 11, 27, 21, 23, 22, 14, 15, 28, 29	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 25, 2, 9, 11, 20, 27, 12, 21, 22, 23, 30, 15, 28, 31, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	32, 24, 1, 27, 21, 13, 20, 23, 14, 30, 15, 22, 26, 16, 29, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	25, 33, 24, 10, 12, 13, 11, 23, 30, 22, 14, 15, 26, 29, 16, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	25, 24, 13, 20, 21, 10, 23, 15, 22, 30, 14, 29, 16, 31, 28, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	25, 24, 10, 27, 13, 20, 22, 30, 15, 14, 23, 26, 31, 16, 28, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	24, 25, 20, 27, 21, 13, 14, 15, 23, 22, 30, 16, 28, 29, 26, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 25, 11, 21, 12, 10, 14, 30, 22, 15, 23, 28, 31, 16, 26, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene V,” how does Shakespeare show the Ghost's revelation? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost's revelation? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene V suggests about the Ghost's revelation. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act I, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost's revelation responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act I, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost's revelation follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene V and its treatment of the Ghost's revelation. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost's revelation in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost's revelation. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “ambiguous” most nearly mean?

   A. wild and confused

   B. confused; irrational

   C. open to more than one meaning

   D. causing great pain

2. *And therefore as a stranger give it welcome. There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, Than are dreamt of in your philosophy. But come; Here, as before, never, so help you mercy, How strange or odd soe’er I bear myself, As I perchance hereafter shall think meet To put an antic disposition on, That you, at such times seeing me, never shall, With arms encumber’d thus, or this headshake, Or by pronouncing of some doubtful phrase, As “Well, well, we know,” or “We could, an if we would,” Or “If we list to speak,” or “There be, an if*

they might," Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene V"?

A. The Ghost's revelation

B. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

C. The duel and the deaths

D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

SAT key: 1. C (open to more than one meaning); 2. A (The Ghost's revelation)

Lesson 8: Act II, Scene I

Focus: Polonius spies on Laertes

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Act II, Scene I" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (slang (sexual), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Some lines in this scene carry period sexual slang; the glosses are hedged. Gloss briefly where needed and move on. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…To youth and liberty. As gaming, my lord. Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbi…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Suggested language: "What does this language show about the speaker?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.

Background: Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life.

Significance: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever right to spy on family? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Prompt: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: indirection.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: windlasses — roundabout methods; indirections — indirect means; brothel — a house of prostitution; fencing — sword-fighting for sport; affrighted — frightened. "indirections": Origin of "indirection": an English formation from indirect + -ion. "affrighted": Origin of "affright": an English formation from a- + fright.
Words: windlasses: roundabout methods · indirections: indirect means · brothel: a house of prostitution · fencing: sword-fighting for sport · affrighted: frightened

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life. Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance. Characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" slowly and put it in my own words: Ophelia tells her father that she has been terribly frightened by Hamlet. Next, craft. I notice the repeated "my lord, my lord," which shows breathless fear. The strongest word is "affrighted": an old, stronger form of "afraid," it shows real shock. Then, effect. Why is Ophelia so frightened? My answer: Ophelia is frightened because Hamlet burst into her room disheveled, pale and silent, staring at her; Polonius takes it as love-madness, while we suspect an act or real distress.

> *O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted* (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" slowly and put it in my own words: Ophelia tells her father that she has been terribly frightened by Hamlet. Next, craft. I notice the repeated "my lord, my lord," which shows breathless fear. The strongest word is "affrighted": an old, stronger form of "afraid," it shows real shock. Then, effect. Why is Ophelia so frightened? My answer: Ophelia is frightened because Hamlet burst into her room disheveled, pale and silent, staring at her; Polonius takes it as love-madness, while we suspect an act or real distress.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

> *By indirections find directions out* (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family? Is Polonius wise or foolish?
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Facilitation: Is Polonius wise or foolish?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Polonius spies on Laertes. Key takeaway: indirection.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.
- **Irony:** Polonius uses lies to find truth.
- **Plot:** Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** indirection.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “meaning: but breathe his faults so quaintly / That they may seem the taints of liberty, / The flash and outbreak of a fiery” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Polonius's method.
- “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) Ophelia's fear.
- “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Polonius's diagnosis.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception.
Evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)
Reasoning: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
windlasses (noun)	roundabout methods	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	

indirections (noun)	indirect means	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	"indirections": Origin of "indirection": an English formation from indirect + -ion. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/indirection#Etymology)
brothel (noun)	a house of prostitution	*Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*	
fencing (noun)	sword-fighting for sport	*Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.*	
affrighted (verb)	frightened	*O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted!*	"affrighted": Origin of "affright": an English formation from a- + fright. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/affright#Etymology)
ecstasy (noun)	madness; frenzy	*This is the very ecstasy of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures.*	"ecstasy": Origin: Old French estaise; earlier Latin ecstasis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ecstasy#Etymology)
beshrew (verb)	curse (a mild oath)	*I am sorry that with better heed and judgment I had not quoted him: I fear'd he did but trifle, And meant to wreck thee; but, beshrew my jealousy!*	
discretion (noun)	good judgment	*By heaven, it is as proper to our age To cast beyond ourselves in our opinions As it is common for the younger sort To lack discretion.*	"discretion": Origin: Old French discretion; earlier Late Latin discrētiō. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/discretion#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever right to spy on family?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20,

21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How was Hamlet dressed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.
2. Where is Reynaldo sent? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Paris
3. What is Reynaldo told to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Spy on Laertes
4. What frightened Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's strange visit
5. What does Polonius conclude? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet is mad for love
6. Whom will Polonius tell? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
8. Who is on stage in "Act II, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act II, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…" What does "windlasses" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: windlasses: roundabout methods.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Polonius's method ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He uses lies to discover truth.
2. What does "Act II, Scene I" suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's

method. On irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “At “closes in the consequence,””, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
7. How does “Act II, Scene I” build on “Act I, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever right to spy on family?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. On plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned reading.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act II, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Polonius spies on Laertes. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act II, Scene I” treats Polonius spies on Laertes with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through

deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act II, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I am sorry that with better heed and judgment I had not quoted him: I fear’d he did but trifle, And meant to wreck thee; but, _____ my jealousy!” Word bank: windlasses, indirections, beshrew, brothel

   Key: beshrew

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “This is the very _____ of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures.” Word bank: brothel, indirections, ecstasy, windlasses

   Key: ecstasy

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.”, what does “brothel” most nearly mean?

   A. one who challenges others

   B. release; acquittal

   C. outdo; defy

   D. a house of prostitution

   Key: D (a house of prostitution)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Reynaldo sent?

   A. London

   B. Wittenberg

C. Paris

D. Norway

Key: C (Paris)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene I, Ophelia: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so _____”

   Key: affrighted

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Reynaldo told to do?

   A. Fight Laertes

   B. Bring money only

   C. Spy on Laertes

   D. Find Hamlet

   Key: C (Spy on Laertes)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom will Polonius tell?

   A. Laertes

   B. Gertrude only

   C. The king

   D. Horatio

   Key: C (The king)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What frightened Ophelia?

   A. Laertes's letter

   B. Her father's anger

   C. Hamlet's strange visit

   D. A ghost

   Key: C (Hamlet's strange visit)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…”, what does “indirections” most nearly mean?

   A. servants who wait on a person of rank

   B. indirect means

   C. slander

   D. in whatever way

   Key: B (indirect means)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia)

    A. The plan.

    B. Ophelia's fear.

    C. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    D. Life versus death.

    Key: B (Ophelia's fear.)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)

    A. Claudius's anxiety.

    B. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

    C. Polonius's diagnosis.

    D. Hamlet's reluctance.

    Key: C (Polonius's diagnosis.)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Polonius's method.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Corruption.

    C. Polonius's method.

    D. The first line: a play of questions.

    Key: C (Polonius's method.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius uses lies to find truth.

    A. Irony

    B. Allusion

    C. Alliteration

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: A (Irony)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Indirection.

    A. Death and mortality

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Action and delay

    Key: B (Appearance and reality)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from an earlier scene to “Act II, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: indirection.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “By heaven, it is as proper to our age To cast beyond ourselves in our opinions As it is common for the younger sort To lack _____.” Word bank: brothel, windlasses, discretion, indirections

    Key: discretion

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene I, Polonius: “This is the very _____ of love”

    Key: ecstasy

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…”, what does “windlasses” most nearly mean?

    A. roundabout methods

    B. full of sores

    C. the purest essence

    D. serviceable; useful

    Key: A (roundabout methods)

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so _____!” Word bank: windlasses, brothel, indirections, affrighted

    Key: affrighted

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.”, what does “fencing” most nearly mean?

    A. the day of final judgment

    B. ministers; preachers

    C. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

    D. sword-fighting for sport

    Key: D (sword-fighting for sport)

22. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Ophelia's fear.

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Polonius's diagnosis.

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene I”? Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.

    A. Plot

    B. Characterization

    C. Simile

    D. Allusion

    Key: B (Characterization)

25. [short · recall · DOK 1] How was Hamlet dressed?

    Sample answer: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Polonius conclude?

    A. Hamlet is ill

    B. Hamlet is faking

    C. Hamlet is spying

    D. Hamlet is mad for love

    Key: D (Hamlet is mad for love)

27. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why is Polonius's method ironic?
    Sample answer: He uses lies to discover truth.
28. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius).
    Sample answer: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's fear.
31. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene I”?
    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia
    B. Polonius spies on Laertes
    C. The Ghost's revelation
    D. Hamlet hides the body

    Key: B (Polonius spies on Laertes)
32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Polonius's method.
33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue.
    Sample answer: A reasoned reading.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 8, 2, 6, 13, 10, 12, 22, 23, 24, 14, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 25, 3, 18, 20, 26, 10, 12, 11, 27, 13, 28, 15, 23, 29, 16	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	20, 1, 26, 4, 3, 10, 27, 11, 12, 13, 14, 28, 15, 24, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	20, 26, 21, 2, 31, 22, 11, 10, 13, 15, 24, 23, 28, 32, 30, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	20, 7, 18, 13, 10, 12, 27, 24, 28, 15, 14, 23, 30, 29, 16, 33	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	26, 18, 17, 11, 27, 31, 22, 28, 15, 24, 14, 23, 29, 33, 30, 32	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
	17, 1, 10, 11, 27, 22, 28, 15, 23, 14, 24, 33, 30, 29, 16, 32	

College Sophomore		recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	20, 2, 22, 11, 13, 27, 14, 28, 15, 23, 24, 33, 30, 16, 32, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	20, 2, 13, 10, 12, 11, 15, 23, 28, 14, 24, 30, 33, 32, 29, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	20, 2, 13, 27, 11, 12, 28, 15, 14, 23, 24, 30, 29, 33, 32, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act II, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show Polonius spies on Laertes? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene I suggests about Polonius spies on Laertes. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act II, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act II, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Polonius spies on Laertes follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene I and its treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Polonius spies on Laertes in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “brothel” most nearly mean?

   A. madness; frenzy

   B. a house of prostitution

   C. good judgment

   D. curse (a mild oath)

2. *At “closes in the consequence,” ay, marry; He closes thus: “I know the gentleman; I saw him yesterday, or t’ other day, Or then, or then; with such, or such; and, as you say, There was a’ gaming; there o’ertook in’s rouse; There falling out at tennis:” or perchance, “I saw him enter such a house of sale,” Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth. See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son. You have me, have you not?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene I”?

   A. Polonius spies on Laertes

   B. The plot against Hamlet

   C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   D. Fortinbras's army

SAT key: 1. B (a house of prostitution); 2. A (Polonius spies on Laertes)

Lesson 9: Act II, Scene II

Focus: Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act II, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (slang (sexual)): 'Fishmonger' may carry the slang sense of a pimp; gloss briefly as an insult and move on.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Suggested language: “What does this language show about the speaker?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.

Background: Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference.

Significance: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why might someone need proof before acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes slang (sexual).
Prompt: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appurtenance — accompaniment; proper ceremony; fishmonger — a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang; doomsday — the day of final judgment; quintessence — the purest essence; apprehension — fear; perception. "appurtenance": Origin: Anglo-Norman apurtenance; earlier Latin appertineō ("to belong"). "apprehension": Origin: Latin apprehensio.
Words: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony · fishmonger: a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang · doomsday: the day of final judgment · quintessence: the purest essence · apprehension: fear; perception

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference. Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests" (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" slowly and put it in my own words: After talking with Hamlet, Polonius says aside that though this is madness, there is method in it. Next, craft. I notice the aside, which lets Polonius speak truth he will not act on. The strongest word is "method": it suggests Hamlet's madness has a pattern and purpose. Then, effect. What does Polonius notice about Hamlet's madness? My answer: Polonius half-sees that Hamlet's "madness" is controlled and pointed, but he still blames love; the line invites the audience to question whether Hamlet is mad or acting.

> *Though this be madness, yet there is method in't (Act II, Scene II, Polonius)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" slowly and put it in my own words: After talking with Hamlet, Polonius says aside that though this is madness, there is method in it. Next, craft. I notice the aside, which lets Polonius speak truth he will not act on. The strongest word is "method": it suggests Hamlet's madness has a pattern and purpose. Then, effect. What does Polonius notice about Hamlet's madness? My answer: Polonius half-sees that Hamlet's "madness" is controlled and pointed, but he still blames love; the line invites the audience to question whether Hamlet is mad or acting.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

> *the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king* (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting? Why does Hamlet need proof?
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet need proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. ("What a piece of work is a man", Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. ("What a piece of work is a man", Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Key takeaway: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.
- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I."
- **Plot:** Hamlet plans The Mousetrap.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests" (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "by time, by means and place, / All given to mine ear" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) Polonius's aside.
- "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet on humanity.
- "the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) The plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth.
Evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appurtenance (noun)	accompaniment; proper ceremony	*Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like entertainment than yours.*	"appurtenance": Origin: Anglo-Norman apurtenance; earlier Latin appertineō ("to belong"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/appurtenance#Etymology)
fishmonger (noun)	a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang	*Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.*	
doomsday (noun)	the day of final judgment	*Then is doomsday near: but your news is not true.*	
quintessence (noun)	the purest essence	*And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.*	
apprehension (noun)	fear; perception	*What a piece of work is a man! how noble in reason! how infinite in faculty! in form and moving how express and admirable! in action how like an angel! in apprehension how like a god! the beauty of the world! the paragon of animals!*	"apprehension": Origin: Latin apprehensio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/apprehension#Etymology)
chanson (noun)	a song; ballad	*Why, "As by lot, God wot," and then, you know, "It came to pass, as most like it was,"— the first row of the pious chanson will show you more; for look, where my abridgement comes.*	
inhibition (noun)	prohibition; ban (on playing)	*I think their inhibition comes by the means of the late innovation.*	"inhibition": Origin: Old French inibicion; earlier Latin inhibitio. (Liber

			et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inhibition#Etymology)
strumpet (noun)	a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all	*O, most true; she is a strumpet.*	
swaddling (noun)	cloths wrapped around a baby	*Hark you, Guildenstern; and you too: at each ear a hearer: that great baby you see there is not yet out of his swaddling-clouts.*	

Discussion questions

1. Why might someone need proof before acting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whose death does the First Player describe? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Priam's, and Hecuba's grief.
2. Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude
3. What does Polonius read? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia
4. What does Hamlet call Polonius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A fishmonger
5. Who arrives at court? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Travelling players
6. What will the play catch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The conscience of the king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.

8. Who is on stage in “Act II, Scene II”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act II, Scene II” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like…” What does “appurtenance” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet doubt the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It may be a devil.
2. What does “Act II, Scene II” suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the structure in this scene shape what we understand about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Aside.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for…
7. How does “Act II, Scene II” build on “Act II, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why might someone need proof before acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act II, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. [DOK

4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act II, Scene II” treats Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act III, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s ·

RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.", what does "fishmonger" most nearly mean?

   A. calmly; steadily

   B. a sport; diversion

   C. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang

   D. a lizard once believed to live on air

   Key: C (a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O, most true; she is a _____." Word bank: doomsday, fishmonger, appurtenance, strumpet

   Key: strumpet

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.", what does "quintessence" most nearly mean?

   A. the purest essence

   B. armies; large groups

   C. full of sores

   D. calmly; steadily

   Key: A (the purest essence)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet call Polonius?

   A. A fishmonger

   B. A friend

   C. A ghost

   D. A king

   Key: A (A fishmonger)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I think their _____ comes by the means of the late innovation." Word bank: inhibition, appurtenance, doomsday, fishmonger

   Key: inhibition

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, Polonius: “Though this be _____, yet there is method in’t”

   Key: madness

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who arrives at court?

   A. Pirates

   B. Travelling players

   C. Fortinbras

   D. Laertes

   Key: B (Travelling players)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Then is doomsday near: but your news is not true.”, what does “doomsday” most nearly mean?

   A. a mine of ore

   B. a solemn declaration

   C. the day of final judgment

   D. causing great pain

   Key: C (the day of final judgment)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act II, Scene II, Hamlet: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the _____ of the king”

   Key: conscience

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene II”?

    A. The closet scene

    B. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    C. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

    D. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

    Key: C (Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet on humanity.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Atmosphere.

    B. Claudius confesses.

    C. Claudius's political move.

    D. The plan.

    Key: D (The plan.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Polonius's aside.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene II”? Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I."

    A. Structure

    B. Tone / mood

    C. Irony

    D. Alliteration

    Key: A (Structure)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from an earlier scene to “Act II, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

17. [short · recall · DOK 1] Whose death does the First Player describe?

    Sample answer: Priam's, and Hecuba's grief.

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?

    A. Hamlet

    B. Claudius and Gertrude

    C. Polonius

    D. Horatio

    Key: B (Claudius and Gertrude)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like…”, what does “appurtenance” most nearly mean?

    A. one who challenges others

    B. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

    C. full of sores

    D. accompaniment; proper ceremony

    Key: D (accompaniment; proper ceremony)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Polonius read?

    A. The Ghost's words

    B. Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia

    C. A letter from Laertes

    D. A play

    Key: B (Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia)

21. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet doubt the Ghost?

    Sample answer: It may be a devil.

22. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Appearance versus reality.

    B. Hamlet on humanity.

    C. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    D. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    Key: B (Hamlet on humanity.)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The plan.

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

    A. Death and mortality

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Action and delay

    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: C (Action and delay)

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius)

    A. Polonius's diagnosis.

    B. Polonius's aside.

    C. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

    D. Gertrude's description.

    Key: B (Polonius's aside.)

27. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act II, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.

    A. Setting

    B. Characterization

    C. Metaphor

    D. Alliteration

    Key: B (Characterization)

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost?

    Sample answer: A judgment.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Polonius's aside.

30. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "What a piece of work is a man! how noble in reason! how infinite in faculty! in form and moving how express and admirable! in action how like an angel! in _____ how like a god! the beauty of the world! the paragon of animals!" Word bank: fishmonger, appurtenance, apprehension, doomsday
    Key: apprehension
31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Hamlet on humanity.
32. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Why, "As by lot, God wot," and then, you know, "It came to pass, as most like it was,"— the first row of the pious _____ will show you more; for look, where my abridgement comes." Word bank: appurtenance, doomsday, fishmonger, chanson
    Key: chanson

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 9, 17, 3, 18, 4, 19, 20, 21, 22, 11, 10, 23, 15, 24, 25	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 18, 20, 6, 5, 3, 21, 11, 26, 12, 22, 15, 27, 14, 28, 16	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	19, 8, 2, 6, 18, 10, 13, 11, 26, 12, 23, 27, 14, 24, 28, 29	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	30, 7, 17, 6, 10, 22, 21, 11, 12, 14, 23, 15, 24, 28, 29, 25	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 6, 9, 10, 13, 21, 11, 14, 27, 15, 24, 23, 16, 29, 28, 25	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	30, 17, 6, 21, 12, 13, 26, 24, 15, 23, 14, 27, 28, 16, 25, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	2, 9, 21, 22, 13, 12, 15, 23, 14, 24, 27, 16, 28, 25, 31, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	30, 32, 22, 26, 10, 13, 14, 23, 27, 15, 24, 16, 28, 31, 25, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	5, 30, 13, 11, 10, 21, 14, 24, 15, 27, 23, 16, 28, 31, 25, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	30, 32, 26, 12, 13, 11, 14, 15, 23, 27, 24, 28, 29, 25, 31, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act II, Scene II," how does Shakespeare show Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and

the players? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene II suggests about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act II, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act II, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene II and its treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Then is doomsday near: but your news is not true.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “doomsday” most nearly mean?

   A. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

   B. the day of final judgment

   C. prohibition; ban (on playing)

   D. cloths wrapped around a baby

2. *Aside. How say you by that? Still harping on my daughter: yet he knew me not at first; he said I was a fishmonger: he is far gone, far gone: and truly in my youth I suffered much extremity for love; very near this. I’ll speak to him again. What do you read, my lord?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene II”?

   A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   B. The plot against Hamlet

   C. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   D. The Ghost on the battlements

SAT key: 1. B (the day of final judgment); 2. C (Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players)

Lesson 10: Act III, Scene I

Focus: 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in “Act III, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Hence we see a great, an almost enormous, intellectual activity, and a proportionate aversion to real action consequent upon it, with all its symptoms and accompanying qualities. This character Shakspeare places in circumstances, under which it is obliged to act on the spur of the moment:--Hamlet is brave and careless of death; but he vacillates from sensibility, and procrastinates from thought, and loses the power of action in the energy of resolve.” (Samuel Taylor Coleridge, poet and critic, *Notes on Hamlet, in The Literary Remains of Samuel Taylor Coleridge, Vol. 2 (1836), "Hamlet"*; public domain). Test the claim: Hamlet kills Polonius instantly in III.iv. Does that contradict Coleridge? *Objective:* Analyze "To be, or not to be" and Hamlet's delay. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Critical voice: “He plays the madman most, when he treats Ophelia with so much rudeness, which seems to be useless and wanton cruelty.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note on Hamlet*; public domain). Seminar: is Hamlet's cruelty to Ophelia strategy, madness, or misogyny? Bring one line for each. *Objective:* Evaluate Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia in the nunnery scene. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, SL.11-12.1

Content note (suicidal thoughts, slang (sexual)): 'To be, or not to be' weighs living against dying. Use the safe-messaging script; keep the discussion on Hamlet's reasoning about action and uncertainty, and name where to find support. 'Nunnery' may also carry the period slang sense of a brothel; present both readings briefly.
Student preview: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What stops Hamlet from acting, according to the speech?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.

Background: Suicide was considered a mortal sin.

Significance: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet contemplates death.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: calumny — slander; nunnery — a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel; pastime — a sport; diversion; inoculate — graft onto; breeder — a mother of children. "nunnery": Origin: an English formation from nun + -ery.
Words: calumny: slander · nunnery: a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel · pastime: a sport; diversion · inoculate: graft onto · breeder: a mother of children

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicide was considered a mortal sin. Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show. Structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "him; / And I'll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England" (Act III, Scene I, Polonius).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "To be, or not to be: that is the question" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Hamlet asks whether it is better to exist or not to exist. Next, craft. I notice the stark, balanced opening, two short infinitives set against each other. The strongest word is "question": it frames life itself as a problem to be reasoned through. Then, effect. What question is Hamlet weighing in this soliloquy? My answer: Hamlet weighs whether enduring life's pain is better than ending it, and concludes that fear of what comes after death makes people suffer on; the speech shows how thought paralyzes his action.

> *To be, or not to be: that is the question (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "To be, or not to be: that is the question" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Hamlet asks whether it is better to exist or not to exist. Next, craft. I notice the stark, balanced opening, two short infinitives set against each other. The strongest word is "question": it frames life itself as a problem to be reasoned through. Then, effect. What question is Hamlet weighing in this soliloquy? My answer: Hamlet weighs whether enduring life's pain is better than ending it, and concludes that fear of what comes after death makes people suffer on; the speech shows how thought paralyzes his action.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

> *Thus conscience does make cowards of us all (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Does Hamlet know he is being watched?
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet know he is being watched?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. (“Thus conscience does make cowards of us all”, Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. (“Thus conscience does make cowards of us all”, Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Key takeaway: Hamlet contemplates death.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
- **Irony:** Claudius and Polonius spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet contemplates death.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “him; / And I’ll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England” (Act III, Scene I, Polonius).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “Madam, it so fell out, that certain players / We o’er-raught on the way: of these we told him; / And” (Act III, Scene I, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Life versus death.
- “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Thinking prevents action.
- “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet's rejection.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis.
Evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
calumny (noun)	slander	*If thou dost marry, I’ll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.*	
nunnery (noun)	a convent of nuns; also	*Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?*	“nunnery”: Origin: an English formation from nun + -ery. (Liber et Libri origin note,

	slang for a brothel		https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/nunnery#Etymology)
pastime (noun)	a sport; diversion	*Did you assay him To any pastime?*	
inoculate (verb)	graft onto	*You should not have believed me; for virtue cannot so inoculate our old stock but we shall relish of it: I loved you not.*	
breeder (noun)	a mother of children	*Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?*	
consummation (noun)	completion; ending	*To die: to sleep; No more; and by a sleep to say we end The heart-ache and the thousand natural shocks That flesh is heir to, 'tis a consummation Devoutly to be wish'd.*	
wantonness (noun)	playful affectation	*I have heard of your paintings too, well enough; God has given you one face, and you make yourselves another: you jig, you amble, and you lisp, and nick-name God's creatures, and make your wantonness your ignorance.*	
remembrances (noun)	keepsakes; love-tokens	*My lord, I have remembrances of yours, That I have longed long to re-deliver; I pray you, now receive them.*	"remembrances": Origin of "remembrance": Old French remembrance; earlier Late Latin rememorārī ("to call to mind"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/remembrance#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet call death? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The undiscover'd country.
2. Who hides to watch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius and Polonius
3. What does Ophelia return? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's gifts
4. Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A nunnery
5. What does Claudius decide? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To send Hamlet to England
6. What does conscience make of us? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Cowards
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "If thou dost marry, I'll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny." What does "calumny" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: calumny: slander.

Inferential / analytical

1. Does Hamlet know he is watched? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A reasoned inference.
2. What does "Act III, Scene I" suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.
7. How does “Act III, Scene I” build on “Act II, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia excusable? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful

evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene I” treats 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet

contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene II" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Life versus death. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a _____ of sinners?" Word bank: breeder, nunnery, calumny, pastime
   Key: breeder
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who hides to watch?
   A. Laertes
   B. Rosencrantz
   C. Gertrude and Horatio
   D. Claudius and Polonius
   Key: D (Claudius and Polonius)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Did you assay him To any pastime?", what does "pastime" most nearly mean?
   A. a sport; diversion
   B. ceremony; show
   C. excellent qualities
   D. the day of final judgment
   Key: A (a sport; diversion)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "My lord, I have _____ of yours, That I have longed long to re-deliver; I pray you, now receive them." Word bank: remembrances, calumny, pastime,

nunnery

Key: remembrances

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “To die: to sleep; No more; and by a sleep to say we end The heart-ache and the thousand natural shocks That flesh is heir to, ’tis a _____ Devoutly to be wish’d.” Word bank: pastime, calumny, consummation, nunnery

   Key: consummation

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, Hamlet: “To be, or not to be: that is the _____”

   Key: question

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “If thou dost marry, I’ll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.”, what does “calumny” most nearly mean?

   A. slander

   B. cannons

   C. full of ominous meaning

   D. picture; portrait

   Key: A (slander)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go?

   A. England

   B. Her father

   C. A nunnery

   D. France

   Key: C (A nunnery)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene I, Hamlet: “Thus _____ does make cowards of us all”

   Key: conscience

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Life versus death.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Thinking prevents action.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] Does Hamlet know he is watched?

    Sample answer: A reasoned inference.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's last words.

    B. Hamlet's chance.

    C. Acceptance before the duel.

    D. Hamlet's rejection.

    Key: D (Hamlet's rejection.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet contemplates death.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Appearance and reality

    D. Death and mortality

    Key: D (Death and mortality)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's rejection.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Ophelia return?

    A. Flowers

    B. A letter

    C. Hamlet's gifts

    D. A ring

    Key: C (Hamlet's gifts)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius decide?

    A. To abdicate

    B. To confess

    C. To send Hamlet to England

    D. To kill Hamlet

    Key: C (To send Hamlet to England)

19. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's last words.

    B. The first line: a play of questions.

    C. First soliloquy.

    D. Life versus death.

    Key: D (Life versus death.)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. Acceptance before the duel.

    B. Hamlet runs.

    C. Thinking prevents action.

    D. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    Key: C (Thinking prevents action.)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet).
    Sample answer: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."
22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene I”? "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Diction / vocabulary
    C. Structure
    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: C (Structure)
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “You should not have believed me; for virtue cannot so inoculate our old stock but we shall relish of it: I loved you not.”, what does “inoculate” most nearly mean?
    A. open to more than one meaning
    B. graft onto
    C. ministers; preachers
    D. prohibition; ban (on playing)

    Key: B (graft onto)
24. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet call death?
    Sample answer: The undiscover'd country.
25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I have heard of your paintings too, well enough; God has given you one face, and you make yourselves another: you jig, you amble, and you lisp, and nick-name God’s creatures, and make your _____ your ignorance.” Word bank: nunnery, wantonness, pastime, calumny
    Key: wantonness
26. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene I”?
    A. The plot against Hamlet
    B. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene
    C. Polonius spies on Laertes
    D. Hamlet hides the body

    Key: B ('To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene)
27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia excusable?
    Sample answer: A judgment.
28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Life versus death.
29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene I”? Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
    A. Characterization
    B. Irony
    C. Point of view
    D. Imagery

Key: A (Characterization)

30. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does conscience make of us?

    A. Saints

    B. Kings

    C. Cowards

    D. Heroes

    Key: C (Cowards)

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Thus conscience does make cowards of us all" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Thinking prevents action.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to "Act III, Scene I". Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Hamlet contemplates death.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 5, 17, 4, 1, 3, 8, 18, 13, 19, 20, 12, 21, 22, 15, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	23, 2, 24, 6, 17, 25, 11, 10, 26, 20, 13, 21, 14, 22, 27, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	23, 6, 18, 24, 9, 26, 13, 19, 12, 11, 22, 21, 15, 29, 16, 27	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 30, 24, 6, 13, 26, 10, 19, 12, 15, 22, 29, 21, 27, 31, 28	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	1, 9, 30, 26, 20, 11, 10, 22, 14, 15, 21, 29, 16, 32, 28, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	1, 7, 5, 19, 10, 13, 11, 21, 22, 29, 14, 15, 28, 27, 31, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	4, 1, 10, 13, 12, 11, 29, 22, 14, 15, 21, 28, 16, 32, 31, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	1, 6, 12, 19, 11, 20, 29, 15, 21, 22, 14, 31, 27, 16, 28, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	1, 5, 12, 11, 13, 20, 22, 14, 21, 15, 29, 16, 27, 28, 32, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 5, 19, 12, 13, 11, 21, 22, 14, 29, 15, 27, 16, 28, 32, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act III, Scene I," how does Shakespeare show 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of

textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene I suggests about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene I and its treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Did you assay him To any pastime?*

As used in the text, what does the word "pastime" most nearly mean?

A. keepsakes; love-tokens

B. completion; ending

C. a sport; diversion

D. playful affectation

2. *Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners? I am myself indifferent honest; but yet I could accuse me of such things that it were better my mother had not borne me: I am very proud, revengeful, ambitious, with more offences at my beck than I have thoughts to put them in, imagination to give them shape, or time to act them in. What should such fellows as I do crawling between earth and heaven? We are arrant knaves, all; believe none of us. Go thy ways to a nunnery. Where's your father?*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene I"?

A. The Ghost's revelation

B. Polonius spies on Laertes

C. The graveyard

D. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

SAT key: 1. C (a sport; diversion); 2. D ('To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene)

Lesson 11: Act III, Scene II

Focus: the Mousetrap

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in "Act III, Scene II" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (sexual innuendo, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Before the play-within-the-play, Hamlet makes bawdy jests at Ophelia ('country matters', 'lie in your lap'). Gloss briefly as public sexual humiliation of Ophelia; do not have students perform it, and discuss how it treats her. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…Is in his retirement marvellous distempered. With drink, sir? No, my lord, rather with choler…."). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Hamlet makes crude, sexual jokes at Ophelia in front of the court.
Suggested language: "Why does Hamlet treat Ophelia this way in public?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.

Background: Plays within plays were popular.

Significance: The test succeeds.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Can art reveal the truth? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: Hamlet makes crude, sexual jokes at Ophelia in front of the court.
Prompt: Can art reveal the truth?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: theater reveals truth.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: candied — sugared; flattering; chameleon — a lizard once believed to live on air; heedful — careful; watchful; dallying — flirting; trifling; purgation — cleansing; also medical purging.
Words: candied: sugared; flattering · chameleon: a lizard once believed to live on air · heedful: careful; watchful · dallying: flirting; trifling · purgation: cleansing; also medical purging

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Plays within plays were popular. The test succeeds. Structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Irony: The Player Queen's vows. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King's ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the" (Act III, Scene II).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells the players to suit their actions to their words and their words to their actions. Next, craft. I notice the mirrored phrasing, which itself matches word and action. The strongest word is "action": it names exactly what Hamlet himself struggles to take. Then, effect. What advice does Hamlet give the actors? My answer: Hamlet advises the actors to suit the action to the word and not overact; his advice about natural acting also comments on his own problem, since he speaks endlessly but does not act.

> *suit the action to the word, the word to the action (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells the players to suit their actions to their words and their words to their actions. Next, craft. I notice the mirrored phrasing, which itself matches word and action. The strongest word is "action": it names exactly what Hamlet himself struggles to take. Then, effect. What advice does Hamlet give the actors? My answer: Hamlet advises the actors to suit the action to the word and not overact; his advice about natural acting also comments on his own problem, since he speaks endlessly but does not act.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

> *The lady doth protest too much, methinks (Act III, Scene II, Queen)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth? Is Claudius's reaction proof?
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth?
Facilitation: Is Claudius's reaction proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. ("The lady doth protest too much, methinks", Act III, Scene II, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. ("The lady doth protest too much, methinks", Act III, Scene II, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes the Mousetrap. Key takeaway: theater reveals truth.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** The Mousetrap play within a play.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
- **Irony:** The Player Queen's vows.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** theater reveals truth.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King’s ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the” (Act III, Scene II).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “a passion to tatters, to very rags, to split the ears of the groundlings, who for the most part are capable of” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) Acting advice.
- “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) Gertrude on the Player Queen.
- “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King) Claudius flees.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius.
Evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen)
Reasoning: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
candied (adjective)	sugared; flattering	*No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.*	
chameleon (noun)	a lizard once believed to live on air	*Excellent, i’ faith; of the chameleon’s dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.*	
heedful (adjective)	careful; watchful	*Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*	

dallying (noun)	flirting; trifling	*I could interpret between you and your love, if I could see the puppets dallying.*	
purgation (noun)	cleansing; also medical purging	*Your wisdom should show itself more richer to signify this to his doctor; for, for me to put him to his purgation would perhaps plunge him into far more choler.*	
recorders (noun)	wooden flutes	*Come, some music! come, the recorders!*	
protestation (noun)	a solemn declaration	*She kneels, and makes show of protestation unto him.*	
witching (adjective)	when witches are abroad	*Tis now the very witching time of night, When churchyards yawn and hell itself breathes out Contagion to this world: now could I drink hot blood, And do such bitter business as the day Would quake to look on.*	

Discussion questions

1. Can art reveal the truth?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet tell the players about acting? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Suit the action to the word.
2. What is the play's name? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Mousetrap
3. Whom does Hamlet ask to watch Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
4. What does Claudius do during the poisoning scene? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Leaves
5. What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: She protests too much
6. What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A recorder
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to

Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.

8. Who is on stage in “Act III, Scene II”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act III, Scene II” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.” What does “candied” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: candied: sugared; flattering.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet trust Horatio? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: He is not passion's slave.
2. What does “Act III, Scene II” suggest about the Mousetrap? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The test succeeds.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about the Mousetrap? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On irony: The Player Queen's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and…
7. How does “Act III, Scene II” build on “Act III, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Can art reveal the truth?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does the Mousetrap prove Claudius's guilt? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned argument.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The test succeeds.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Mousetrap. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful

evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene II” treats the Mousetrap with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act III, Scene III” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Mousetrap? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen): Gertrude on the Player

Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.", what does "candied" most nearly mean?

   A. full of sores

   B. sugared; flattering

   C. servants who wait on a person of rank

   D. fear; perception

   Key: B (sugared; flattering)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.", what does "heedful" most nearly mean?

   A. careful; watchful

   B. servants who wait on a person of rank

   C. burial cloths

   D. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   Key: A (careful; watchful)

3. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet tell the players about acting?
   Sample answer: Suit the action to the word.

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Tis now the very _____ time of night, When churchyards yawn and hell itself breathes out Contagion to this world: now could I drink hot blood, And do such bitter business as the day Would quake to look on." Word bank: chameleon, candied, heedful, witching
   Key: witching

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Your wisdom should show itself more richer to signify this to his doctor; for, for me to put him to his _____ would perhaps plunge him into far more choler." Word bank: candied, purgation, chameleon, heedful
   Key: purgation

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the play's name?

   A. The King's Fall

   B. The Ghost

   C. The Revenge

   D. The Mousetrap

   Key: D (The Mousetrap)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Come, some music! come, the _____!” Word bank: heedful, candied, chameleon, recorders

   Key: recorders

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I could interpret between you and your love, if I could see the puppets dallying.”, what does “dallying” most nearly mean?

   A. it seems to me

   B. last night

   C. flirting; trifling

   D. an herb symbolizing remembrance

   Key: C (flirting; trifling)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius do during the poisoning scene?

   A. Applauds

   B. Leaves

   C. Sleeps

   D. Laughs

   Key: B (Leaves)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Acting advice.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen)

    A. Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.

    B. Death levels the mighty.

    C. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    D. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    Key: C (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King)

    A. Life versus death.

    B. Claudius flees.

    C. Hamlet on humanity.

    D. Atmosphere.

    Key: B (Claudius flees.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene II”? Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.

    A. Point of view

    B. Setting

C. Characterization

D. Theme

Key: C (Characterization)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen).
Sample answer: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, Hamlet: “suit the _____ to the word, the word to the action”
Key: action

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen?

A. She is mad

B. She is beautiful

C. She is honest

D. She protests too much

Key: D (She protests too much)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Excellent, i’ faith; of the chameleon’s dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.”, what does “chameleon” most nearly mean?

A. a punishment; whip

B. graft onto

C. last night

D. a lizard once believed to live on air

Key: D (a lizard once believed to live on air)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene II”?

A. The plot against Hamlet

B. Hamlet sees the Ghost

C. The Mousetrap

D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

Key: C (The Mousetrap)

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene II”? The Mousetrap play within a play.

A. Irony

B. Symbolism

C. Conflict

D. Structure

Key: D (Structure)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Claudius flees.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"
24. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet)
    A. Hamlet's new trust in providence.
    B. Polonius's aside.
    C. The Ghost's farewell.
    D. Acting advice.

    Key: D (Acting advice.)
25. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet trust Horatio?
    Sample answer: He is not passion's slave.
26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Does the Mousetrap prove Claudius's guilt?
    Sample answer: A reasoned argument.
27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern?
    A. A lute
    B. A drum
    C. A recorder
    D. A trumpet

    Key: C (A recorder)
28. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Theater reveals truth.
    A. Action and delay
    B. Revenge and justice
    C. Appearance and reality
    D. Death and mortality

    Key: C (Appearance and reality)
29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from an earlier scene to “Act III, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: theater reveals truth.
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Acting advice.
31. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene II, Queen: “The lady doth protest too much, _____”

    Key: methinks

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 3, 17, 8, 18, 2, 19, 1, 20, 10, 11, 13, 21, 14, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	19, 2, 6, 7, 4, 8, 13, 10, 24, 25, 11, 15, 21, 22, 26, 23	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 19, 5, 27, 17, 20, 24, 13, 12, 25, 22, 14, 28, 21, 29, 26	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 17, 27, 18, 11, 20, 10, 24, 12, 28, 14, 21, 15, 23, 26, 30	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 17, 18, 25, 24, 12, 20, 21, 22, 15, 14, 28, 16, 23, 26, 29	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 4, 7, 24, 25, 10, 20, 21, 28, 15, 14, 22, 30, 23, 29, 26	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 7, 13, 11, 25, 12, 14, 15, 21, 22, 28, 23, 16, 29, 26, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	4, 31, 20, 13, 11, 24, 21, 22, 14, 15, 28, 30, 23, 29, 26, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	4, 5, 13, 20, 25, 24, 14, 28, 21, 15, 22, 30, 26, 29, 23, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	5, 7, 24, 25, 12, 11, 22, 14, 28, 15, 21, 29, 16, 26, 23, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show the Mousetrap? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Mousetrap? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene II suggests about the Mousetrap. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Mousetrap responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Mousetrap follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene II and its treatment of the Mousetrap. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the Mousetrap in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Mousetrap. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “heedful” most nearly mean?

   A. wooden flutes

   B. a solemn declaration

   C. careful; watchful

   D. when witches are abroad

2. *Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her. She kneels, and makes show of protestation unto him. He takes her up, and declines his head upon her neck: lays him down upon a bank of flowers: she, seeing him asleep, leaves him. Anon comes in a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King's ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the King dead, and makes passionate action. The Poisoner, with some two or three Mutes, comes in again, seeming to lament with her. The dead body is carried away. The Poisoner wooes the Queen with gifts: she seems loath and unwilling awhile, but in the end accepts his love. Exeunt.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene II"?

A. The court of Denmark

B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

C. The duel and the deaths

D. The Mousetrap

SAT key: 1. C (careful; watchful); 2. D (The Mousetrap)

Lesson 12: Act III, Scene III

Focus: Claudius at prayer

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Act III, Scene III" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: "He is the prince of philosophical speculators, and because he cannot have his revenge perfect, according to the most refined idea his wish can form, he misses it altogether." (William Hazlitt, essayist and critic, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays (1817), "Hamlet", "Hamlet"*; public domain). Essay lens: perfectionism as tragic flaw. Use "Now might I do it pat." *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's refusal to kill Claudius at prayer. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Content note (incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Hamlet imagines Claudius 'in the incestuous pleasure of his bed'. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…ord; and know thou a more horrid hent: When he is drunk asleep, or in his rage, Or in the inces…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this section includes incest (period view, described).
Suggested language: "What does this language show about the speaker?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.

Background: Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation.

Significance: A key moment of delay.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever wrong to wait? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this section includes incest (period view, described).
Prompt: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet wants damnation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: prolongs — delays; extends; forestalled — prevented beforehand; fetters — chains for the feet; stubborn — unbending; grossly — in a state of gross sin, unprepared.
Words: prolongs: delays; extends · forestalled: prevented beforehand · fetters: chains for the feet · stubborn: unbending · grossly: in a state of gross sin, unprepared

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation. A key moment of delay. Characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Structure: soliloquies of both. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon't" (Act III, Scene III, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Claudius admits his offense is rank and smells to heaven. Next, craft. I notice the image of a crime with a stench that reaches God. The strongest word is "rank": it means foul-smelling and gross, so his guilt is physical and disgusting. Then, effect. What does Claudius's prayer reveal? My answer: Claudius's prayer reveals that he really murdered his brother; he wants forgiveness but will not give up the crown or queen, and Hamlet, seeing him pray, misses his chance for revenge.

> *O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven* (Act III, Scene III, King)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" slowly and put it in my own words: Alone, Claudius admits his offense is rank and smells to heaven. Next, craft. I notice the image of a crime with a stench that reaches God. The strongest word is "rank": it means foul-smelling and gross, so his guilt is physical and disgusting. Then, effect. What does Claudius's prayer reveal? My answer: Claudius's prayer reveals that he really murdered his brother; he wants forgiveness but will not give up the crown or queen, and Hamlet, seeing him pray, misses his chance for revenge.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

> *Now might I do it pat, now he is praying* (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait? Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius at prayer. Key takeaway: Hamlet wants damnation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius's confession and prayer.
- **Irony:** Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
- **Structure:** soliloquies of both.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet wants damnation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon’t” (Act III, Scene III, King).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “pleasure of his bed; / At gaming, swearing, or about some act / That has no relish of salvation in’t; / Then trip him, that” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King) Claudius confesses.
- “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) Hamlet's chance.
- “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King) Claudius cannot pray.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading.
Evidence: "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King)
Reasoning: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
prolongs (verb)	delays; extends	*My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.*	
forestalled (verb)	prevented beforehand	*And what's in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon'd being down?*	
fetters (noun)	chains for the feet	*Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*	
stubborn (adjective)	unbending	*Bow, stubborn knees; and, heart with strings of steel, Be soft as sinews of the newborn babe!*	
grossly (adverb)	in a state of gross sin, unprepared	*He took my father grossly, full of bread; With all his crimes broad blown, as flush as May; And how his audit stands who knows save heaven?*	
repentance (noun)	sorrow for sin	*Try what repentance can: what can it not?*	"repentance": Origin: Old French repentance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/repentance#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever wrong to wait?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius call his offence? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rank; it smells to heaven.
2. What does Claudius try to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Pray
3. Why does Hamlet not kill him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He might go to heaven
4. What does Claudius admit? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Murdering his brother
5. Can Claudius repent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: No, he will not give up his gains
6. Where is Hamlet going next? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To his mother
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days." What does "prolongs" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: prolongs: delays; extends.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's reasoning ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius was not truly praying.
2. What does "Act III, Scene III" suggest about Claudius at prayer? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A key moment of delay.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
7. How does “Act III, Scene III” build on “Act III, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever wrong to wait?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's reason a pretext? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A key moment of delay.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link:

Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius at prayer. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene III” treats Claudius at prayer with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link:

Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene IV" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius call his offence?
   Sample answer: Rank; it smells to heaven.
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is Hamlet going next?
   A. To his mother
   B. To the players
   C. To England
   D. To Ophelia
   Key: A (To his mother)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, Hamlet: "Now might I do it pat, now he is _____"
   Key: praying
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Can Claudius repent?
   A. He refuses to try
   B. Yes
   C. He tries and succeeds
   D. No, he will not give up his gains
   Key: D (No, he will not give up his gains)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.”, what does “prolongs” most nearly mean?

   A. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

   B. delays; extends

   C. cleansing; also medical purging

   D. a mine of ore

   Key: B (delays; extends)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, King: “O, my _____ is rank, it smells to heaven”

   Key: offence

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.”, what does “fetters” most nearly mean?

   A. chains for the feet

   B. drinking and revelry

   C. a bird easily caught; a fool

   D. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

   Key: A (chains for the feet)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Bow, stubborn knees; and, heart with strings of steel, Be soft as sinews of the newborn babe!”, what does “stubborn” most nearly mean?

   A. distresses deeply; tears at

   B. not yet having feathers; immature

   C. unbending

   D. repay

   Key: C (unbending)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does Hamlet not kill him?

   A. Gertrude enters

   B. He might go to heaven

   C. Hamlet is afraid

   D. He is guarded

   Key: B (He might go to heaven)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Another prince who has lost a father.

    C. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    D. Claudius cannot pray.

    Key: D (Claudius cannot pray.)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene III”?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. The Ghost on the battlements

C. Hamlet sees the Ghost

D. Claudius at prayer

Key: D (Claudius at prayer)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet)

A. Hamlet's chance.

B. Greatness.

C. Gertrude's two roles.

D. Hamlet on Gertrude.

Key: A (Hamlet's chance.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why is Hamlet's reasoning ironic?

Sample answer: Claudius was not truly praying.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King).

Sample answer: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene III”? Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.

A. Alliteration

B. Irony

C. Structure

D. Diction / vocabulary

Key: B (Irony)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from an earlier scene to “Act III, Scene III”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: Hamlet wants damnation.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And what’s in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon’d being down?”, what does “forestalled” most nearly mean?

A. tricked; deceived

B. a trap for birds

C. slander

D. prevented beforehand

Key: D (prevented beforehand)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene III, King: “My words fly up, my _____ remain below”

Key: thoughts

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Try what _____ can: what can it not?” Word bank: forestalled, repentance, fetters, prolongs

Key: repentance

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He took my father _____, full of bread; With all his crimes broad blown, as flush as May; And how his audit stands who knows save

heaven?" Word bank: grossly, prolongs, fetters, forestalled

Key: grossly

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Claudius cannot pray.

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act III, Scene III"? Claudius's confession and prayer.

    A. Conflict

    B. Point of view

    C. Characterization

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: C (Characterization)

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's chance.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius admit?

    A. Nothing

    B. Murdering his brother

    C. Fearing Norway

    D. Loving Ophelia

    Key: B (Murdering his brother)

25. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Claudius confesses.

26. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's chance.

27. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King)

    A. Acting advice.

    B. Hamlet's self-reproach.

    C. Ophelia's flowers.

    D. Claudius confesses.

    Key: D (Claudius confesses.)

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Claudius confesses.

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius try to do?

    A. Pray

    B. Escape

    C. Fight

D. Sleep

Key: A (Pray)

30. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet wants damnation.

    A. Appearance and reality

    B. Action and delay

    C. Revenge and justice

    D. Death and mortality

    Key: C (Revenge and justice)

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's reason a pretext?

    Sample answer: A judgment.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 9, 17, 6, 1, 18, 19, 20, 11, 12, 13, 10, 21, 15, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	20, 19, 24, 7, 2, 1, 25, 26, 10, 12, 27, 22, 21, 14, 28, 16	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	20, 6, 17, 9, 2, 13, 11, 27, 25, 26, 14, 22, 15, 21, 23, 16	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	20, 19, 29, 9, 11, 13, 27, 10, 26, 21, 22, 14, 30, 23, 31, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	20, 19, 24, 26, 25, 13, 27, 21, 30, 15, 22, 14, 32, 16, 31, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	20, 19, 2, 25, 13, 11, 27, 21, 15, 22, 14, 30, 32, 16, 31, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 20, 26, 25, 27, 11, 30, 22, 21, 14, 15, 23, 28, 16, 32, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	20, 19, 27, 13, 10, 12, 14, 15, 30, 21, 22, 28, 31, 16, 32, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	20, 19, 26, 27, 25, 11, 21, 30, 15, 14, 22, 28, 23, 32, 31, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	20, 19, 13, 26, 11, 10, 30, 15, 21, 14, 22, 23, 16, 28, 31, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius at prayer? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius at prayer? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene III suggests about Claudius at prayer. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act III, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius at prayer responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius at prayer follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene III and its treatment of Claudius at prayer. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius at prayer in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius at prayer. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “fetters” most nearly mean?

   A. unbending

   B. in a state of gross sin, unprepared

   C. chains for the feet

   D. sorrow for sin

2. *I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range. Therefore prepare you; I your commission will forthwith dispatch, And he to England shall along with you: The terms of our estate may not endure Hazard so dangerous as doth hourly grow Out of his lunacies.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene III”?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

   D. Claudius at prayer

SAT key: 1. C (chains for the feet); 2. D (Claudius at prayer)

Lesson 13: Act III, Scene IV

Focus: the closet scene

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act III, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “The only way of expressing emotion in the form of art is by finding an “objective correlative”; in other words, a set of objects, a situation, a chain of events which shall be the formula of that _particular_ emotion; such that when the external facts, which must terminate in sensory experience, are given, the emotion is immediately evoked.” (T. S. Eliot, poet and critic, *"Hamlet and His Problems," The Sacred Wood (1920), "Hamlet and His Problems"*; public domain). Term lesson: define "objective correlative," then judge: does Gertrude's guilt justify Hamlet's fury in III.iv? *Objective:* Analyze the closet scene and whether Hamlet's emotion matches its object. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, RL.11-12.5

Content note (killing, violence toward a parent (threatened), sexual imagery): Hamlet frightens his mother and kills Polonius through a curtain. Focus on rashness and responsibility. Hamlet's attack on his mother uses graphic sexual imagery ('the rank sweat of an enseamed bed', 'the nasty sty'). Gloss briefly; keep discussion on Hamlet's disgust and on Gertrude's position, not on the images.
Student preview: A man is killed by mistake in this scene. Hamlet uses graphic sexual language toward his mother.
Suggested language: “Who is responsible for Polonius's death?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.

Background: Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room.

Significance: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What happens when anger takes over? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... Content note before we start: A man is killed by mistake in this scene. Hamlet uses graphic sexual language toward his mother.
Prompt: What happens when anger takes over?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Gertrude's guilt.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: cutpurse — a thief; pickpocket; bodiless — without a body; imagined; prating — chattering; penetrable — capable of being pierced; ulcerous — full of sores. “cutpurse”: Origin: an English formation from cut + purse. “bodiless”: Origin: an English formation from body + -less. “ulcerous”: Origin: an English formation from ulcer + -ous.
Words: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket · bodiless: without a body; imagined · prating: chattering · penetrable: capable of being pierced · ulcerous: full of sores

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room. Hamlet finally acts but wrongly. Plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Structure: The Ghost reappears. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew’d in corruption, honeying and making” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” slowly and put it in my own words: Hearing someone behind the curtain, Hamlet cries "A rat?" and stabs through it, killing Polonius. Next, craft. I notice the short, sharp exclamations, as if he acts before he thinks. The strongest word is “rat”: he treats the hidden man as vermin, which shows contempt and rashness. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room show? My answer: Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room shows that after so much delay he can act rashly; he stabs through the arras and kills the wrong man, Polonius, setting off the chain of deaths.

> *How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” slowly and put it in my own words: Hearing someone behind the curtain, Hamlet cries "A rat?" and stabs through it, killing Polonius. Next, craft. I notice the short, sharp exclamations, as if he acts before he thinks. The strongest word is “rat”: he treats the hidden man as vermin, which shows contempt and rashness. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room show? My answer: Hamlet's quick violence in his mother's room shows that after so much delay he can act rashly; he stabs through the arras and kills the wrong man, Polonius, setting off the chain of deaths.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

> *Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over? Is Gertrude guilty?
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude guilty?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the closet scene. Key takeaway: Gertrude's guilt.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet confronts Gertrude.
- **Structure:** The Ghost reappears.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Gertrude's guilt.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew'd in corruption, honeying and making" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "now, what follows: / Here is your husband; like a mildew'd ear, / Blasting his wholesome brother. Have you eyes? / Could you on this" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet kills Polonius.
- "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.
- "O Hamlet, speak no more" (Act III, Scene IV, Queen) Gertrude's shame.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man.
Evidence: "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cutpurse (noun)	a thief; pickpocket	*A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his pocket!*	"cutpurse": Origin: an English formation from cut + purse. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cutpurse#Etymology)
bodiless (adjective)	without a body; imagined	*This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.*	"bodiless": Origin: an English formation from body + -less. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/bodiless#Etymology)
prating (adjective)	chattering	*Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*	
penetrable (adjective)	capable of being pierced	*Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.*	
ulcerous (adjective)	full of sores	*Mother, for love of grace, Lay not that flattering unction to your soul, That not your trespass, but my madness speaks: It will but skin and film the ulcerous place, Whilst rank corruption, mining all within, Infects unseen.*	"ulcerous": Origin: an English formation from ulcer + -ous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/ulcerous#Etymology)
compost (noun)	manure	*Confess yourself to heaven; Repent what's past; avoid what is to come; And do not spread the compost on the weeds, To make them ranker.*	
presentment (noun)	picture; portrait	*Look here, upon this picture, and on this, The counterfeit presentment of two brothers.*	
grained (adjective)	deep-dyed; ingrained	*O Hamlet, speak no more: Thou turn'st mine eyes into my very soul; And there I see such*	

		black and grained spots As will not leave their tinct.	
knavery (noun)	trickery	*There's letters seal'd: and my two schoolfellows, Whom I will trust as I will adders fang'd, They bear the mandate; they must sweep my way, And marshal me to knavery.*	
temperately (adverb)	calmly; steadily	*My pulse, as yours, doth temperately keep time, And makes as healthful music: it is not madness That I have utter'd: bring me to the test, And I the matter will re-word; which madness Would gambol from.*	

Discussion questions

1. What happens when anger takes over?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet think Polonius is at first? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A rat, or the king.
2. Where does Polonius hide? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Behind the arras
3. Whom does Hamlet kill? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius
4. What does Hamlet compare? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two portraits
5. Who sees the Ghost this time? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Only Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet urge Gertrude? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Avoid Claudius's bed
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares

portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.

8. Who is on stage in “Act III, Scene IV”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act III, Scene IV” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…” What does “cutpurse” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice.
2. What does “Act III, Scene IV” suggest about the closet scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the closet scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Ay, lady, ’twas my word.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid…
7. How does “Act III, Scene IV” build on “Act III, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a

quoted line.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What happens when anger takes over?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Gertrude guilty of Claudius's crime? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the closet scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's

epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene IV” treats the closet scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the closet scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's

epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Look here, upon this picture, and on this, The counterfeit _____ of two brothers." Word bank: presentment, cutpurse, prating, bodiless
   Key: presentment
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet compare?
   A. Two letters
   B. Two swords
   C. Two portraits
   D. Two crowns
   Key: C (Two portraits)
3. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet think Polonius is at first?
   Sample answer: A rat, or the king.
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Hamlet kill?
   A. Laertes
   B. Rosencrantz
   C. Claudius
   D. Polonius
   Key: D (Polonius)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who sees the Ghost this time?
   A. Polonius
   B. Both
   C. Only Hamlet
   D. Gertrude
   Key: C (Only Hamlet)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Polonius hide?
   A. In the hall
   B. Under the bed
   C. In a closet
   D. Behind the arras
   Key: D (Behind the arras)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…”, what does “cutpurse” most nearly mean?

   A. coroner

   B. people who carry messages

   C. a thief; pickpocket

   D. completion; ending

   Key: C (a thief; pickpocket)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet: “Thou wretched, rash, _____ fool, farewell”

   Key: intruding

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet urge Gertrude?

   A. Leave Denmark

   B. Kill Claudius

   C. Avoid Claudius's bed

   D. Confess publicly

   Key: C (Avoid Claudius's bed)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene IV”?

    A. The closet scene

    B. Worms and kings

    C. Claudius at prayer

    D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    Key: A (The closet scene)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost?

    Sample answer: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    B. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    C. Hamlet kills Polonius.

    D. Ophelia's flowers.

    Key: C (Hamlet kills Polonius.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act III, Scene IV”? Hamlet confronts Gertrude.

    A. Structure

    B. Characterization

    C. Conflict

D. Point of view

Key: B (Characterization)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet).
Sample answer: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.”, what does “prating” most nearly mean?

A. image; likeness

B. flirting; trifling

C. sword-fighting for sport

D. chattering

Key: D (chattering)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Confess yourself to heaven; Repent what’s past; avoid what is to come; And do not spread the _____ on the weeds, To make them ranker.”
Word bank: cutpurse, bodiless, compost, prating
Key: compost

19. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen)

A. Gertrude's two roles.

B. Atmosphere.

C. Rosencrantz as sponge.

D. Gertrude's shame.

Key: D (Gertrude's shame.)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet)

A. Polonius's method.

B. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

C. Ophelia's fear.

D. Hamlet's divided position.

Key: B (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Gertrude's shame.

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Gertrude's guilt.

A. Appearance and reality

B. Corruption and the state

C. Revenge and justice

D. Action and delay

Key: B (Corruption and the state)

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O Hamlet, speak no more: Thou turn'st mine eyes into my very soul; And there I see such black and _____ spots As will not leave their tinct." Word bank: grained, prating, cutpurse, bodiless
Key: grained

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.", what does "penetrable" most nearly mean?

A. capable of being pierced

B. seamen

C. idle, flirtatious play

D. image; likeness

Key: A (capable of being pierced)

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Gertrude guilty of Claudius's crime?
Sample answer: A reasoned view.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to "Act III, Scene IV". Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Gertrude's guilt.

28. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Mother, for love of grace, Lay not that flattering unction to your soul, That not your trespass, but my madness speaks: It will but skin and film the _____ place, Whilst rank corruption, mining all within, Infects unseen." Word bank: bodiless, cutpurse, ulcerous, prating
Key: ulcerous

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.", what does "bodiless" most nearly mean?

A. deeds transferring property

B. a man whose wife is unfaithful

C. prevented beforehand

D. without a body; imagined

Key: D (without a body; imagined)

30. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Hamlet kills Polonius.

31. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act III, Scene IV"? Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.

A. Plot

B. Personification

C. Metaphor

D. Point of view

Key: A (Plot)

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 1, 2, 18, 5, 9, 7, 6, 19, 11, 20, 13, 21, 14, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	24, 25, 3, 1, 9, 8, 13, 20, 12, 11, 10, 22, 15, 21, 26, 27	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	28, 18, 6, 7, 29, 11, 19, 30, 12, 10, 31, 14, 15, 22, 26, 16	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	28, 18, 9, 6, 13, 12, 19, 11, 30, 15, 14, 31, 21, 16, 23, 26	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	28, 18, 6, 11, 19, 13, 10, 15, 31, 14, 22, 21, 26, 27, 23, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	28, 18, 6, 20, 11, 12, 19, 21, 15, 31, 22, 14, 32, 26, 27, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	18, 1, 11, 30, 10, 20, 22, 14, 31, 15, 21, 32, 23, 27, 26, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 28, 19, 11, 20, 30, 14, 21, 22, 15, 31, 16, 32, 27, 23, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	28, 18, 13, 10, 30, 19, 15, 22, 31, 21, 14, 32, 26, 27, 23, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	28, 18, 20, 19, 13, 11, 22, 15, 14, 31, 21, 16, 26, 27, 32, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show the closet scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the closet scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene IV suggests about the closet scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act III, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act III, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the closet scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act III, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the closet scene follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene IV and its treatment of the closet scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about the closet scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the closet scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial

approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "prating" most nearly mean?

   A. trickery
   B. calmly; steadily
   C. chattering
   D. deep-dyed; ingrained

2. *Ay, lady, 'twas my word. Lifts up the arras and discovers Polonius. Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell! I took thee for thy better: take thy fortune; Thou find'st to be too busy is some danger. Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene IV"?

   A. Hamlet's letter from the sea
   B. The closet scene
   C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return
   D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

SAT key: 1. C (chattering); 2. B (The closet scene)

Lesson 14: Act IV, Scene I

Focus: Claudius hears of Polonius's death

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act IV, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.

Background: Kings feared public unrest.

Significance: Claudius's self-interest.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do leaders handle bad news? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: How do leaders handle bad news?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Claudius worries about public opinion.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Three key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: mineral — a mine of ore; lawless — uncontrolled; discord — conflict; distress. “mineral”: Origin: probably Old French mineral. “discord”: Origin: Old French descort; earlier Latin discordia.
Words: mineral: a mine of ore · lawless: uncontrolled · discord: conflict; distress

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Kings feared public unrest. Claudius's self-interest. Characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the” (Act IV, Scene I, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" slowly and put it in my own words: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet is as mad as the sea and wind fighting over which is stronger. Next, craft. I notice the storm simile, which makes his madness a natural force. The strongest word is "mightier": it shows a struggle with no winner, which fits Hamlet's inner battle. Then, effect. How does Gertrude describe Hamlet's state to Claudius? My answer: Gertrude protects Hamlet by insisting he is mad, not dangerous; the image also shows the turmoil she has seen, and Claudius decides to send him to England.

> *Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier* (Act IV, Scene I, Queen)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" slowly and put it in my own words: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet is as mad as the sea and wind fighting over which is stronger. Next, craft. I notice the storm simile, which makes his madness a natural force. The strongest word is "mightier": it shows a struggle with no winner, which fits Hamlet's inner battle. Then, effect. How does Gertrude describe Hamlet's state to Claudius? My answer: Gertrude protects Hamlet by insisting he is mad, not dangerous; the image also shows the turmoil she has seen, and Claudius decides to send him to England.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

> *My soul is full of discord and dismay* (Act IV, Scene I)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news? Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Key takeaway: Claudius worries about public opinion.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.
- **Plot:** Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Mad as the sea and wind."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Claudius worries about public opinion.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the” (Act IV, Scene I, King).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “As level as the canon to his blank, / Transports his poison’d shot, may miss our name, / And hit the woundless air. O” (Act IV, Scene I).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) Gertrude's description.
- “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) Claudius's anxiety.
- “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I) Claudius's political move.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety.
Evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I)
Reasoning: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
mineral (noun)	a mine of ore	*To draw apart the body he hath kill’d: O’er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.*	“mineral”: Origin: probably Old French mineral. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/mineral#Etymology)
lawless (adjective)	uncontrolled	*Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his*	

		lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, "A rat, a rat!"	
discord (noun)	conflict; distress	*My soul is full of discord and dismay.*	"discord": Origin: Old French descort; earlier Latin discordia. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/discord#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How do leaders handle bad news?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whom does Claudius send to find Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern.
2. Who tells Claudius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. What does Gertrude say Hamlet is? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Mad
4. What does Claudius fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: It could have been him
5. Where will Hamlet be sent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: England
6. How does Claudius describe his soul? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Full of discord and dismay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.

10. Reread: “To draw apart the body he hath kill’d: O’er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.” What does “mineral” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: mineral: a mine of ore.

Inferential / analytical

1. Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: She describes him as mad.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene I” suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Claudius's self-interest.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, “A rat, a rat!””, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene I” build on “Act III, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “How do leaders handle bad news?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does this show about Claudius as king? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Claudius's self-interest.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1,

RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene I” treats Claudius hears of Polonius's death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius fear?

   A. It could have been him

   B. Laertes

   C. The players

   D. Norway

   Key: A (It could have been him)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "My soul is full of discord and dismay.", what does "discord" most nearly mean?

   A. conflict; distress

   B. the day of final judgment

   C. ministers; preachers

   D. a trap for birds

   Key: A (conflict; distress)

3. [short · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Claudius send to find Hamlet?

   Sample answer: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern.

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Claudius describe his soul?

   A. At peace

   B. Full of discord and dismay

   C. Empty

   D. Joyful

   Key: B (Full of discord and dismay)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where will Hamlet be sent?

   A. Wittenberg

   B. France

   C. England

   D. Norway

   Key: C (England)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, "A rat, a rat!"", what does "lawless" most nearly mean?

   A. it seems to me

   B. uncontrolled

C. knowing in advance

D. wild and confused

Key: B (uncontrolled)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Gertrude say Hamlet is?

   A. Guilty

   B. Calm

   C. Mad

   D. Asleep

   Key: C (Mad)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his _____ fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, “A rat, a rat!”” Word bank: mineral, discord, lawless

   Key: lawless

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I: “Come, _____, we’ll call up our wisest friends”

   Key: Gertrude

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's description.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I)

    A. Hamlet's divided position.

    B. Resolve.

    C. Claudius's anxiety.

    D. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    Key: C (Claudius's anxiety.)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

    Sample answer: She describes him as mad.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen)

    A. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    B. Rosencrantz as sponge.

    C. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    D. Gertrude's description.

    Key: D (Gertrude's description.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene I”? Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.

    A. Theme

    B. Symbolism

    C. Plot

D. Alliteration

Key: C (Plot)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Claudius worries about public opinion.

    A. Corruption and the state

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Action and delay

    D. Revenge and justice

    Key: A (Corruption and the state)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's description.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I, Queen: "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the _____"

    Key: mightier

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who tells Claudius?

    A. Gertrude

    B. Hamlet

    C. Laertes

    D. Rosencrantz

    Key: A (Gertrude)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a _____ of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done." Word bank: lawless, discord, mineral

    Key: mineral

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "Come, Gertrude, we'll call up our wisest friends" (Act IV, Scene I)

    A. Laertes.

    B. Ophelia's flowers.

    C. Claudius's political move.

    D. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

    Key: C (Claudius's political move.)

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in "Come, Gertrude, we'll call up our wisest friends" (Act IV, Scene I). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Claudius's political move.

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act IV, Scene I"? Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.

    A. Symbolism

    B. Tone / mood

C. Theme

D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “To draw apart the body he hath kill’d: O’er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.”, what does “mineral” most nearly mean?

A. a mine of ore

B. imagination; a figment

C. last night

D. a bird easily caught; a fool

Key: A (a mine of ore)

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene I”?

A. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

B. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

D. The Ghost's revelation

Key: A (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

26. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety.

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I).
Sample answer: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Claudius worries about public opinion.

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene I: “My soul is full of _____ and dismay”
Key: discord

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] What does this show about Claudius as king?
Sample answer: A judgment.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	

		recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 3, 18, 1, 19, 4, 2, 6, 20, 10, 11, 13, 21, 15, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 19, 24, 9, 6, 4, 25, 26, 12, 13, 10, 27, 14, 15, 23, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	2, 29, 9, 4, 5, 13, 11, 10, 26, 20, 21, 14, 27, 22, 23, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 2, 19, 1, 11, 20, 12, 25, 26, 21, 14, 22, 27, 28, 31, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	19, 3, 29, 12, 11, 20, 10, 27, 22, 21, 15, 14, 28, 30, 16, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	6, 17, 8, 20, 11, 10, 12, 15, 22, 27, 14, 21, 28, 30, 16, 23	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	29, 19, 10, 26, 11, 13, 14, 22, 21, 15, 27, 28, 16, 31, 23, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	19, 9, 25, 12, 20, 10, 15, 22, 27, 14, 21, 30, 31, 28, 16, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	9, 19, 11, 10, 20, 13, 27, 14, 21, 22, 15, 30, 16, 28, 31, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	19, 8, 20, 12, 26, 11, 15, 21, 22, 14, 27, 31, 30, 16, 23, 28	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene I suggests about Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius hears of Polonius's death follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene I and its treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius hears of Polonius's death in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, "A rat, a rat!" And, in this brainish apprehension, kills The unseen good old man.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene I"?

   A. The graveyard

   B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   C. Worms and kings

   D. The Ghost's revelation

SAT key: 1. B (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

Lesson 15: Act IV, Scene II

Focus: Hamlet hides the body

Objective: Students will summarize what happens in Act IV, Scene II (Hamlet hides the body) in 2 sentences and, in a 3-sentence warm-up response, explain how one quoted line from the scene sets up the scene that follows.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.3

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.

Background: Sponges soak and are squeezed dry.

Significance: Hamlet's wit as weapon.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Why use riddles? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....*
> **Prompt:** Why use riddles?
> **Sentence starters:** I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
> **Strong response:** A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the courtiers serve the king.

> **8–16 min · Background and context · I do (8 min)**
> Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
> *Sponges soak and are squeezed dry. Hamlet's wit as weapon. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Plot: Hamlet hides the body. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).*

> **16–20 min · Closure · I do (4 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes Hamlet hides the body. Key takeaway: the courtiers serve the king.*

Total: 20 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
- **Plot:** Hamlet hides the body.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the courtiers serve the king.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “What have you done, my lord, with the dead body” (Act IV, Scene II, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Rosencrantz as sponge.
- “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Riddle.
- “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet runs.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool.
Evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
knavish (adjective)	villainous; sly	*I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.*	“knavish”: Origin: an English formation from knave + -ish. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/knavish#Etymology)
replication (noun)	a reply or answer	*Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what replication should be made by the son of a king?*	

Discussion questions

1. Why use riddles?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.

3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the body and king? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.
2. Who asks where the body is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern
3. What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A sponge
4. How does Hamlet answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In riddles
5. What does Hamlet do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Runs off
6. Whose favour does the sponge soak up? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king's
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear." What does "knavish" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: knavish: villainous; sly.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does the sponge image mean? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Courtiers are used and discarded.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene II" suggest about Hamlet hides the body? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's wit as weapon.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance, his rewards, his authorities.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene II” build on “Act IV, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why use riddles?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On plot: Hamlet hides the body. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet mad here? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet's wit as weapon.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet hides the body. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with

criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene II” treats Hamlet hides the body with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene III” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose favour does the sponge soak up?

   A. Polonius's

   B. Hamlet's

   C. The king's

   D. Gertrude's

   Key: C (The king's)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.", what does "knavish" most nearly mean?

   A. adulterous

   B. calmly; steadily

   C. villainous; sly

   D. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

   Key: C (villainous; sly)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet do at the end?

   A. Confesses

   B. Runs off

   C. Weeps

   D. Fights

   Key: B (Runs off)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what replication should be made by the son of a king?", what does "replication" most nearly mean?

   A. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang

   B. good judgment

   C. chattering

   D. a reply or answer

   Key: D (a reply or answer)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I am glad of it: a _____ speech sleeps in a foolish ear." Word bank: knavish, replication

   Key: knavish

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's _____"

   Key: countenance

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz?

   A. A friend

   B. A sponge

   C. A fool

   D. A rat

   Key: B (A sponge)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Hamlet answer?

   A. Silently

   B. In riddles

   C. With a letter

   D. Directly

   Key: B (In riddles)

9. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say about the body and king?

   Sample answer: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Riddle.
11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene II”?
    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia
    B. Hamlet hides the body
    C. Hamlet sees the Ghost
    D. Worms and kings

    Key: B (Hamlet hides the body)
12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does the sponge image mean?
    Sample answer: Courtiers are used and discarded.
13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)
    A. Mood: cold and unease.
    B. Gertrude on the Player Queen.
    C. Claudius's anxiety.
    D. Riddle.

    Key: D (Riddle.)
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
    A. Irony
    B. Point of view
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Structure

    Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.
    A. Diction / vocabulary
    B. Setting
    C. Characterization
    D. Personification

    Key: C (Characterization)
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what _____ should be made by the son of a king?” Word bank: replication, knavish
    Key: replication

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who asks where the body is?

    A. Gertrude

    B. Horatio

    C. Claudius

    D. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern

    Key: D (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern)

19. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Claudius confesses.

    C. Rosencrantz as sponge.

    D. Claudius flees.

    Key: C (Rosencrantz as sponge.)

20. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The courtiers serve the king.

    A. Corruption and the state

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Action and delay

    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: A (Corruption and the state)

23. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Polonius's method.

    B. Appearance versus reality.

    C. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

    D. Hamlet runs.

    Key: D (Hamlet runs.)

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet runs.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the courtiers serve the king.

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge.
27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet mad here?
    Sample answer: A reasoned view.
28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Riddle.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 1, 17, 7, 2, 18, 8, 9, 19, 11, 20, 13, 14, 21, 22, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 3, 7, 5, 1, 2, 10, 20, 13, 12, 23, 22, 14, 24, 16, 25	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 6, 3, 5, 9, 13, 19, 10, 11, 12, 15, 22, 24, 21, 26, 25	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 6, 9, 3, 20, 12, 13, 19, 10, 21, 14, 15, 22, 26, 25, 27	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 17, 18, 11, 19, 23, 12, 21, 22, 14, 15, 24, 25, 26, 16, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	17, 5, 7, 23, 12, 10, 13, 22, 21, 15, 14, 24, 16, 26, 25, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 17, 12, 11, 20, 19, 22, 24, 14, 21, 15, 27, 28, 25, 16, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	5, 17, 10, 20, 12, 11, 14, 21, 22, 24, 15, 16, 27, 28, 25, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	5, 17, 19, 20, 10, 12, 22, 14, 24, 21, 15, 27, 25, 16, 28, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	5, 17, 23, 11, 20, 13, 22, 14, 15, 21, 24, 28, 16, 27, 26, 25	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene II," how does Shakespeare show Hamlet hides the body? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet hides the body? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene II develops the idea of Hamlet hides the body. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene II suggests about Hamlet hides the body. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet hides the body responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet hides the body follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene II and its treatment of Hamlet hides the body. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet hides the body in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet hides the body. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance, his rewards, his authorities. But such officers do the king best service in the end: he keeps them, like an ape, in the corner of his jaw; first mouthed, to be last swallowed: when he needs what you have gleaned, it is but squeezing you, and, sponge, you shall be dry again.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene II"?

   A. The graveyard

   B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

   C. Hamlet hides the body

   D. Claudius at prayer

SAT key: 1. C (Hamlet hides the body)

Lesson 16: Act IV, Scene III

Focus: worms and kings

Objective: Students will analyze how diction / vocabulary develops in "Act IV, Scene III" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.

Background: England owed Denmark tribute.

Significance: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death do to rank? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because....
Prompt: What does death do to rank?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: kings and beggars.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Four key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appliance — remedy; convocation — an assembly; scourge — a punishment; whip; politic — crafty; shrewd. "appliance": Origin: an English formation from apply + -ance. "convocation": Origin: Old French convocation; earlier Latin convocatio.
Words: appliance: remedy · convocation: an assembly · scourge: a punishment; whip · politic: crafty; shrewd

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
England owed Denmark tribute. Mortality and Claudius's treachery. Diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Watch for acting and seeming: "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: "all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or" (Act IV, Scene III, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Claudius that worms are the only true emperors, since all bodies end as their food. Next, craft. I notice the dark joke, turning "emperor" into a word for worms. The strongest word is "emperor": it mocks royal power, since even kings feed worms. Then, effect. What is Hamlet saying about death and kings? My answer: Hamlet's wit hides a threat and a truth: Claudius too will die and rot; death levels everyone, a theme that grows in the graveyard scene.

> *Your worm is your only emperor for diet* *(Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Claudius that worms are the only true emperors, since all bodies end as their food. Next, craft. I notice the dark joke, turning "emperor" into a word for worms. The strongest word is "emperor": it mocks royal power, since even kings feed worms. Then, effect. What is Hamlet saying about death and kings? My answer: Hamlet's wit hides a threat and a truth: Claudius too will die and rot; death levels everyone, a theme that grows in the graveyard scene.

40–50 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (10 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

> *a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar* *(Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

50–55 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (5 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."
Task: Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

55–60 min · Discussion · We do (5 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does death do to rank? Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?
Anchor question: What does death do to rank?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?

60–67 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. ("a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar", Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. ("a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar", Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

67–70 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how diction / vocabulary shapes worms and kings. Key takeaway: kings and beggars.

Total: 70 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Diction / vocabulary:** Worms and kings.
- **Plot:** Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
- **Characterization:** Claudius's soliloquy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** kings and beggars.

Symbols and motifs

- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or” (Act IV, Scene III, King).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “Where the dead body is bestow’d, my lord, / We cannot get from him” (Act IV, Scene III, Rosencrantz).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Death levels all.
- “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Mortality.
- “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King) Claudius's plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death.
Evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appliance (noun)	remedy	*To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*	“appliance”: Origin: an English formation from apply + -ance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/appliance#Etymology)
convocation (noun)	an assembly	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.*	“convocation”: Origin: Old French convocation; earlier Latin convocatio. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://

			en.wiktionary.org/wiki/convocation#Etymology)
scourge (noun)	a punishment; whip	*Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He's loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where 'tis so, the offender's scourge is weigh'd, But never the offence.*	
politic (adjective)	crafty; shrewd	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e'en at him.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does death do to rank?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What will a king do through a beggar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Go a progress through his guts.
2. Where does Hamlet say Polonius is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: At supper, being eaten
3. What does Claudius order? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet's death in England
4. What does Hamlet say about worms? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Your worm is your only emperor for diet
5. Where is the body? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Up the stairs into the lobby
6. What does Claudius call Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Like the hectic in my blood
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.

8. Who is on stage in “Act IV, Scene III”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act IV, Scene III” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.” What does “appliance” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: appliance: remedy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Claudius's letter significant? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: It shows his intent to kill.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene III” suggest about worms and kings? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.
3. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about worms and kings? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. On plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “I have sent to seek him, and to find the body.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene III”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene III” build on “Act IV, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about

death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What does death do to rank?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Hamlet suspect the plot? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Mortality and Claudius's treachery.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of worms and kings. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the diction / vocabulary in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. On diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene III” treats worms and kings with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about worms and kings? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [short · recall · DOK 1] What will a king do through a beggar?
   Sample answer: Go a progress through his guts.
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet: "a king may go a _____ through the guts of a beggar"
   Key: progress
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain _____ of politic worms are e'en at him." Word bank: politic, convocation, scourge, appliance
   Key: convocation
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say about worms?
   A. Worms are friends
   B. Worms fear kings
   C. Your worm is your only emperor for diet
   D. Nothing

   Key: C (Your worm is your only emperor for diet)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet: "Your worm is your only _____ for diet"
   Key: emperor
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.", what does "appliance" most nearly mean?
   A. remedy
   B. open to more than one meaning
   C. sharply cold
   D. a long-handled spear with a broad blade

   Key: A (remedy)
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is the body?
   A. Up the stairs into the lobby
   B. In the garden
   C. In the chapel
   D. In the river

   Key: A (Up the stairs into the lobby)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He’s loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where ’tis so, the offender’s scourge is weigh’d, But never the offence.”, what does “scourge” most nearly mean?

    A. an outbreak of trouble

    B. a punishment; whip

    C. quickness; speed

    D. picture; portrait

    Key: B (a punishment; whip)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.”, what does “convocation” most nearly mean?

    A. an assembly

    B. calmly; steadily

    C. cloths wrapped around a baby

    D. chattering

    Key: A (an assembly)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why is Claudius's letter significant?

    Sample answer: It shows his intent to kill.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King)

    A. Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.

    B. The Ghost's command.

    C. Claudius's plan.

    D. Atmosphere.

    Key: C (Claudius's plan.)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene III”?

    A. Hamlet's letter from the sea

    B. Worms and kings

    C. The graveyard

    D. Polonius spies on Laertes

    Key: B (Worms and kings)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Mortality.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Kings and beggars.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Death and mortality

    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: C (Death and mortality)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Claudius's plan.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene III”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: kings and beggars.
17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate _____ are relieved, Or not at all.” Word bank: scourge, appliance, politic, convocation
    Key: appliance
18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Hamlet say Polonius is?
    A. In heaven
    B. In the river
    C. In England
    D. At supper, being eaten
    Key: D (At supper, being eaten)
19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.”, what does “politic” most nearly mean?
    A. crafty; shrewd
    B. flirting; trifling
    C. contrary; opposed
    D. when witches are abroad
    Key: A (crafty; shrewd)
20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius call Hamlet?
    A. A son
    B. A friend
    C. Like the hectic in my blood
    D. A traitor
    Key: C (Like the hectic in my blood)
21. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)
    A. Claudius confesses.
    B. Another prince who has lost a father.
    C. Death levels all.
    D. Acceptance before the duel.
    Key: C (Death levels all.)
22. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Death levels all.

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet).
    Sample answer: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."
24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."
25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius order?
    A. Hamlet's death in England
    B. Hamlet's crowning
    C. Polonius's burial only
    D. Laertes's return

    Key: A (Hamlet's death in England)
26. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet)
    A. Horatio's farewell.
    B. Greatness.
    C. Hamlet on humanity.
    D. Mortality.

    Key: D (Mortality.)
27. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene III”? Worms and kings.
    A. Foreshadowing
    B. Characterization
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Imagery

    Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)
28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Does Hamlet suspect the plot?
    Sample answer: A judgment.
29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene III”? Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
    A. Plot
    B. Conflict
    C. Personification
    D. Irony

    Key: A (Plot)
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Death levels all.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Mortality.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 17, 9, 4, 18, 6, 19, 20, 12, 10, 21, 22, 15, 14, 23, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 25, 3, 17, 5, 4, 26, 12, 22, 11, 21, 23, 27, 15, 24, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 3, 20, 7, 4, 11, 12, 21, 10, 22, 29, 23, 14, 15, 28, 16	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	17, 9, 7, 3, 12, 10, 11, 13, 22, 15, 27, 29, 14, 30, 16, 28	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 9, 17, 22, 13, 21, 26, 14, 23, 27, 29, 15, 24, 28, 16, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 17, 6, 11, 22, 21, 12, 14, 27, 23, 29, 15, 31, 30, 28, 24	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	17, 3, 22, 13, 26, 21, 14, 15, 27, 23, 29, 28, 30, 24, 31, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	17, 3, 13, 26, 11, 10, 14, 23, 27, 15, 29, 24, 31, 30, 28, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	17, 3, 10, 12, 13, 26, 29, 15, 23, 27, 14, 30, 28, 24, 16, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	3, 17, 12, 26, 22, 10, 15, 23, 29, 27, 14, 28, 30, 31, 16, 24	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene III," how does Shakespeare show worms and kings? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of worms and kings? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of worms and kings. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene III suggests about worms and kings. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses diction / vocabulary in Act IV, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of worms and kings. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of worms and kings responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of worms and kings follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene III and its treatment of worms and kings. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about worms and kings in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of worms and kings. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

As used in the text, what does the word "appliance" most nearly mean?

A. remedy

B. a punishment; whip

C. an assembly

D. crafty; shrewd

2. *I have sent to seek him, and to find the body. How dangerous is it that this man goes loose! Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He's loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where 'tis so, the offender's scourge is weigh'd, But never the offence. To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene III"?

A. The plot against Hamlet

B. The Ghost's revelation

C. The closet scene

D. Worms and kings

SAT key: 1. A (remedy); 2. D (Worms and kings)

Lesson 17: Act IV, Scene IV

Focus: Fortinbras's army

Objective: Students will analyze how structure develops in “Act IV, Scene IV” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “This exclamation and this question both show the same thing, that the whole story turns upon the peculiar character of the hero.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III*; public domain). Thought experiment (Bradley's own): swap Hamlet for Fortinbras or Laertes. How short is the play? Context: Bradley is answering the question why Hamlet did not obey the Ghost at once. *Objective:* Analyze Hamlet's self-reproach on seeing Fortinbras's army. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3

Teacher only · spoilers

Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.

Background: Fortinbras as foil.

Significance: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is fighting for honour admirable? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet resolves.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Four key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: imposthume — an abscess; internal swelling; oblivion — forgetfulness; capability — power; capacity; frontier — a border region. “oblivion”: Origin: Anglo-Norman oblivion; earlier Latin oblīviō (“forgetfulness”).
Words: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling · oblivion: forgetfulness · capability: power; capacity · frontier: a border region

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fortinbras as foil. A turning point in Hamlet's resolve. Structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Watch for death and the grave: skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "How all occasions do inform against me" slowly and put it in my own words: Seeing Fortinbras's army march to fight for a tiny piece of land, Hamlet says every event accuses him. Next, craft. I notice the personified "occasions" that inform against him like witnesses. The strongest word is "inform": it means accuse, so the world itself testifies against his delay. Then, effect. What does Hamlet see in Fortinbras's army? My answer: In Fortinbras's army Hamlet sees thousands of soldiers ready to die for a worthless patch of ground; shamed, he resolves that his thoughts will be bloody, which sharpens his sense of failure.

> *How all occasions do inform against me* (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "How all occasions do inform against me" slowly and put it in my own words: Seeing Fortinbras's army march to fight for a tiny piece of land, Hamlet says every event accuses him. Next, craft. I notice the personified "occasions" that inform against him like witnesses. The strongest word is "inform": it means accuse, so the world itself testifies against his delay. Then, effect. What does Hamlet see in Fortinbras's army? My answer: In Fortinbras's army Hamlet sees thousands of soldiers ready to die for a worthless patch of ground; shamed, he resolves that his thoughts will be bloody, which sharpens his sense of failure.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

> *Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument* (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable? Is Fortinbras admirable?
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Facilitation: Is Fortinbras admirable?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes Fortinbras's army. Key takeaway: Hamlet resolves.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."
- **Characterization:** Fortinbras as foil.
- **Conflict:** Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet resolves.

Symbols and motifs

- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Hamlet's self-reproach.
- “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Greatness.
- “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Resolve.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution.
Evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
imposthume (noun)	an abscess; internal swelling	*Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*	
oblivion (noun)	forgetfulness	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And*	“oblivion”: Origin: Anglo-Norman oblivion; earlier Latin oblīviō (“forgetfulness”). (Liber et Libri origin

		ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"	note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/oblivion#Etymology)
capability (noun)	power; capacity	*Sure, he that made us with such large discourse, Looking before and after, gave us not That capability and god-like reason To fust in us unused.*	
frontier (noun)	a border region	*Goes it against the main of Poland, sir, Or for some frontier?*	

Discussion questions

1. Is fighting for honour admirable?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many men will die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Twenty thousand.
2. Whose army passes? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras's
3. What are they fighting for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A little patch of ground
4. How does Hamlet react? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He berates his delay
5. What does Hamlet vow? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Bloody thoughts
6. Who tells Hamlet about the war? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A Captain
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene IV", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene IV" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.

10. Reread: “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.” What does “imposthume” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling.

Inferential / analytical

1. What makes Fortinbras a foil? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: He acts decisively.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene IV” suggest about Fortinbras's army? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene IV” build on “Act IV, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is fighting for honour admirable?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does conflict appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Fortinbras's war admirable or absurd? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Fortinbras's army. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene IV” treats Fortinbras's army with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene V” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)

- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [short · recall · DOK 1] How many men will die?
   Sample answer: Twenty thousand.
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Sure, he that made us with such large discourse, Looking before and after, gave us not That capability and god-like reason To fust in us unused.", what does "capability" most nearly mean?
   A. denial
   B. closely united
   C. a builder of ships
   D. power; capacity
   Key: D (power; capacity)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who tells Hamlet about the war?
   A. Fortinbras
   B. Horatio
   C. Rosencrantz
   D. A Captain
   Key: D (A Captain)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Now, whether it be Bestial _____, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"" Word bank: capability, imposthume, oblivion, frontier
   Key: oblivion
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet: "O, from this time forth, / My _____ be bloody, or be nothing worth"
   Key: thoughts
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say…", what does "oblivion" most nearly mean?
   A. calmly; steadily
   B. ceremony; show
   C. forgetfulness
   D. following
   Key: C (forgetfulness)
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Goes it against the main of Poland, sir, Or for some frontier?", what does "frontier" most nearly mean?
   A. denial
   B. a border region
   C. quickness; speed

D. light slender swords

Key: B (a border region)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What are they fighting for?

   A. A little patch of ground

   B. A princess

   C. Gold

   D. Denmark

   Key: A (A little patch of ground)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the _____ of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.” Word bank: imposthume, capability, oblivion, frontier

   Key: imposthume

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What makes Fortinbras a foil?

    Sample answer: He acts decisively.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

    B. Horatio's farewell.

    C. Hamlet's self-reproach.

    D. Thinking prevents action.

    Key: C (Hamlet's self-reproach.)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Greatness.

    B. Mortality.

    C. First soliloquy.

    D. Ophelia's fear.

    Key: A (Greatness.)

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.

    B. Horatio's farewell.

    C. Claudius cannot pray.

    D. Resolve.

    Key: D (Resolve.)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet resolves.

    A. Action and delay

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Death and mortality

    D. Revenge and justice

    Key: A (Action and delay)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Greatness.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet: "Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great _____"

    Key: argument

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet vow?

    A. Bloody thoughts

    B. To confess

    C. Peace

    D. To flee

    Key: A (Bloody thoughts)

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Hamlet react?

    A. He weeps

    B. He laughs

    C. He berates his delay

    D. He joins

    Key: C (He berates his delay)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene IV"?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. Fortinbras's army

    C. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    D. Polonius spies on Laertes

    Key: B (Fortinbras's army)

21. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Greatness.

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act IV, Scene IV"? Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."

    A. Imagery

    B. Symbolism

    C. Structure

    D. Characterization

Key: C (Structure)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Resolve.

24. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene IV”? Fortinbras as foil.
    A. Characterization
    B. Theme
    C. Conflict
    D. Tone / mood

    Key: A (Characterization)

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet: “How all _____ do inform against me”
    Key: occasions

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene IV”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Hamlet resolves.

28. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Hamlet's self-reproach.

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose army passes?
    A. England's
    B. Fortinbras's
    C. Claudius's
    D. Laertes's

    Key: B (Fortinbras's)

30. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.”, what does “imposthume” most nearly mean?
    A. the purest essence
    B. an abscess; internal swelling
    C. a person without moral restraint
    D. imagination; a figment

    Key: B (an abscess; internal swelling)

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Fortinbras's war admirable or absurd?
    Sample answer: A judgment.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 8, 7, 4, 17, 5, 18, 19, 20, 13, 10, 21, 22, 23, 24, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	25, 17, 6, 18, 7, 8, 10, 13, 11, 21, 20, 14, 23, 22, 26, 27	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 25, 9, 6, 8, 10, 21, 13, 28, 11, 14, 24, 15, 23, 27, 26	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	9, 29, 17, 30, 20, 10, 21, 28, 11, 15, 23, 24, 14, 26, 31, 27	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	9, 4, 18, 12, 21, 11, 28, 14, 15, 24, 23, 22, 16, 32, 31, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 25, 7, 20, 11, 13, 28, 14, 23, 22, 15, 24, 16, 32, 26, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	25, 9, 20, 13, 12, 21, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24, 32, 16, 31, 26, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	9, 4, 11, 10, 28, 12, 23, 14, 24, 22, 15, 26, 27, 16, 32, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	9, 4, 20, 21, 12, 28, 23, 22, 24, 14, 15, 16, 32, 26, 31, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	5, 9, 13, 11, 12, 21, 23, 15, 14, 24, 22, 26, 32, 16, 27, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene IV,” how does Shakespeare show Fortinbras's army? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Fortinbras's army? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene IV suggests about Fortinbras's army. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act IV, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Fortinbras's army responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Fortinbras's army follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene IV and its treatment of Fortinbras's army. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Fortinbras's army in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Fortinbras's army. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “imposthume” most nearly mean?

   A. an abscess; internal swelling

   B. a border region

   C. forgetfulness

   D. power; capacity

2. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies. I humbly thank you, sir.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene IV"?

A. Hamlet hides the body

B. Fortinbras's army

C. The Ghost's revelation

D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. A (an abscess; internal swelling); 2. B (Fortinbras's army)

Lesson 18: Act IV, Scene V

Focus: Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Act IV, Scene V" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (mental illness, sexual content in songs): Ophelia's madness includes bawdy songs. Present her grief with care and discuss how the court responds to her.
Student preview: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Suggested language: "What do the people around Ophelia do, or fail to do?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.

Background: Flowers carried symbolic meanings.

Significance: Laertes foils Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do people show grief? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Prompt: How do people show grief?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes acts at once.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: juggled — tricked; deceived; cuckold — a man whose wife is unfaithful; hatchment — a coat of arms displayed at a funeral; pelican — a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood; rosemary — an herb symbolizing remembrance. "rosemary": Origin: Middle English rosmarine; earlier Old French rosmarin.
Words: juggled: tricked; deceived · cuckold: a man whose wife is unfaithful · hatchment: a coat of arms displayed at a funeral · pelican: a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood · rosemary: an herb symbolizing remembrance

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Flowers carried symbolic meanings. Laertes foils Hamlet. Characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Plot: Laertes demands revenge. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to" (Act IV, Scene V, Queen).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" slowly and put it in my own words: In her madness, Ophelia hands out flowers, giving rosemary for remembrance. Next, craft. I notice the gentle, song-like speech that hides deep grief. The strongest word is "remembrance": it names memory, which haunts her after her father's death. Then, effect. What does Ophelia's flower speech show? My answer: Ophelia's madness shows the cost of the court's violence; each flower carries a meaning, so her broken speech still speaks truth about loss and betrayal.

> *There's rosemary, that's for remembrance* (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" slowly and put it in my own words: In her madness, Ophelia hands out flowers, giving rosemary for remembrance. Next, craft. I notice the gentle, song-like speech that hides deep grief. The strongest word is "remembrance": it names memory, which haunts her after her father's death. Then, effect. What does Ophelia's flower speech show? My answer: Ophelia's madness shows the cost of the court's violence; each flower carries a meaning, so her broken speech still speaks truth about loss and betrayal.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

> *To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil* (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do people show grief? Compare Laertes and Hamlet.
Anchor question: How do people show grief?
Facilitation: Compare Laertes and Hamlet.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. ("To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil", Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. ("To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil", Act IV, Scene V, Laertes). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Key takeaway: Laertes acts at once.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.
- **Symbolism:** Ophelia's flowers.
- **Plot:** Laertes demands revenge.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes acts at once.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin’s true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to” (Act IV, Scene V, Queen).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “watch, I pray you. Exit Horatio. / O, this is the poison of deep grief; it springs / All from her father’s death. O” (Act IV, Scene V, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) Ophelia's flowers.
- “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) Laertes.
- “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King) Claudius.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.
Evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes)
Reasoning: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
juggled (verb)	tricked; deceived	*I’ll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!*	
cuckold (noun)	a man whose wife is unfaithful	*That drop of blood that’s calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.*	

hatchment (noun)	a coat of arms displayed at a funeral	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*	
pelican (noun)	a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood	*To his good friends thus wide I'll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.*	
rosemary (noun)	an herb symbolizing remembrance	*There's rosemary, that's for remembrance; pray, love, remember: and there is pansies, that's for thoughts.*	"rosemary": Origin: Middle English rosmarine; earlier Old French rosmarin. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/rosemary#Etymology)
riotous (adjective)	wild; rebellious	*Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers.*	"riotous": Origin: Anglo-Norman riotous. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/riotous#Etymology)
battalions (noun)	armies; large groups	*O Gertrude, Gertrude, When sorrows come, they come not single spies, But in battalions.*	"battalions": Origin of "battalion": Middle French battaillon. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/battalion#Etymology)
columbines (noun)	flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity	*There's fennel for you, and columbines: there's rue for you; and here's some for me: we may call it herb-grace o' Sundays: O you must wear your rue with a difference.*	
ostentation (noun)	ceremony; show	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*	

Discussion questions

1. How do people show grief?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius say about sorrows? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They come in battalions.
2. What does Ophelia hand out? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Flowers
3. Who storms the castle? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes
4. What does rosemary mean? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Remembrance
5. Who calms Laertes? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius
6. What do the people cry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes shall be king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!" What does "juggled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: juggled: tricked; deceived.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Ophelia go mad? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Father's death and Hamlet's rejection.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene V" suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Laertes foils Hamlet.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the symbolism in this scene shape what we understand about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O’erbears your officers.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene V”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene V” build on “Act IV, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “How do people show grief?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On plot: Laertes demands revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Compare Laertes and Hamlet. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Laertes foils Hamlet.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position

with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene V”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene V”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene V” treats Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle ·

wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene VI" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There's _____, that's for remembrance; pray, love, remember: and there is pansies, that's for thoughts." Word bank: rosemary, cuckold, juggled, hatchment

   Key: rosemary

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who storms the castle?

   A. Laertes

   B. Horatio

   C. Hamlet

   D. Fortinbras

   Key: A (Laertes)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in…", what does "hatchment" most nearly mean?

   A. a person who attends a royal court

   B. ministers; preachers

C. uncontrolled

D. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

Key: D (a coat of arms displayed at a funeral)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does rosemary mean?

   A. Remembrance

   B. Peace

   C. Hate

   D. Love

   Key: A (Remembrance)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "To his good friends thus wide I'll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.", what does "pelican" most nearly mean?

   A. sorrow for sin

   B. idle, flirtatious play

   C. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

   D. a long-handled spear with a broad blade

   Key: C (a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a _____ head, O'erbears your officers." Word bank: cuckold, juggled, hatchment, riotous

   Key: riotous

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There's fennel for you, and _____: there's rue for you; and here's some for me: we may call it herb-grace o' Sundays: O you must wear your rue with a difference." Word bank: juggled, columbines, cuckold, hatchment

   Key: columbines

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O Gertrude, Gertrude, When sorrows come, they come not single spies, But in _____." Word bank: hatchment, juggled, cuckold, battalions

   Key: battalions

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "That drop of blood that's calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.", what does "cuckold" most nearly mean?

   A. burial cloths

   B. it seems to me

   C. imagination; a figment

   D. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   Key: D (a man whose wife is unfaithful)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Ophelia's flowers.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King)
    A. Corruption.
    B. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
    C. Claudius.
    D. Horatio's farewell.

    Key: C (Claudius.)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia)
    A. Polonius's method.
    B. The Ghost's farewell.
    C. Mood: cold and unease.
    D. Ophelia's flowers.

    Key: D (Ophelia's flowers.)

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene V”?
    A. The Ghost's revelation
    B. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return
    C. The duel and the deaths
    D. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

    Key: B (Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Claudius.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene V”? Ophelia's flowers.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Theme
    C. Metaphor
    D. Symbolism

    Key: D (Symbolism)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene V”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Laertes acts at once.

17. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Claudius say about sorrows?
    Sample answer: They come in battalions.

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, King: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in _____”
    Key: battalions

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene V, Laertes: “To hell, _____! vows, to the blackest devil”
    Key: allegiance

20. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Ophelia go mad?
    Sample answer: Father's death and Hamlet's rejection.

21. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes)
    A. Laertes.
    B. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.
    C. Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.
    D. Polonius's diagnosis.
    Key: A (Laertes.)

22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Laertes acts at once.
    A. Death and mortality
    B. Appearance and reality
    C. Action and delay
    D. Revenge and justice
    Key: D (Revenge and justice)

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes).
    Sample answer: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!”, what does “juggled” most nearly mean?
    A. wild and confused
    B. tricked; deceived
    C. an abscess; internal swelling
    D. a bird easily caught; a fool
    Key: B (tricked; deceived)

25. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Laertes.

26. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene V”? Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.
    A. Setting
    B. Alliteration
    C. Characterization
    D. Imagery
    Key: C (Characterization)

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Laertes.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."
29. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Ophelia hand out?
    A. Coins
    B. Letters
    C. Flowers
    D. Rings
    Key: C (Flowers)
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Compare Laertes and Hamlet.
    Sample answer: A judgment.
31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's flowers.
32. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the people cry?
    A. Death to Claudius
    B. Long live Hamlet
    C. Laertes shall be king
    D. Peace
    Key: C (Laertes shall be king)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	9, 2, 6, 8, 5, 17, 18, 19, 20, 13, 11, 21, 14, 22, 23, 16	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 3, 17, 24, 8, 5, 13, 20, 25, 10, 12, 26, 23, 14, 27, 28	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	1, 29, 24, 3, 7, 12, 13, 11, 10, 21, 26, 23, 22, 15, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 18, 6, 29, 21, 20, 25, 12, 11, 26, 15, 22, 23, 16, 31, 30	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 32, 1, 11, 12, 21, 20, 15, 23, 22, 26, 14, 30, 16, 28, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	1, 6, 24, 25, 12, 13, 20, 14, 15, 26, 23, 22, 27, 31, 30, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	1, 6, 13, 12, 10, 21, 23, 22, 15, 26, 14, 30, 31, 16, 28, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 8, 13, 11, 20, 10, 14, 26, 23, 15, 22, 16, 28, 31, 27, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	8, 1, 11, 12, 21, 10, 23, 22, 15, 26, 14, 30, 27, 31, 28, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	1, 6, 25, 12, 20, 13, 26, 22, 15, 23, 14, 16, 30, 31, 28, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene V,” how does Shakespeare show Ophelia's madness and

Laertes's return? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene V suggests about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene V and its treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "hatchment" most nearly mean?

   A. flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity

   B. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

   C. ceremony; show

   D. armies; large groups

2. *Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers. The rabble call him lord; And, as the world were now but to begin, Antiquity forgot, custom not known, The ratifiers and props of every word, They cry "Choose we: Laertes shall be king:" Caps, hands, and tongues, applaud it to the clouds: "Laertes shall be king, Laertes king!"*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene V"?

   A. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   C. The graveyard

   D. The plot against Hamlet

SAT key: 1. B (a coat of arms displayed at a funeral); 2. A (Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return)

Lesson 19: Act IV, Scene VI

Focus: Hamlet's letter from the sea

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act IV, Scene VI” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Teacher only · spoilers

Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.

Background: Piracy was common.

Significance: Chance returns Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What role does luck play? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: What role does luck play?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Two key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: boarded — forced their way onto (a ship); grapple — seize and hold.
Words: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship) · grapple: seize and hold

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Piracy was common. Chance returns Hamlet. Plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" slowly and put it in my own words: Horatio reads Hamlet's letter saying a pirate ship attacked them two days into the voyage. Next, craft. I notice the quick, adventurous tone of the letter. The strongest word is "pirate": it introduces chance as the force that saves Hamlet. Then, effect. What does Horatio's account reveal? My answer: Horatio's account reveals that Hamlet escaped the ship to England with the pirates' help and is returning; Hamlet's escape shows fate working for him and brings him back for the final confrontation.

> *Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" slowly and put it in my own words: Horatio reads Hamlet's letter saying a pirate ship attacked them two days into the voyage. Next, craft. I notice the quick, adventurous tone of the letter. The strongest word is "pirate": it introduces chance as the force that saves Hamlet. Then, effect. What does Horatio's account reveal? My answer: Horatio's account reveals that Hamlet escaped the ship to England with the pirates' help and is returning; Hamlet's escape shows fate working for him and brings him back for the final confrontation.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends." Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

> *They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends."
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What role does luck play? Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?
Anchor question: What role does luck play?
Facilitation: Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how plot shapes Hamlet's letter from the sea. Key takeaway: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court.
- **Structure:** The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “to me with as much speed as thou wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) The pirate attack.
- “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.
- “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence.
Evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)
Reasoning: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
boarded (verb)	forced their way onto (a ship)	*Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*	
grapple (verb)	seize and hold	*Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*	

Discussion questions

1. What role does luck play?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many days at sea? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two.
2. Who brings the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sailors
3. Who attacked Hamlet's ship? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Pirates
4. How did pirates treat Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Like thieves of mercy
5. Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: England
6. Who receives the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Horatio
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VI" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene VI", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.

9. Where and when does “Act IV, Scene VI” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.” What does “boarded” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship).

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's return important? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He comes back to complete revenge.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene VI” suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Chance returns Hamlet.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “He shall, sir, an’t please him.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VI”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VI” build on “Act IV, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act

IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What role does luck play?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is the pirate episode convincing? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Chance returns Hamlet.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VI”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet's letter from the sea. [DOK 4 ·

thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VI”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VI” treats Hamlet's letter from the sea with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene VII” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike

appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: "They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who attacked Hamlet's ship?
    A. English soldiers
    B. Norwegians
    C. Danes
    D. Pirates

    Key: D (Pirates)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio: "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike _____ gave us chase"
    Key: appointment
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I _____ them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner." Word bank: boarded, grapple
    Key: boarded
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio: "They have dealt with me like _____ of mercy"
    Key: thieves
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the _____ I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner." Word bank: grapple, boarded
    Key: grapple
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.", what does "boarded" most nearly mean?
    A. careful; watchful

B. forced their way onto (a ship)

C. flirting; trifling

D. confused; irrational

Key: B (forced their way onto (a ship))

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who receives the letter?

   A. Horatio

   B. Gertrude

   C. Laertes

   D. Claudius

   Key: A (Horatio)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.”, what does “grapple” most nearly mean?

   A. sharply cold

   B. seize and hold

   C. tricked; deceived

   D. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   Key: B (seize and hold)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go?

   A. Norway

   B. England

   C. Denmark

   D. Poland

   Key: B (England)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene VI”?

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

    Key: D (Hamlet's letter from the sea)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

    A. Gertrude's two roles.

    B. The pirate attack.

    C. Ophelia's flowers.

    D. Ophelia's fear.

Key: B (The pirate attack.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The pirate attack.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VI”? Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.

    A. Plot

    B. Imagery

    C. Metaphor

    D. Simile

    Key: A (Plot)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VI”? Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court.

    A. Imagery

    B. Alliteration

    C. Characterization

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: C (Characterization)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is the pirate episode convincing?

    Sample answer: A judgment.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who brings the letter?

    A. Sailors

    B. Rosencrantz

    C. A messenger

    D. Osric

    Key: A (Sailors)

18. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    C. The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.

    D. Ophelia's flowers.

    Key: C (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

    A. Appearance and reality

    B. Action and delay

    C. Death and mortality

    D. Revenge and justice

Key: B (Action and delay)

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio).
    Sample answer: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how action and delay develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene VI”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How did pirates treat Hamlet?
    A. Like thieves of mercy
    B. Cruelly
    C. As a slave
    D. As a king

    Key: A (Like thieves of mercy)
23. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why is Hamlet's return important?
    Sample answer: He comes back to complete revenge.
24. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio)
    A. Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
    B. Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
    C. Life versus death.
    D. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    Key: B (Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.)
25. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.
26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."
27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.
28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The pirate attack.
29. [short · recall · DOK 1] How many days at sea?
    Sample answer: Two.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	3, 6, 17, 2, 5, 8, 4, 9, 18, 13, 11, 10, 19, 20, 14, 21	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	22, 4, 8, 5, 1, 17, 18, 23, 13, 12, 24, 25, 20, 19, 26, 27	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	7, 2, 6, 3, 9, 18, 11, 10, 12, 24, 19, 20, 15, 25, 28, 26	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	22, 2, 3, 29, 24, 13, 10, 23, 18, 14, 25, 20, 15, 28, 26, 21	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 4, 8, 23, 11, 12, 18, 19, 25, 14, 20, 15, 16, 28, 26, 21	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 9, 3, 12, 10, 24, 18, 19, 25, 14, 20, 15, 26, 16, 21, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 3, 18, 23, 13, 10, 19, 20, 15, 14, 25, 16, 21, 27, 28, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	3, 4, 23, 10, 12, 13, 15, 14, 19, 25, 20, 27, 28, 16, 26, 21	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	3, 5, 10, 12, 23, 11, 25, 14, 15, 19, 20, 28, 21, 26, 27, 16	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	3, 5, 10, 12, 23, 13, 15, 25, 20, 14, 19, 21, 16, 28, 27, 26	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene VI,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet's letter from the sea? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VI, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VI (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VI suggests about Hamlet's letter from the sea. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VI to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter

from the sea. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene VI within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene VI alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet's letter from the sea follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VI and its treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet's letter from the sea in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *He shall, sir, an’t please him. There’s a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene VI”?

   A. The Mousetrap

   B. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   C. Hamlet's letter from the sea

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. C (Hamlet's letter from the sea)

Lesson 20: Act IV, Scene VII

Focus: the plot against Hamlet

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in "Act IV, Scene VII" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (suicide (implied), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Gertrude reports Ophelia's drowning; whether it was suicide is debated later. Use the safe-messaging script. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…s more violent to that end— And that he calls for drink, I'll have prepared him A chalice for t…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does Gertrude describe the death so gently?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.

Background: Fencing was an aristocratic sport.

Significance: The trap is set.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
When does revenge become crime? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: When does revenge become crime?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: conjunctive — closely united; acquittance — release; acquittal; envenom — poison; perfections — excellent qualities; challenger — one who challenges others. “conjunctive”: Origin: Latin coniunctivus (“serving to connect”). “envenom”: Origin: Old French envenimer (“to poison”).
Words: conjunctive: closely united · acquittance: release; acquittal · envenom: poison · perfections: excellent qualities · challenger: one who challenges others

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fencing was an aristocratic sport. The trap is set. Plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” slowly and put it in my own words: Laertes agrees to Claudius's plan and adds that he will poison his sword. Next, craft. I notice he goes beyond Claudius's plan, adding his own treachery. The strongest word is “anoint”: it is a holy word for applying oil, here used for poison. Then, effect. What does Laertes agree to do? My answer: Laertes agrees to kill Hamlet in a fencing match with an unblunted, poisoned sword; his grief turns him into a schemer, and the plot sets up the deaths of Hamlet, Laertes, Gertrude and Claudius.

> *I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword* (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” slowly and put it in my own words: Laertes agrees to Claudius's plan and adds that he will poison his sword. Next, craft. I notice he goes beyond Claudius's plan, adding his own treachery. The strongest word is “anoint”: it is a holy word for applying oil, here used for poison. Then, effect. What does Laertes agree to do? My answer: Laertes agrees to kill Hamlet in a fencing match with an unblunted, poisoned sword; his grief turns him into a schemer, and the plot sets up the deaths of Hamlet, Laertes, Gertrude and Claudius.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

> *To cut his throat i' the church (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: When does revenge become crime? Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.
Anchor question: When does revenge become crime?
Facilitation: Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the plot against Hamlet. Key takeaway: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.
- **Characterization:** Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.
- **Imagery:** Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “for friend, / Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, / That he which hath your noble father slain / Pursued my life” (Act IV, Scene VII, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "To cut his throat i' the church" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
- "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Laertes adds poison to the plan.
- "There is a willow grows aslant a brook" (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen) Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits.
Evidence: "There is a willow grows aslant a brook" (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen)
Reasoning: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
conjunctive (adjective)	closely united	*The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*	"conjunctive": Origin: Latin coniunctivus ("serving to connect"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/conjunctive#Etymology)
acquittance (noun)	release; acquittal	*Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.*	
envenom (verb)	poison	*Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o'er, to play with him.*	"envenom": Origin: Old French envenimer ("to poison"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/envenom#Etymology)
perfections (noun)	excellent qualities	*And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood challenger on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.*	
challenger (noun)	one who challenges others	*And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood*	

		challenger on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.	

Discussion questions

1. When does revenge become crime?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where would Laertes cut Hamlet's throat? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In the church.
2. What will Laertes's sword have? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poison on an unblunted tip
3. What is the backup plan? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A poisoned cup
4. How does Ophelia die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Drowning
5. Who reports her death? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
6. Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude and the people love him
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VII" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene VII", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene VII" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her." What does "conjunctive" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: conjunctive: closely united.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Laertes add poison? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: He bought an unction from a mountebank.
2. What does “Act IV, Scene VII” suggest about the plot against Hamlet? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The trap is set.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew’d, But yet to me they are strong.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VII”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VII” build on “Act IV, Scene VI”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “When does revenge become crime?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

10. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Laertes more honourable than Hamlet? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The trap is set.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VII”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the plot against Hamlet. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VII”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1,

RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. On plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VII” treats the plot against Hamlet with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII,

Laertes): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [short · recall · DOK 1] Where would Laertes cut Hamlet's throat?
   Sample answer: In the church.
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the backup plan?
   A. An ambush
   B. A false letter
   C. A poisoned cup
   D. A second sword
   Key: C (A poisoned cup)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She’s so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.”, what does “conjunctive” most nearly mean?
   A. closely united
   B. burial cloths
   C. boisterous; reeling
   D. necessary
   Key: A (closely united)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Queen: “There is a _____ grows aslant a brook”
   Key: willow
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who reports her death?
   A. Laertes
   B. Gertrude
   C. Horatio
   D. Claudius
   Key: B (Gertrude)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood challenger on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.”, what does “perfections” most nearly mean?
   A. prohibition; ban (on playing)
   B. excellent qualities

C. flowers symbolizing ingratitude or infidelity

D. a trap for birds

Key: B (excellent qualities)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Ophelia die?

   A. Drowning

   B. Poison

   C. Fever

   D. A fall

   Key: A (Drowning)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes: “I will do’t: / And, for that _____, I’ll anoint my sword”

   Key: purpose

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet?

   A. He forgot

   B. He liked Hamlet

   C. Gertrude and the people love him

   D. He feared Laertes

   Key: C (Gertrude and the people love him)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Ophelia's flowers.

    C. Atmosphere.

    D. Claudius flees.

    Key: A (Laertes adds poison to the plan.)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene VII”?

    A. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

    B. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    C. Claudius at prayer

    D. The plot against Hamlet

    Key: D (The plot against Hamlet)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Laertes adds poison to the plan.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.

    A. Symbolism

    B. Characterization

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Structure

    Key: B (Characterization)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how revenge and justice develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene VII”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What will Laertes's sword have?

    A. Poison on an unblunted tip

    B. Nothing special

    C. A jewel

    D. A curse

    Key: A (Poison on an unblunted tip)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “And so have I a noble father lost; A sister driven into desperate terms, Whose worth, if praises may go back again, Stood _____ on mount of all the age For her perfections: but my revenge will come.” Word bank: challenger, envenom, acquittance, conjunctive

    Key: challenger

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o’er, to play with him.”, what does “envenom” most nearly mean?

    A. curse (a mild oath)

    B. open to more than one meaning

    C. poison

    D. a long-handled spear with a broad blade

    Key: C (poison)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.

    C. Another prince who has lost a father.

    D. The plan.

    Key: B (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

21. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

    A. Death and mortality

    B. Appearance and reality

    C. Action and delay

D. Revenge and justice

Key: D (Revenge and justice)

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen).
    Sample answer: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.
24. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen)
    A. Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.
    B. Gertrude's two roles.
    C. Death levels all.
    D. Hamlet runs.

    Key: A (Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.)
25. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene VII”? Claudius and Laertes this device a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.
    A. Plot
    B. Structure
    C. Foreshadowing
    D. Personification

    Key: A (Plot)
26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
27. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes: “To cut his _____ i’ the church”
    Key: throat
28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Laertes more honourable than Hamlet?
    Sample answer: A judgment.
29. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Laertes add poison?
    Sample answer: He bought an unction from a mountebank.
30. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.”, what does “acquittance” most nearly mean?
    A. release; acquittal
    B. excellent qualities
    C. closely united
    D. poison

Key: A (release; acquittal)

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Laertes adds poison to the plan.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 8, 18, 19, 2, 4, 6, 1, 20, 13, 10, 11, 21, 14, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 9, 6, 4, 7, 3, 24, 10, 13, 12, 20, 25, 22, 14, 16, 26	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	27, 1, 18, 3, 2, 10, 24, 20, 12, 13, 25, 15, 22, 14, 16, 28	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	18, 27, 17, 19, 11, 12, 24, 10, 29, 22, 25, 14, 15, 28, 26, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 1, 8, 29, 24, 13, 12, 21, 25, 15, 14, 22, 26, 16, 23, 28	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	18, 27, 30, 13, 12, 20, 24, 15, 21, 22, 25, 14, 16, 31, 28, 23	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	18, 4, 24, 10, 13, 11, 25, 15, 21, 22, 14, 26, 31, 28, 16, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 27, 10, 24, 20, 12, 15, 14, 21, 22, 25, 23, 31, 16, 26, 28	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	27, 18, 12, 24, 11, 13, 22, 21, 14, 25, 15, 23, 28, 16, 26, 31	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	8, 18, 13, 12, 11, 10, 22, 14, 25, 21, 15, 28, 16, 31, 26, 23	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene VII," how does Shakespeare show the plot against Hamlet? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VII, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the plot against Hamlet? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual

evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VII (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VII suggests about the plot against Hamlet. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VII to complicate the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act IV, Scene VII within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the plot against Hamlet responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act IV, Scene VII alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the plot against Hamlet follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VII and its treatment of the plot against Hamlet. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as evidence for a larger claim about the plot against Hamlet in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the plot against Hamlet. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which — She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "conjunctive" most nearly mean?

   A. closely united
   B. one who challenges others
   C. excellent qualities
   D. poison

2. *O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew'd, But yet to me they are strong. The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which — She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her. The other motive, Why to a public count I might not go, Is the great love the general gender bear him; Who, dipping all his faults in their affection, Would, like the spring that turneth wood to stone, Convert his gyves to graces; so that my arrows, Too slightly timber'd for so loud a wind, Would have reverted to my bow again, And not where I had aim'd them.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VII"?

   A. The court of Denmark
   B. The Ghost's revelation
   C. Claudius at prayer
   D. The plot against Hamlet

SAT key: 1. A (closely united); 2. D (The plot against Hamlet)

Lesson 21: Act V, Scene I

Focus: the graveyard

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “Act V, Scene I” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “_Hamlet_ is singular in its kind: a tragedy of thought inspired by continual and never-satisfied meditation on human destiny and the dark perplexity of the events of this world, and calculated to call forth the very same meditation in the minds of the spectators.” (August Wilhelm Schlegel, critic and translator of Shakespeare, *Lectures on Dramatic Art and Literature (1809-11), trans. John Black, Lecture XXV, Lecture XXV*; public domain). Response journal: after Yorick, what "meditation on human destiny" does the scene call forth in you? *Objective:* Determine how the graveyard scene develops the theme of death and mortality. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.2

Content note (suicide (discussed), human remains, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Gravediggers debate whether Ophelia took her own life; skulls are handled. Use the safe-messaging script; keep focus on mortality and on how the Church and court treat her. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…day. Go, get thee to Yaughan: fetch me a stoup of liquor. Exit Second Clown. He digs and sings.…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “What does the debate over her burial show about this society?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.

Background: Suicides were denied full Christian burial.

Significance: Hamlet's view of death matures.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death mean to you? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What does death mean to you?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: outface — outdo; defy; equivocation — ambiguity; word-play; shipwright — a builder of ships; conveyances — deeds transferring property; crowner — coroner. "equivocation": Origin: Old French equivocation; earlier Late Latin aequivocus ("ambiguous"). "shipwright": Origin: an English formation from ship + wright. "conveyances": Origin of "conveyance": an English formation from convey + -ance.
Words: outface: outdo; defy · equivocation: ambiguity; word-play · shipwright: a builder of ships · conveyances: deeds transferring property · crowner: coroner

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicides were denied full Christian burial. Hamlet's view of death matures. Characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "I' faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will" (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" slowly and put it in my own words: Holding the skull of the old jester Yorick, Hamlet says he knew him. Next, craft. I notice the shift from casual talk to personal memory. The strongest word is "Yorick": it is a name, which turns an anonymous skull into a beloved person. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull show? My answer: Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull shows him facing death directly: even the jester who carried him as a child is reduced to bones, and the scene deepens Hamlet's acceptance of mortality.

> *Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" slowly and put it in my own words: Holding the skull of the old jester Yorick, Hamlet says he knew him. Next, craft. I notice the shift from casual talk to personal memory. The strongest word is "Yorick": it is a name, which turns an anonymous skull into a beloved person. Then, effect. What does Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull show? My answer: Hamlet's speech over Yorick's skull shows him facing death directly: even the jester who carried him as a child is reduced to bones, and the scene deepens Hamlet's acceptance of mortality.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

> *Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does death mean to you? Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?
Anchor question: What does death mean to you?
Facilitation: Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the graveyard. Key takeaway: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.
- **Plot:** Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “I’ faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “the point: if I drown myself wittingly, it argues an act: and an act hath three branches; it is, to act, to” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.
- “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Death levels the mighty.
- “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Hamlet's claim at the grave.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

> **Claim:** The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone.
> **Evidence:** “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)
> **Reasoning:** Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
outface (verb)	outdo; defy	*To outface me with leaping in her grave?*	
equivocation (noun)	ambiguity; word-play	*How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.*	"equivocation": Origin: Old French equivocation; earlier Late Latin aequivocus ("ambiguous"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/equivocation#Etymology)
shipwright (noun)	a builder of ships	*What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?*	"shipwright": Origin: an English formation from ship + wright. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/shipwright#Etymology)
conveyances (noun)	deeds transferring property	*The very conveyances of his lands will hardly lie in this box; and must the inheritor himself have no more, ha?*	"conveyances": Origin of "conveyance": an English formation from convey + -ance. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/conveyance#Etymology)
crowner (noun)	coroner	*I tell thee she is: and therefore make her grave straight: the crowner hath sat on her, and finds it Christian burial.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does death mean to you?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How long has the gravedigger worked? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Since the day Hamlet was born, thirty years.
2. Whose skull does Hamlet hold? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Yorick's
3. Who was Yorick? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The king's jester
4. Whose grave is being dug? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Ophelia's

5. Who leaps into the grave? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes and Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet say of Caesar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Turned to clay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To outface me with leaping in her grave?" What does "outface" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: outface: outdo; defy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does the priest limit the rites? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Her death was doubtful.
2. What does "Act V, Scene I" suggest about the graveyard? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Hamlet's view of death matures.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the graveyard? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "How absolute the knave is!", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act V, Scene I", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
7. How does "Act V, Scene I" build on "Act IV, Scene VII"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "What does death mean to you?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's grief sincere? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: "Hamlet's view of death matures." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and

evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act V, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the graveyard. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act V, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act V, Scene I” treats the graveyard with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and

universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the graveyard? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?”, what does “shipwright” most nearly mean?

   A. a builder of ships

   B. offers (of love)

   C. a thief; pickpocket

   D. a lizard once believed to live on air

   Key: A (a builder of ships)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who was Yorick?

   A. The king's jester

   B. A priest

   C. A gravedigger

   D. A soldier

   Key: A (The king's jester)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.", what does "equivocation" most nearly mean?

   A. ambiguity; word-play

   B. an abscess; internal swelling

   C. excellent qualities

   D. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   Key: A (ambiguity; word-play)

4. [short · recall · DOK 1] How long has the gravedigger worked?

   Sample answer: Since the day Hamlet was born, thirty years.

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, Hamlet: "_____ Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay"

   Key: Imperious

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say of Caesar?

   A. A hero

   B. A god

   C. A coward

   D. Turned to clay

   Key: D (Turned to clay)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "To outface me with leaping in her grave?", what does "outface" most nearly mean?

   A. outdo; defy

   B. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

   C. cloths wrapped around a baby

   D. adulterous

   Key: A (outdo; defy)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, Hamlet: "I loved Ophelia: forty _____ brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum"

   Key: thousand

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "I tell thee she is: and therefore make her grave straight: the _____ hath sat on her, and finds it Christian burial." Word bank: shipwright, equivocation, crowner, outface

   Key: crowner

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does the priest limit the rites?

    Sample answer: Her death was doubtful.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

    B. The pirate attack.

C. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

D. Gertrude's description.

Key: A (Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.)

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

A. Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.

B. Claudius's political move.

C. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

D. Appearance versus reality.

Key: C (Hamlet's claim at the grave.)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

A. Death and mortality

B. Appearance and reality

C. Revenge and justice

D. Action and delay

Key: A (Death and mortality)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet).

Sample answer: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to “Act V, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who leaps into the grave?

A. Only Horatio

B. Claudius

C. Laertes and Hamlet

D. Gertrude

Key: C (Laertes and Hamlet)

18. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene I”? The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.

A. Imagery

B. Simile

C. Characterization

D. Symbolism

Key: C (Characterization)

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain

what they suggest.

Sample answer: Hamlet's claim at the grave.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose grave is being dug?

    A. Polonius's

    B. Gertrude's

    C. Hamlet's

    D. Ophelia's

    Key: D (Ophelia's)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The very conveyances of his lands will hardly lie in this box; and must the inheritor himself have no more, ha?”, what does “conveyances” most nearly mean?

    A. deeds transferring property

    B. conflict; distress

    C. slander

    D. serviceable; useful

    Key: A (deeds transferring property)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose skull does Hamlet hold?

    A. Polonius's

    B. His father's

    C. Yorick's

    D. Caesar's

    Key: C (Yorick's)

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene I, Hamlet: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, _____”

    Key: Horatio

25. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene I”?

    A. The graveyard

    B. The court of Denmark

    C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: A (The graveyard)

26. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Death levels the mighty.

    C. Claudius confesses.

D. Hamlet's rejection.

Key: B (Death levels the mighty.)

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.

28. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Death levels the mighty.

29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Act V, Scene I"? Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Conflict
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Point of view
    Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Death levels the mighty.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's grief sincere?
    Sample answer: A judgment.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 3, 9, 5, 7, 6, 4, 1, 12, 10, 13, 11, 18, 19, 14, 20	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	21, 22, 23, 7, 8, 24, 25, 11, 12, 10, 26, 19, 14, 15, 27, 20	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	21, 7, 8, 9, 24, 26, 28, 25, 11, 13, 15, 29, 18, 14, 20, 27	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	9, 3, 24, 2, 12, 26, 28, 11, 25, 19, 14, 18, 29, 27, 30, 20	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	24, 3, 9, 26, 25, 13, 12, 18, 14, 15, 19, 29, 16, 30, 20, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	9, 2, 5, 26, 11, 13, 25, 29, 14, 18, 15, 19, 27, 16, 20, 31	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	9, 24, 11, 12, 28, 13, 15, 14, 18, 29, 19, 20, 31, 30, 16, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	9, 5, 26, 11, 12, 10, 15, 18, 19, 14, 29, 31, 16, 20, 30, 27	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	8, 9, 10, 26, 13, 28, 18, 14, 29, 19, 15, 27, 16, 20, 31, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	9, 24, 10, 12, 26, 13, 15, 19, 29, 18, 14, 16, 20, 27, 31, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act V, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show the graveyard? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the graveyard? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene I suggests about the graveyard. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act V, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act V, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the graveyard responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act V, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the graveyard follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene I and its treatment of the graveyard. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the graveyard in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the graveyard. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *To outface me with leaping in her grave?*

   As used in the text, what does the word “outface” most nearly mean?

   A. coroner

   B. outdo; defy

   C. deeds transferring property

   D. a builder of ships

2. *How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us. By the Lord, Horatio, these three years I have taken a note of it; the age is grown so picked that the toe of the peasant comes so near the heel of the courtier, he galls his kibe. How long hast thou been a grave-maker?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene I”?

   A. Claudius at prayer

   B. The graveyard

   C. The Ghost's revelation

   D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

SAT key: 1. B (outdo; defy); 2. B (The graveyard)

Lesson 22: Act V, Scene II

Focus: the duel and the deaths

Objective: Students will analyze how plot develops in “Act V, Scene II” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Critical voice: “Hamlet is, through the whole play, rather an instrument than an agent. After he has, by the stratagem of the play, convicted the King, he makes no attempt to punish him, and his death is at last effected by an incident which Hamlet has no part in producing.” (Samuel Johnson, critic and lexicographer, *Notes to Hamlet, The Plays of William Shakespeare (1765), in Preface to Shakespeare, together with selected notes on some of the plays, general note on Hamlet*; public domain). Debate: "There's a divinity that shapes our ends." Is Hamlet's passivity in V.ii defeat or acceptance? *Objective:* Evaluate Hamlet's agency in the final scene. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, RL.11-12.5

Content note (poisoning, multiple deaths, incest (period view, described), alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Four principal characters die on stage. Focus on justice and responsibility, not methods. Hamlet calls Claudius 'thou incestuous, murderous, damned Dane'. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…e to play. Ay, my good lord. Set me the stoups of wine upon that table. If Hamlet give the fir…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: The ending shows several deaths.
Suggested language: “Is the ending just?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.

Background: Royal successions were often decided by force.

Significance: The tragedy's resolution.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is the ending just? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: The ending shows several deaths.
Prompt: Is the ending just?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: disclaiming — denial; lapwing — a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head; rapiers — light slender swords; woodcock — a bird easily caught; a fool; springe — a trap for birds. “disclaiming”: Origin of “disclaim”: Anglo-Norman disclaimer.
Words: disclaiming: denial · lapwing: a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head · rapiers: light slender swords · woodcock: a bird easily caught; a fool · springe: a trap for birds

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Royal successions were often decided by force. The tragedy's resolution. Plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Aside. It is the poison’d cup: it is too late” (Act V, Scene II, King).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Horatio that a divinity shapes our ends, however roughly we plan them. Next, craft. I notice the image of a craftsman's rough cut finished by a higher hand. The strongest word is “divinity”: it names a guiding power, Providence, beyond human plans. Then, effect. What has Hamlet come to believe before the duel? My answer: Hamlet now trusts fate rather than his own schemes; his calm acceptance prepares him for the duel and his death.

> *There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will* (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” slowly and put it in my own words: Hamlet tells Horatio that a divinity shapes our ends, however roughly we plan them. Next, craft. I notice the image of a craftsman's rough cut finished by a higher hand. The strongest word is “divinity”: it names a guiding power, Providence, beyond human plans. Then, effect. What has Hamlet come to believe before the duel? My answer: Hamlet now trusts fate rather than his own schemes; his calm acceptance prepares him for the duel and his death.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

> *the readiness is all (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is the ending just? Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?
Anchor question: Is the ending just?
Facilitation: Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. ("the readiness is all", Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. ("the readiness is all", Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the duel and the deaths. Key takeaway: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
- **Structure:** Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Aside. It is the poison'd cup: it is too late" (Act V, Scene II, King).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "Aside. It is the poison'd cup: it is too late" (Act V, Scene II, King).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's new trust in providence.
- "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Acceptance before the duel.
- "The rest is silence" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Hamlet's last words.

- “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio) Horatio's farewell.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone.
Evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)
Reasoning: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
disclaiming (noun)	denial	*Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother.*	“disclaiming”: Origin of “disclaim”: Anglo-Norman disclaimer. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/disclaim#Etymology)
lapwing (noun)	a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head	*This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.*	
rapiers (noun)	light slender swords	*Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*	
woodcock (noun)	a bird easily caught; a fool	*Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.*	
springe (noun)	a trap for birds	*Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.*	
bloodily (adverb)	in a bloody way	*O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So bloodily hast struck?*	
sequent (adjective)	following	*Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was sequent Thou know'st already.*	“sequent”: Origin: Middle French sequent; earlier Old French sequent. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/sequent#Etymology)
portraiture (noun)	image; likeness	*But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The portraiture*	

		of his: I'll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion.	
changeling (noun)	substitute	*I had my father's signet in my purse, Which was the model of that Danish seal; Folded the writ up in form of the other, Subscribed it, gave't the impression, placed it safely, The changeling never known.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is the ending just?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: They were executed in England.
2. Who drinks the poisoned cup? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. How does Hamlet kill Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Poisoned sword and drink
4. Who confesses the plot? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Laertes
5. Who becomes king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fortinbras
6. What are Hamlet's last words? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The rest is silence
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.

10. Reread: “Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o’er the house, And hurt my brother.” What does “disclaiming” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: disclaiming: denial.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: To tell his story.
2. What does “Act V, Scene II” suggest about the duel and the deaths? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: The tragedy's resolution.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Why, even in that was heaven ordinant.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act V, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet…
7. How does “Act V, Scene II” build on “Act V, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever

comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is the ending just?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Who is most responsible for the deaths? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The tragedy's resolution.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act V, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the duel and the deaths. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night,

sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest" (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about "Act V, Scene II": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "The rest is silence" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's last words. On plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how "Act V, Scene II" treats the duel and the deaths with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest" (Act V, Scene II, Horatio): Horatio's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. As the final scene, does this ending resolve revenge and justice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Hamlet's new

trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "the readiness is all" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.", what does "woodcock" most nearly mean?

    A. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

    B. a bird easily caught; a fool

    C. contrary; opposed

    D. like a pig; gross

    Key: B (a bird easily caught; a fool)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who drinks the poisoned cup?

    A. Claudius

    B. Laertes

    C. Hamlet

    D. Gertrude

    Key: D (Gertrude)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So _____ hast struck?" Word bank: disclaiming, lapwing, bloodily, rapiers

    Key: bloodily

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Hamlet: "There's a _____ that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will"

    Key: divinity

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.", what does "rapiers" most nearly mean?

    A. light slender swords

    B. a builder of ships

C. sorrow for sin

D. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

Key: A (light slender swords)

6. [short · recall · DOK 1] What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?

   Sample answer: They were executed in England.

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Hamlet kill Claudius?

   A. Poisoned sword and drink

   B. A fall

   C. Strangling

   D. A pistol

   Key: A (Poisoned sword and drink)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Horatio: “Good night, sweet prince; / And _____ of angels sing thee to thy rest”

   Key: flights

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who confesses the plot?

   A. Horatio

   B. Osric

   C. Gertrude

   D. Laertes

   Key: D (Laertes)

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    B. Claudius confesses.

    C. Death levels all.

    D. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    Key: A (Hamlet's new trust in providence.)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

    A. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

    B. The duel and the deaths

    C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

    D. Fortinbras's army

    Key: B (The duel and the deaths)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Thinking prevents action.

    C. Ophelia's obedience.

    D. Hamlet's last words.

Key: D (Hamlet's last words.)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.
    A. Characterization
    B. Plot
    C. Tone / mood
    D. Metaphor
    Key: B (Plot)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.
    A. Revenge and justice
    B. Death and mortality
    C. Action and delay
    D. Appearance and reality
    Key: B (Death and mortality)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was _____ Thou know’st already.” Word bank: sequent, disclaiming, lapwing, rapiers
    Key: sequent

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Why, as a woodcock to mine own _____, Osric; I am justly kill’d with mine own treachery.” Word bank: lapwing, springe, rapiers, disclaiming
    Key: springe

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o’er the house, And hurt my brother.”, what does “disclaiming” most nearly mean?
    A. forgetfulness
    B. chattering
    C. denial
    D. a person without moral restraint
    Key: C (denial)

20. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio)
    A. The Ghost's farewell.
    B. Polonius's advice.
    C. Life versus death.

D. Horatio's farewell.

Key: D (Horatio's farewell.)

21. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live?
Sample answer: To tell his story.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet).
Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

23. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
A. Alliteration
B. Imagery
C. Point of view
D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Who is most responsible for the deaths?
Sample answer: A judgment.

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What are Hamlet's last words?
A. Farewell
B. Good night
C. The rest is silence
D. Remember me

Key: C (The rest is silence)

26. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence.

27. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)
A. Acceptance before the duel.
B. Mood: cold and unease.
C. Laertes adds poison to the plan.
D. Hamlet's reluctance.

Key: A (Acceptance before the duel.)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Hamlet's last words.

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The _____ of his: I’ll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion.” Word bank: disclaiming, portraiture,

lapwing, rapiers

Key: portraiture

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to “Act V, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	17, 18, 1, 3, 9, 7, 19, 6, 20, 12, 11, 21, 15, 22, 23, 24	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 25, 4, 9, 3, 1, 26, 10, 11, 20, 27, 22, 28, 14, 24, 16	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	29, 18, 5, 6, 9, 20, 10, 26, 21, 12, 22, 28, 15, 14, 24, 30	recall 5, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	18, 25, 29, 1, 13, 12, 11, 26, 27, 22, 15, 23, 28, 31, 32, 16	recall 4, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	18, 3, 9, 21, 13, 27, 26, 15, 14, 22, 28, 23, 24, 31, 16, 32	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	18, 17, 9, 26, 12, 11, 10, 22, 28, 14, 23, 15, 30, 32, 31, 16	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	18, 3, 21, 20, 27, 10, 15, 23, 28, 14, 22, 32, 24, 16, 31, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Junior	18, 3, 21, 27, 13, 10, 23, 28, 14, 15, 22, 24, 31, 32, 16, 30	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	8, 18, 26, 27, 11, 10, 22, 14, 28, 15, 23, 24, 31, 16, 30, 32	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	18, 3, 21, 10, 12, 26, 14, 28, 22, 23, 15, 30, 32, 16, 31, 24	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act V, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show the duel and the deaths? Write a

paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the duel and the deaths? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene II suggests about the duel and the deaths. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act V, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Act V, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the duel and the deaths responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Act V, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the duel and the deaths follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene II and its treatment of the duel and the deaths. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the duel and the deaths in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the duel and the deaths. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “rapiers” most nearly mean?

   A. image; likeness

   B. substitute

   C. following

   D. light slender swords

2. *Why, even in that was heaven ordinant. I had my father’s signet in my purse, Which was the model of that Danish seal; Folded the writ up in form of the other, Subscribed it, gave’t the impression, placed it safely, The changeling never known. Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was sequent Thou know’st already.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

   A. The duel and the deaths

   B. Fortinbras's army

   C. Worms and kings

   D. The Ghost's revelation

SAT key: 1. D (light slender swords); 2. A (The duel and the deaths)

Unit test

Hamlet: unit test · 90 minutes · 50 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, _____, and other attendants” Word bank: attendants, messengers, sailors

   Key: messengers
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “_____, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet”

   Key: Gertrude
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “attendants” most nearly mean?

   A. servants who wait on a person of rank

   B. pressed with requests; courted

   C. repay

   D. prevented beforehand

   Key: A (servants who wait on a person of rank)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “messengers” most nearly mean?

   A. accompaniment; proper ceremony

   B. power; capacity

   C. people who carry messages

   D. outdo; defy

   Key: C (people who carry messages)
5. [short · recall · DOK 1] Which characters are listed as courtiers?

   Sample answer: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Hamlet's relation to the king?

   A. Nephew

   B. Cousin

   C. Son

   D. Brother

Key: A (Nephew)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Dramatis Personae: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the _____ king”

   Key: present

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where is the play set?

   A. Denmark

   B. England

   C. Poland

   D. Norway

   Key: A (Denmark)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other _____” Word bank: sailors, messengers, attendants

   Key: attendants

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Fortinbras?

    A. An actor

    B. A gravedigger

    C. Prince of Norway

    D. A Danish courtier

    Key: C (Prince of Norway)

11. [short · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet say about the body and king?

    Sample answer: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.

12. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what replication should be made by the son of a king?”, what does “replication” most nearly mean?

    A. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang

    B. good judgment

    C. chattering

    D. a reply or answer

    Key: D (a reply or answer)

13. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who asks where the body is?

    A. Gertrude

    B. Horatio

    C. Claudius

    D. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern

    Key: D (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern)

14. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Hamlet answer?

    A. Silently

    B. In riddles

    C. With a letter

    D. Directly

    Key: B (In riddles)

15. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose favour does the sponge soak up?

    A. Polonius's

    B. Hamlet's

    C. The king's

    D. Gertrude's

    Key: C (The king's)

16. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance”

    A. Act I, Scene IV

    B. Act IV, Scene II

    C. Act III, Scene I

    D. Act II, Scene I

    Key: B (Act IV, Scene II)

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Besides, to be demanded of a sponge! what _____ should be made by the son of a king?” Word bank: replication, knavish

    Key: replication

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I am glad of it: a _____ speech sleeps in a foolish ear.” Word bank: knavish, replication

    Key: knavish

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet do at the end?

    A. Confesses

    B. Runs off

    C. Weeps

    D. Fights

    Key: B (Runs off)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.”, what does “knavish” most nearly mean?

    A. adulterous

    B. calmly; steadily

    C. villainous; sly

    D. a prostitute; here Fortune, unfaithful to all

    Key: C (villainous; sly)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.”, what does “lapwing” most nearly mean?

    A. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

    B. a border region

    C. wild and confused

    D. a mine of ore

    Key: A (a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who drinks the poisoned cup?

    A. Claudius

    B. Laertes

    C. Hamlet

    D. Gertrude

    Key: D (Gertrude)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.”, what does “rapiers” most nearly mean?

    A. light slender swords

    B. a builder of ships

    C. sorrow for sin

    D. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

    Key: A (light slender swords)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who becomes king?

    A. Osric

    B. Horatio

    C. Laertes

    D. Fortinbras

    Key: D (Fortinbras)

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Why, as a woodcock to mine own _____, Osric; I am justly kill’d with mine own treachery.” Word bank: lapwing, springe, rapiers, disclaiming

    Key: springe

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Horatio: “Good night, sweet prince; / And _____ of angels sing thee to thy rest”

    Key: flights

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who confesses the plot?

    A. Horatio

    B. Osric

    C. Gertrude

    D. Laertes

    Key: D (Laertes)

28. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What are Hamlet's last words?

    A. Farewell

    B. Good night

    C. The rest is silence

    D. Remember me

    Key: C (The rest is silence)

29. [short · recall · DOK 1] What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?

    Sample answer: They were executed in England.

30. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Dramatis Personae"?

    A. The court of Denmark

    B. The graveyard

    C. The Mousetrap

    D. The Ghost on the battlements

    Key: A (The court of Denmark)

31. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king" (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position.

32. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet" (Dramatis Personae) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles.

33. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "Fortinbras, prince of Norway" (Dramatis Personae)

    A. Resolve.

    B. The pirate attack.

    C. Another prince who has lost a father.

    D. Atmosphere.

    Key: C (Another prince who has lost a father.)

34. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Polonius's method.

    B. Appearance versus reality.

    C. Hamlet's claim at the grave.

    D. Hamlet runs.

    Key: D (Hamlet runs.)

35. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Mood: cold and unease.

    B. Gertrude on the Player Queen.

    C. Claudius's anxiety.

    D. Riddle.

    Key: D (Riddle.)

36. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge.

37. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Riddle.

38. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence.

39. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel.

40. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet sees the Ghost.

    B. Thinking prevents action.

    C. Ophelia's obedience.

    D. Hamlet's last words.

    Key: D (Hamlet's last words.)

41. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    B. Claudius confesses.

    C. Death levels all.

    D. Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").

    Key: A (Hamlet's new trust in providence.)

42. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Tone / mood

    C. Alliteration

    D. Setting

    Key: D (Setting)

43. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

    A. Revenge and justice

    B. Corruption and the state

    C. Action and delay

    D. Appearance and reality

    Key: B (Corruption and the state)

44. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? The courtiers serve the king.

    A. Corruption and the state

    B. Revenge and justice

    C. Action and delay

D. Appearance and reality

Key: A (Corruption and the state)

45. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

A. Irony

B. Point of view

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Structure

Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)

46. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

A. Characterization

B. Plot

C. Tone / mood

D. Metaphor

Key: B (Plot)

47. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet).

Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

48. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's divided position.

49. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet mad here?

Sample answer: A reasoned view.

50. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Hamlet's new trust in providence.

51. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “sailors” most nearly mean?

A. substitute

B. boisterous; reeling

C. seamen

D. not yet having feathers; immature

Key: C (seamen)

52. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet: “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s _____”

    Key: countenance

53. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz?

    A. A friend

    B. A sponge

    C. A fool

    D. A rat

    Key: B (A sponge)

54. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill’d with mine own treachery.”, what does “woodcock” most nearly mean?

    A. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

    B. a bird easily caught; a fool

    C. contrary; opposed

    D. like a pig; gross

    Key: B (a bird easily caught; a fool)

55. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Act V, Scene II, Hamlet: “There’s a _____ that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will”

    Key: divinity

56. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o’er the house, And hurt my brother.”, what does “disclaiming” most nearly mean?

    A. forgetfulness

    B. chattering

    C. denial

    D. a person without moral restraint

    Key: C (denial)

57. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers?

    Sample answer: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge.

58. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae)

    A. Ophelia's fear.

    B. Hamlet's divided position.

    C. Atmosphere.

    D. Gertrude's description.

    Key: B (Hamlet's divided position.)

59. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does the sponge image mean?

    Sample answer: Courtiers are used and discarded.

60. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    B. Claudius confesses.

    C. Rosencrantz as sponge.

    D. Claudius flees.

    Key: C (Rosencrantz as sponge.)

61. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene II”?

    A. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

    B. Hamlet hides the body

    C. Hamlet sees the Ghost

    D. Worms and kings

    Key: B (Hamlet hides the body)

62. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet)

    A. Acceptance before the duel.

    B. Mood: cold and unease.

    C. Laertes adds poison to the plan.

    D. Hamlet's reluctance.

    Key: A (Acceptance before the duel.)

63. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Another prince who has lost a father.

64. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae).

    Sample answer: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

65. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet).

    Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

66. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Hamlet runs.

67. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act IV, Scene II”? Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Setting

    C. Characterization

    D. Personification

Key: C (Characterization)

68. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in "The rest is silence" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
Sample answer: Hamlet's last words.

69. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] In this scene, which theme does the following most directly develop? Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.
A. Revenge and justice
B. Death and mortality
C. Action and delay
D. Appearance and reality

Key: B (Death and mortality)

70. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will"
A. Act IV, Scene III
B. Act V, Scene II
C. Act V, Scene I
D. Act II, Scene II

Key: B (Act V, Scene II)

71. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet" (Dramatis Personae) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Gertrude's two roles.

72. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to "Act V, Scene II". Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

73. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is king of Denmark at the start?
A. Fortinbras
B. Old Hamlet
C. Claudius
D. Polonius

Key: C (Claudius)

74. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Hamlet kill Claudius?
A. Poisoned sword and drink
B. A fall
C. Strangling
D. A pistol

Key: A (Poisoned sword and drink)

75. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Now, the next day Was our sea-fight; and what to this was _____ Thou know'st already." Word bank: sequent, disclaiming, lapwing, rapiers
Key: sequent

76. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae)

    A. Claudius flees.

    B. Gertrude's two roles.

    C. Thinking prevents action.

    D. Hamlet's new trust in providence.

    Key: B (Gertrude's two roles.)

77. [short · inference · DOK 2] Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live?

    Sample answer: To tell his story.

78. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Quote identification: in which section does this passage appear? “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king”

    A. Dramatis Personae

    B. Act III, Scene IV

    C. Act IV, Scene IV

    D. Act IV, Scene VII

    Key: A (Dramatis Personae)

79. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

80. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest?

    Sample answer: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position.

81. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene II”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the courtiers serve the king.

82. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Riddle.

83. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Dramatis Personae”? Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Structure

    C. Characterization

    D. Allusion

    Key: C (Characterization)

84. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Rosencrantz as sponge.

85. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Who is most responsible for the deaths?

    Sample answer: A judgment.

86. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
Sample answer: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

87. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “But I am very sorry, good Horatio, That to Laertes I forgot myself; For, by the image of my cause, I see The _____ of his: I’ll court his favours: But, sure, the bravery of his grief did put me Into a towering passion.” Word bank: disclaiming, portraiture, lapwing, rapiers
Key: portraiture

88. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?
A. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return
B. The duel and the deaths
C. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief
D. Fortinbras's army
Key: B (The duel and the deaths)

89. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio)
A. The Ghost's farewell.
B. Polonius's advice.
C. Life versus death.
D. Horatio's farewell.
Key: D (Horatio's farewell.)

90. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Act V, Scene II”? Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
A. Alliteration
B. Imagery
C. Point of view
D. Characterization
Key: D (Characterization)

91. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Dramatis Personae”. Use one quotation from each.
Sample answer: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

92. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: Acceptance before the duel.

93. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “O proud death, What feast is toward in thine eternal cell, That thou so many princes at a shot So _____ hast struck?” Word bank: lapwing, bloodily, rapiers, disclaiming
Key: bloodily

94. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
95. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia?
    A. Horatio's
    B. Gertrude's
    C. Claudius's
    D. Polonius's
    Key: D (Polonius's)
96. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how appearance and reality develops from an earlier scene to “Act II, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: indirection.
97. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Polonius's method.
98. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
99. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."
100. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how death and mortality develops from an earlier scene to “Act V, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.
101. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue.
    Sample answer: A reasoned reading.
102. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Ophelia's fear.
103. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how corruption and the state develops from an earlier scene to “Act IV, Scene I”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Claudius worries about public opinion.
104. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Gertrude's description.
105. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the scene: “The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

106. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Death levels the mighty.

107. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Claudius's anxiety.

108. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Is Hamlet's grief sincere?

    Sample answer: A judgment.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50	recall 29, inference 12, analysis 6, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	5, 8, 2, 1, 10, 9, 51, 4, 6, 17, 15, 18, 12, 52, 14, 19, 13, 53, 27, 26, 54, 55, 23, 21, 29, 56, 57, 33, 31, 58, 59, 60, 61, 36, 40, 62, 41, 38, 42, 63, 64, 65, 66, 67, 68, 69, 70, 71, 49, 72	recall 26, inference 12, analysis 9, synthesis 3
HS Sophomore	73, 10, 5, 51, 2, 9, 1, 12, 19, 53, 20, 15, 13, 21, 74, 55, 75, 25, 29, 33, 58, 76, 57, 31, 32, 61, 59, 36, 35, 60, 39, 77, 40, 62, 38, 43, 78, 64, 66, 65, 67, 70, 46, 69, 79, 80, 81, 82, 72, 50	recall 19, inference 16, analysis 9, synthesis 6
HS Junior	10, 4, 8, 2, 1, 5, 52, 13, 12, 53, 20, 54, 24, 23, 75, 28, 33, 76, 32, 57, 30, 31, 59, 60, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39, 41, 77, 62, 43, 83, 78, 63, 44, 66, 67, 65, 70, 46, 47, 68, 80, 71, 49, 84, 85, 86	recall 16, inference 16, analysis 12, synthesis 6
HS Senior	1, 10, 6, 51, 5, 20, 11, 53, 15, 87, 22, 27, 56, 31, 33, 58, 32, 57, 76, 34, 61, 36, 35, 60, 39, 88, 41, 89, 40, 78, 64, 43, 63, 44, 66, 67, 65, 47, 69, 46, 90, 48, 91, 79, 82, 84, 49, 92, 85, 50	recall 13, inference 16, analysis 12, synthesis 9
AP	8, 3, 9, 17, 52, 15, 24, 27, 93, 58, 30, 32, 31, 35, 61, 34, 59, 41, 40, 38, 39, 64, 42, 78, 43, 83, 63, 67, 66, 44, 65, 45, 90, 47, 46, 69, 70, 71, 91, 80, 79, 48, 82, 49, 84, 94, 72, 92, 85, 50	recall 9, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 13
College Freshman	2, 6, 95, 19, 17, 52, 29, 28, 27, 57, 31, 30, 76, 34, 36, 59, 60, 88, 40, 39, 38, 83, 63, 78, 42, 64, 43, 66, 45, 65, 44, 67, 68, 90, 46, 69, 70, 48, 80, 79, 91, 71, 84, 82, 81, 94, 92, 86, 72, 50	recall 9, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 13
College Sophomore	51, 6, 12, 52, 93, 22, 57, 32, 33, 30, 35, 61, 36, 34, 41, 62, 38, 77, 83, 63, 43, 42, 78, 64, 66, 67, 44, 45, 65, 68, 47, 46, 69, 70, 91, 79, 71, 80, 48, 96, 82, 49, 81, 84, 94, 92, 72, 86, 85, 50	recall 6, inference 12, analysis 16, synthesis 16
College Junior	1, 4, 14, 19, 25, 29, 30, 58, 57, 35, 61, 36, 40, 62, 77, 42, 78, 64, 43, 63, 83, 65, 45, 66, 67, 44, 70, 46, 47, 69, 68, 80, 48, 91, 71, 79, 97, 98, 99, 94, 84, 82, 81, 49, 100, 85, 92, 72, 86, 50	recall 6, inference 9, analysis 16, synthesis 19
College Senior		

	1, 9, 54, 30, 31, 32, 37, 35, 59, 40, 41, 89, 64, 63, 78, 83, 42, 43, 45, 65, 67, 44, 66, 70, 90, 68, 47, 69, 79, 48, 91, 71, 80, 97, 101, 102, 103, 104, 81, 82, 84, 49, 94, 105, 106, 50, 72, 86, 85, 92	recall 3, inference 9, analysis 16, synthesis 22
Graduate / PhD	9, 19, 26, 76, 33, 35, 37, 40, 41, 78, 43, 83, 63, 42, 64, 66, 67, 44, 65, 45, 68, 70, 47, 69, 90, 71, 48, 80, 91, 79, 97, 102, 96, 98, 99, 107, 103, 82, 49, 84, 81, 94, 108, 105, 100, 86, 85, 92, 72, 50	recall 3, inference 6, analysis 16, synthesis 25

Final paper

Hamlet: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Hamlet and argue how its meaning changes over the play and why that change matters to action and delay.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Hamlet. Argue whether the play judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Hamlet finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of appearance and reality. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 6 quotations from at least three sections, from the beginning, middle and end. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the act, scene and line (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Critical voice: “But what Hamlet wanted was not a private revenge, to be followed by his own imprisonment or execution; it was public justice.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture III, Lecture III, section on the "external difficulties" theory*; public domain). Careful attribution: Bradley is summarizing a view he goes on to reject (Hamlet's obstacles were external). Students who use it must say so, then decide: does V.ii give us private revenge or public justice? *Objective:* Final paper Prompt 1: trace revenge and justice and argue what the ending suggests. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.2, W.11-12.1, W.11-12.9

Critical voice: “And, in the third place, there is a trait about which doubt is impossible,--a sense in Hamlet that he is in the hands of Providence.” (A. C. Bradley, Oxford Professor of Poetry, *Shakespearean Tragedy (1904), Lecture IV, Lecture IV, on Hamlet after the voyage (Act V)*; public domain). Ending lens: is "There's a divinity that shapes our ends" (V.ii) faith or fatalism? Bradley

goes on to call it the latter; students argue for or against. *Objective:* Final paper Prompts 1 and 3: judge Hamlet's final choices and the play's ending. *Standards:* Common Core RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, W.11-12.9

Essay assignments

Essay: Revenge and justice

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about revenge and justice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and justice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and justice in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and justice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of revenge and justice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Action and delay

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about action and delay. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops action and delay in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops action and delay across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of action and delay. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of action and delay in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of action and delay, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of action and delay in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about action and delay in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on action and delay in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Appearance and reality

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about appearance and reality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of appearance and reality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of appearance and reality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of appearance and reality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of appearance and reality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Death and mortality

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about death and mortality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of death and mortality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of death and mortality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of death and mortality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of death and mortality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Corruption and the state

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about corruption and the state. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of corruption and the state. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of corruption and the state in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of corruption and the state, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of corruption and the state in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on corruption and the state in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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